version 2017-01-28

Nonong's World

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Medrano

The family name Medrano is from the Basque Country, which today overlaps Spain and France. The meaning of the surname is unclear and mysterious. One source claims

that it means "place of ferns" in that "edi" is fern and "ano" is abundance. Another source claims that it means "narrow plain." Whatever is its meaning, one generally agrees that it is a Basque name. And Basque, or Euskara, was believed to be an isolated language, unrelated to the Indo-European languages around it. Recently, in linguistic research, including those of Merritt Ruhlen, Basque would be grouped in the still controversial Dene-Caucasian language family, which would include language families or languages previously thought to be isolates. An arguable list, these linguistic entities are Basque, Caucasian, Burushaski, Sino-Tibetan, Yeniseian, and Na-Dene (an Amerindian stock).

The Indo-European language family is a gigantic family with over 3 billion speakers and encompasses several subfamilies,

including Italic, Germanic, Indo-Iranian, Celtic, Baltic, Slavic, Greek, et cetera. The Kurgan Hypothesis places the original language Proto-Indo-European, PIE, in the Pontic steppe in what is now southern Russia, near the Black Sea, in the year -4000. The speakers of PIE spread around likely on horseback throughout Europe and Asia.

The Uralic language family is a different group that includes Finnish, Estonian, Hungarian, and more. The vicinity of the Ural mountains, in western Russia, is assumed to be the original home or Urheimat, Proto-Uralic being spoken there around -7000/-2000.

It is unknown whether my Filipino ancestors inherited the name Medrano from Spanish

settlers or they adopted it according to the Claveria edict in the Philippines. The majority of native Filipinos adopted Hispanic names by decree of Governor General Narciso Claveria in 1849. Administrators created *El Catálogo Alfabético de Apellidos* or "The Book of Surnames" to systematically distribute the names. They did so in order that maintaining tax records could be easier since Filipinos initially did not have surnames and many of the earlier converts of Roman Catholicism adopted names of saints and, in turn, duplication of the same surnames were numerous then. This history is about a lineage of Medranos from the Philippines.

Incidentally, there is an old legendary Circus Medrano (or Cirque Medrano, or Circo Medrano, etc.) in Europe. Along with caravans of wagons, the circus has been circulating the continent.

Hybrids

In traditional anthropology, I and my siblings would be a multiracial mixture of Mongoloid, Caucasoid, and Australoid subspecies. Mongoloid is from Han Chinese. Caucasoid is from Spanish, Greek, Jew, and Portuguese. These ethnic groups are mainly of the Mediterranean variant of the Caucasoid subspecies, but one cannot discount the probability of the Nordic variant playing a rôle because some people in Europe moved from town to town, country to country.

We are also partly Malay—the Filipino Native. Malays are considered Southern Mongoloids. A long time ago, the Southern Mongoloids expanded into South-East Asia.

They partly replaced and partly assimilated the native Australoids. My ancestors travelled very far and wide through the aeons.

Because the Philippines is so close to Indochina, I may have had ancestors from places like Thailand, or even Vietnam. Such traces may be very ancient. In analyzing genealogy, it is important to find relations of neighbouring countries to a home country.

I may have also Mexican genes, inclusive of those of Amerindians of Mexico, because one regularly shipped across the Pacific centuries ago under the Spanish Empire. The Filipino (Tagalog) words *tatay* (father) and *nanay* (mother) are derived from Aztec (Nahuatl), a Mexican native language: *tatl* and *nantl* there.

I suspect that I may have Japanese ancestry, also. As early as the 1100's, records indicate that some Japanese have been emigrating to the Philippines. A Japanese person who either has emigrated from Japan or who is a descendant of a person who emigrated from Japan is called a nikkeijin (日系人).

Most Chinese in the Philippines speak Hokkien, which is a variant of Min Nan Chinese. Hokkien is spoken in southern Fújiàn, Táiwān, and South-East Asia. Hokkien was a likely ancestral language for my family, although as in Europe, some people in China moved about from town to town, province to province. So generationally, they might have changed from one Chinese topolect to another.

Island South-East Asia (ISEA), where the Philippines is located, is a convergence zone for many peoples during many centuries: Han Chinese, Indochinese, East Indians, Japanese, Austronesians (Malays), and later Arabs, Portuguese, and Spanish. So, there are varying probabilities of ancestry from all these ethnic groups. Sometimes, in genealogical research, one must work with just probabilities.

The Jewish part of us remains a mystery. If our Jewish ancestors were Sephardic Jews, then they probably came from the Iberian Peninsula, but if they were Ashkenazi Jews, then they probably came from Eastern Europe. Our Jewish strain were most recently traceable from Greece and there was probably mixing betwixt Jews and native Greeks. According to Max I. Dimont's book Jews, God, and History, the first Jews came

from the city of Ur in Babylonia about the year -2000. By the Greco-Roman times, scholars translated the Old Testament into Greek. They called it the Septuagint, derived from Latin *Interpretatio septuaginta virorum* (Greek, *hē metáphrasis tōn hebdomēkonta*), the "translation of the seventy interpreters." Many Greeks, as well as some people from other ethnic groups all over Europe, converted to Judaism. And so, these Greeks and others were at least some of the ancestors of the Jews who spread into other parts of Europe.

Some of my ancestors in Greece probably hailed from elsewhere in Europe. Perhaps, they were, from Spain, Sephardic Jews whose ancestry could be traced from Greece and so they came back to Greece. Perhaps, they were Ashkenazi Jews from the Ottoman Empire or Prussia or the Austro-Hungarian Empire, or

from somewhere there around Central or Eastern Europe. There might have been Slavic family influences from these areas. Also, possible influences from Germanic tribes have not been discounted.

Sephardic Jews spoke a variant of Spanish called Ladino written in Hebrew letters, whilst Ashkenazi Jews spoke a variant of German called Yiddish also written in Hebrew letters. The revival of the Hebrew language as a spoken mother language started in the late 1800's. A Jew named Dr. L.L. Zamenhof publicized his invented language Esperanto in the year 1887.

The Genographic Project's researcher Spencer Wells has done genetic studies that show that male populations of Lebanon, Palestinian territories, Syria, Malta, Spain, and other

areas colonized by ancient Phoenicians, as well as those of the Ashkenazim and other Jewish populations in Europe and elsewhere, including modern Israel, share a common m89 chromosome Y type. This m89 chromosome first emanated more than 40 000 years ago. It has been evidently a lineage marker of 90 to 95 percent of all non-Africans who migrated out of Africa and colonized the fertile lands of the Middle East and beyond.

Thousands of years ago, the original religions of the Semites were polytheistic, together with pantheons of many gods. Probably, like elsewhere on Earth at that time, they were forms of Animism. Proto-Judaism was such and consisted of Henotheism, the belief in a chief god of the tribe or family and in other gods who were not chief to them, but chief of other peoples.

Historians might argue whether my ancestors from Greece were really Greek or Jewish. If such would be contentious, then one should note that Italy was, around the year -0550, before the height of the Roman Empire, a Greek colony. The Etruscans who were there already long before, the Phoenicians who also settled, and the Greek colonists together combined to create the Italic people. Conjoined with these assimilated tribes were the original Italic peoples, including the Oscans, the Umbrians, and the dominating Latins, as well as the Celts in the north. Italy and Greece shared family lineages throughout the centuries. Italian history was really complicated, like the rest of Europe's.

Spain, colonized by Italic people, in ancient times was part of the Roman Empire, then a

vast pagan realm of many gods. The Basques and other tribes were, perhaps since the last Ice Age, already established in Spain, when those Romans came. Centuries later, the whole empire converted to Roman Catholicism, then referred to as Nicene Christianity, in the year 0380 by the Edict of Thessalonica. Much later, Spain became a land of three religions: Islam, Judaism, and Roman Catholicism. Under Islamic rule from the 8th century to the 15th century, there was religious tolerance about the Jews and Roman Catholics. So who knows? We may also have had Arab ancestors from the distant past. It was very likely. In later years of the history, after Spain reverted to Roman Catholicism, during colonization, in the vast Ibero-America and the Philippines, there were many Crypto-Jews. These people were Jews who practiced Judaism in secret. According to Claudia Roden's The Food of

Spain, recent genetic investigations have revealed that at least 20 percent of Spaniards today have Jewish ancestry.

Our Semitic ancestors, Arabs or Jews, whatever they might have been, could be traceable to faraway places like Ancient Egypt or Babylonia. Because of the fact that the Medrano family owned a circus, would Gypsies also play a rôle in the genealogy? Gypsies came from India into most parts of Europe many centuries ago. Gypsies often worked in the circus and perhaps the family hired some. Currently, without documentation, such would only be speculation.

Genetics and anthropology are complex subjects. It is probably just easier to say, using traditional anthropological

terminology, that we are Caucasoid and Mongoloid with some Australoid admixture. A little bit of Negroid from many generations or many centuries ago may be also likely. It was probable that these Negroids, desert people, came from North Africa. Or, if from more recent generations, they probably came from parts of the Hispanic Empire as Cuba, ultimately perhaps from jungle-filled West Africa. Ambiguous labels that may apply to my family are Eurasian, mestizo, or mulatto.

Ultimately, I have come to accept that I have ancestry from all 4 major human subspecies, the Caucasoid, the Mongoloid, the Negroid, and the Australoid. So, a concocted racial term for me may be "Holoid" from the Greek holos, "whole."

The categorization of subspecies into those 4

is controversial even today because some researchers believe that there may be more than 4 human subspecies, sometimes called "races." For example, it is polemic whether to include Amerindians ("Native Indians") into the Mongoloid category. Peter Brown, a researcher, claims that the origin of the Mongoloid phenotype remains unknown, and could, highly controversially, even lie in the New World. If that not impossible theory were true, it would reverse the commonly accepted Asia-to-Americas Mongoloid migration flow into Americas-to-Asia. Uneven bidirectional flow is not discounted, of course. Moreover, T. Tirado believes that, as many experts claim, East Asians and Amerindians descended from a common Proto-Mongoloid race as late as 12 000 years ago.

Dr. Akazawa Takeru opines that there are

Neo-Mongoloids and Paleo-Mongoloids. The more cold-adapted Neo-Mongoloids include Chinese, Buryats, Eskimos, and Chukchi. The more warm-adapted Paleo-Mongoloids include Burmese, Filipinos, Polynesians, Jōmon, and Amerindians. The Jōmon were people in Japan in ancient times (the years -14000/-00300). The Yayoi who came after them were Neo-Mongoloids (the years -0300/+0300). I opine that Japanese now are really a combination of Neo-Mongoloids and Paleo-Mongoloids with a slight admixture of Caucasoid. The Ainu are said to descend from the Jōmon, but there is speculation of whether they are more Caucasoid with Australoid admixture. Some Japanese know that Nagasaki and some other places were peppered with numerous Portuguese-Japanese mestizos. (The Portuguese are Caucasoids.)

There is a theory, and there is even some evidence, that Proto-Australoids arrived in the Americas, across the then existing Bering land bridge around the year -52 000, before the Mongoloids arrived. These first ancient peoples are called the Pre-Siberian American Aborigines. The Great Coastal Migration of Proto-Australoids began around South-East Asia, then traversed East Asia and North Asia into the Americas. (Before this migration, they perhaps moved out of Africa around the year -60 000 and traversed the Indian subcontinent as they attained Australia around -50 000.) The racial makeup of the Pre-Columbian Amerindians and Eskimos might have been such that besides their dominant Mongoloid heritage, they might have had already traces of Caucasoid or Australoid genes. Racial purity, even in prehistoric times, might have been already an ambiguous concept.

Researchers often agree that the Homo sapiens species is about 200 000 years old. The genus Homo itself is about 2.3 to 2.4 million years old, with the ultimate origin of Africa.

Interestingly, Douglas Futuyma believes that Mongoloids diverged 41 000 years ago from a common Caucasoid-Mongoloid group, which diverged from Negroids 110 000 years ago. The divergence of the Australoids from the Caucasoid-Mongoloid group happened around 62 000 to 75 000 years ago.

(The numbers are just estimates. Intermediate human forms existed at divergence.)

Racial purity is gradient mathematics. It is like the temperature on a thermometer or the

varying colour of litmus paper to test for alkalinity-acidity.

Southern Mongoloids ("Austronesians") are mostly Mongoloids with Australoid admixture. They are common in Island South-East Asia (ISEA) and the Pacific Islands. From anthropological findings, the home or *Urheimat* of Proto-Austronesian, PAN, around the year -4000 is supposedly Taiwan, from where islanders switched from cereal agriculture to maritime foraging and spread eventually southwards to the Philippines and to what are now the Malay areas and down to New Zealand, westwards to Madagascar near East Africa, and eastwards to Hawaii, Tahiti, and to the rest of the Pacific. Eventually, PAN diverged into the Austronesian languages such as Tagalog, Indonesian, Hawaiian, Tahitian, Samoan, Maori, and Malagasy.

East Indians are mostly Mediterranean Caucasoids with Australoid admixture. But up farther north in Jammu and Kashmir, in Himachal Pradesh, in Uttarakhand (Uttaranchal), in Orissa, in West Bengal, in Assam, and in other states, some people have Mongoloid genes. Northern India is full of Indo-European languages such as Hindi and Punjabi, but the south is full of Dravidian languages, seemingly unrelated to Indo-European. Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam (not Malay) are examples of Dravidian. The people in the south are more Australoid, more specifically Veddoid, in appearance, having blackish skin. Due to the lack of research, the grammar, time, and location of the mysterious Proto-Dravidian, the parent of all Dravidian languages, are still unknown. The prevailing dominance in northern India of Indo-European was a

result of the Aryan invasion.

Most Mexicans today are hybrids of Amerindians and Mediterranean Caucasoids. In Mexico, amongst the multitudinous Amerindian-Mediterranean mestizos are some "pure" Amerindians. Amerindians tend to look like some Malay types (Austronesians) in Asia, but look a bit different. Sometimes, they are, in fact, squinty-eyed, but not always. Some Mediterraneans carry traces of Negroid and/or Australoid genes from the long past in the Old World, and these traces were passed on to many Mexicans in the New World. The story of Mexico is similar for other Latin American countries like Peru.

In Brazil, in the year 2008, 48.43% of the population (about 92 million) described

themselves as White; 43.80% (about 83 million) as Brown (pardos, Multiracial); 6.84% (about 13 million) as Black; 0.58% (about 1.1 million) as Asian; and 0.28% (about 536 thousand) as Amerindian (indígena, Indigenous), whilst 0.07% (about 130 thousand) had no racial declaration. Whites (Caucasoids) are mostly Mediterraneans, but also include immigrant groups like Germans, who are Nordic. In Brazil, my racial category is Brown (Multiracial), or even Asian. It depends on perspective, but Brown is more accurate. In Brazil, many of those with Japanese ancestry have moved on to the Brown category due to mixing and are not counted as Asians. I may be in a similar situation.

In most of the world, blackish hair is more usual and seems to be the original hair colour of humanity. Amongst Caucasoids,

lighter hair colours, such as blond, brunette, and red, were recent mutations from well over 10 000 years ago. Very dark brown and jet-black are variations of blackish hair. Interestingly, blackish hair also can be slightly reddish (like mine), soft black, or blue-black. Amongst Europeans, the original Celts and many Southern Europeans have blackish hair. Also, in Eastern Europe, it is more common. These Europeans may be classified as Mediterranean Caucasoids, as opposed to the lighter-haired Nordic Caucasoids. The Mediterranean-Nordic dichotomy is a gradient.

Amongst Australoids of Australia, blondism occurs in some areas, especially in central Australia. The blond hair often turns brownish black as the Australoid gets older, but many do retain it through adulthood. At times, it looks reddish. I conjecture that this

phenomenon of lighter hair colour in Australia must be very ancient.

It is likely that not all my ancestors had blackish hair. As with all people, my genealogy would look really complicated if taken back many, many generations. My family looks like the convergence of humanity, which diverged into different subspecies many thousands of years back.

When I look at my bearded face and body in the mirror, I tend to think nowadays that I look like a "slanty-eyed mulatto." My mother, Belinda, and my auntie, Tita Nedy, both look like light-skinned mulattas. The ancient trade routes of the Hispanic Empire might be relevant. Maybe it was Cuba? Who knows? (A Negroid is different from an Australoid.) Filipinos are not often aware of

their genetic make-up because they do not know their genealogy fully.

Years ago, at a rustic boutique called Penelope's on Commercial Drive in Vancouver, B.C., a Hispanic man said to me obliquely, "¡Eres mulato!" (You are a mulatto!). But at that time, psychologically, I had a different racial identity.

However, when I turn my head and body at different angles, I feel that I look more Mexican than Cuban. In Spanish, "¡Soy mestizo!" (I am a mestizo!) The fact that I am quadriracial at least, being Caucasoid, Mongoloid, Negroid, and Australoid, makes me into a Kaleidoscope Man. (I am like many Latinos.)

Or, I am like a chameleon.

Maternal Ties

The Spanish Empire and Crown granted land to my great-great-grandfather, the Spaniard Captain Ramón Palacios, as a reward for his great servitude. It was in the faraway colony of the Philippines, Las Islas Filipinas. Ramón, an aristocrat, embarked from Spain to his new home sometime in the 1800's. He resided in the region of Batangas and married a Filipina, María Aguirre. They had a daughter named Concepción 'Concha' Aguirre Palacios. Concha was small in stature and a gentle señorita. She married Andrés Talambiras, a wealthy textile merchant and wholesaler of men's clothes. He was from Athens, Greece. Andrés was from a family of five children. His parents, Dimitri Talambiras and Keratsu Stamelos,

lived in Greece. It is said that the hometown was Kimi on the island of Évia in Greece.

The other brothers of my great-grandfather Andrés Talambiras relocated themselves in other lands, including Panama, so that I may have relatives in Latin America even to this day.

Before the birth of his daughter Josefa Palacios Talambiras, Andrés left for New York, USA, never to come back. His wife, Concha, remained in the Philippines. Her domineering older brother, Juan Aguirre Palacios, discouraged her from going. Juan intercepted and never gave the tickets that Andrés had sent for Concha and their two children, Josefa and Ramón. Most of the letters that Andrés had sent Concha never reached her.

Andrés remarried in America, to a Jewish woman. About his religion, hearsay proclaims him of Greek Orthodox faith, but he was really a Jew.

Meanwhile, in the Philippines, Josefa grew up under her wealthy mother's protective umbrella and became accustomed to the quiescent pace of life. Josefa studied fine arts in Holy Ghost College, a Roman Catholic institution.

Josefa married an intelligent and hard-working man, Macario Aguilera Medrano. He was a general practitioner and in his time was one of the top achievers of the medical board examinations. During World War II, he served as a medical officer for the Philippine Commonwealth Army and

participated in the Bataán Death March. In later years, he would take up acupuncture and Oriental medicine. His favourite games included betting in sabong or cock-fighting matches and playing mah-jong.

Macario's father, Pedro Medrano, was a landowner, horse-trainer, and an advisor to the barrio (village) people. Macario's mother, Florencia Aguilera, was a beautiful and complacent woman. Macario, who did not even know the names and origins of his own grandparents, likely had some Chinese ancestors, aside from Filipino ones, judging from his physical appearance.

Josefa and Macario raised four children: Belinda, Bella, Edgardo, and Alberto. Belinda was Miss Luzón of 1958 and was runner-up for Miss Philippines in the same

year. She studied Business Administration in the University of the Philippines. She became the first woman bank manager of one of the biggest banks in South-East Asia, the Far East Bank. Upon immigrating to Canada in 1976, she worked for Royal Bank until 1997, when she finally retired.

Paternal Ties

In 1898, Spain lost a war with the United States. The Philippines came under American administration. Insurrections followed. During the Filipino-American War, Captain Mariano Medrano fought under General Malvar. Malvar was the last general to surrender to the Americans. Although the general laid down his arms, the valiant Mariano continued to defy the Americans, but mysteriously he disappeared from the

scene. His son, Victorino Medrano, strove to find him for years. Fruitless in his search, he decided to settle down and marry.

On the 2nd of April of 1913, nature blessed the young couple, Victorino Medrano and Margarita Achico, with their first child, a son, named Francisco Aguirre Medrano. Victorino was at the time a busy man, working as a civil engineer for the Batangas Provincial Government in the Philippines. Margarita was only 15. It was mainly Francisco's maternal grandparents, Fernanda Venturina Achico and Alejandro Aguirre, who raised him. Alejandro's mother, Lim Dy Co, was of Chinese descent. Fernanda's father had a surname, Achico, which was probably also of Chinese origin. This surname, it is said, was originally "Chico," but inheritors later prefixed it with an "A" because a chico was coincidentally a kind of fruit in the

Filipino vernacular language.

Francisco grew to be a very active, industrious boy. In school, he excelled both academically and athletically. He cherished the classic proverb, Mens sana in corpore sano (a sound mind in a sound body). Alongside being a great orator, debater, and journalist, he was also a judo master, fencing master, marksman, amateur boxing champion, exceptional swimmer, tennis player, and even a superb painter and dancer. He also was a master of arnís de mano, a Filipino martial art. He graduated as one of the most highly acclaimed students from San Beda College of Manila.

Francisco went on to study law in the University of the Philippines in Manila. There, he fell in love with Lydia Ramos

Rillo, who was studying to be a teacher. On the 24th of September of 1934, the lovers eloped and married at the Manila Justice and Peace. The affair was without the consent of the bride's wealthy parents, Salvador Benigno Apacible Rillo and Nazaria Cudiamat Ramos. Incidentally, Tiangco and Inciong are Chinese surnames that appear in Lydia's lineage. One of her ancestors from the 1700's, Pedro Bohai, was from Portugal. Perhaps, Macau, then a Portuguese colony in China, was really a stepping-stone for Portuguese ancestors, who might even have intermarried with local Chinese.

Salvador was a collector of the Bureau of Government Internal Revenue and a heavy investor of mining stocks. He was well-educated and spoke Spanish, English, and Tagalog with equal fluency. Lydia's mother,

Nazaria, was an industrious, strong-willed woman. She was known for being an avid card game player. Salvador's father, Santiago Rillo, was a soldier. During the late 1800's, he fought amongst the revolutionary forces known as the Kátaástaásang Kágalánggalángang Katipunan (KKK) against the corrupt Spanish rulers. Chivalry ran in the family. Santiago also was one of the signers of the Malolos Constitution, promulgated on the 21st of January of 1899. That constitution laid the foundation of President Emilio Aguinaldo's short-lived independent republic betwixt Spanish rulers and the new American invaders.

After marriage, Lydia graduated and because of her extraordinary command of the English language, she soon became the proud head of the English Department of the highly reputed Batangas High School. Meanwhile, the

husband Francisco worked as a public servant in Manila. He graduated and earned a law degree in 1941. Ill-fated, he would be unable to take his bar examinations as that same year was the dawning of World War II.

The Japanese forces ransacked and occupied the Islands. They beat the American and Filipino forces at Bataán. Francisco aborted all his plans. To protect his family, he had them move about in the secluded jungles. Patriotism shot through the veins of Francisco. Gallantly, he formed an underground "guerrilla" movement with himself ranked as colonel. The Japanese declared him a wanted man.

Coincidentally, Francisco's father-in-law, Salvador, also involved himself in another resistance movement in which he also ranked

as colonel. Unfortunately, the Japanese captured him. They brutally tortured and beat him with a metal pipe. It resulted in a partial indentation of his skull. He would be held as prisoner in Fort Santiago until American Liberation.

As the war continued, the Japanese appointed a Filipino president, José P. Laurel, Sr., who entrusted Francisco as presidential aide. Tragically, the Japanese intelligence, the Kempitai, identified Francisco one day through an informant. They arrested him. They pegged him to the ground to roast under the tropical sun amongst other captives. The President reasoned with the Japanese and they fortunately spared Francisco's life.

When the Americans came for the Liberation,

fearless Francisco rejoined his brave soldiers to help annihilate the invaders. All this time, his wife and family lost contact with him and thought he was already dead. A long search by Lydia proved it otherwise.

After the hostilities, Francisco's political life persevered. He ran for governor of Batangas. He became Provincial Secretary. In 1946, he helped an old friend, Manuel Roxas, campaign for and win presidency. The new President appointed him General Manager of the National Development Company. Francisco organized the Civilian Guards to keep peace and order. Then triumphantly in 1948, he fought against the communist-led peasant uprising of the Hukbalaháp, a guerrilla movement.

In 1949 after the fatal heart attack of

President Roxas, an election was in order. Francisco became chief security officer for Former President José P. Laurel, who was campaigning for presidency against the incumbent Elpidio Quirino. Quirino succeeded in winning presidency. This event angered Francisco and he re-mobilized his guerrilla forces for an armed revolution. He stated a manifesto to the government and the Filipino people:

> "I appeal to all freedom and liberty loving people to unite and fight for the very things our forebears fought to be free from Spanish domination and for the sake of the memory of those unknown soldiers who had died in the battlefields of Bataán and Corregidor to conserve our democratic institutions for our posterity."

General Medrano's forces soon pressed from all sides and his family pursued by enemies through swamp and jungle, the situation became critical. After 45 days of fighting, General Medrano, whose followers' spirits had waned and grown weary, accepted amnesty on his own terms. They made truce with the enemy. Thus the frustrated Francisco came to the resplendent Malacañang Palace and met President Quirino personally.

After the truce, the government re-appointed General Medrano as the chief of the administrative department of the National Development Company. Years later, Francisco would successfully campaign for President García's presidency. He also became Chief of Import Central Commission, General Manager of the Manila Port Service, and Vice President of the International Ports Managers

Association. After many years of political service and sacrifice for his country, he would retire peacefully in 1963 to engage in private business which included traditional handicrafts for export. He and Lydia moved to California, USA, in the 1980's. He died on the 21st of February of 1987.

Francisco and Lydia had four children: Virginia, Mila, Frank, and Viveca. Due to the ill health of Frank's mother, his great-grandparents Fernanda Venturina Achico and Alejandro Aguirre nurtured Frank for the first three years whilst in Batangas. Wars and his father's involvement in risky politics constantly disrupted Frank's education. His mother and his sisters taught him the three R's whilst hiding in the jungles. At a tender age, he led an adventurous life and experienced the tragedies of war. He went to high school in Manila at a Roman Catholic

private school, San Beda. Frank's real ambition was to be a pilot, but under his father's guidance, he took up preparatory law. Truly, his real talents lay in music and singing. He gradually neglected his studies as he decided to go to work. Soon enough, the world of business engulfed him, occupying high positions in various companies involved in light steel, textiles, and agriculture. He was an assistant manager of the American-owned California Manufacturing, Inc., and later its marketing arm, California Sales Corporation, which he started up. He also started up Monterrey Farms, Inc., the multi-billion-peso agribusiness industry later owned by San Miguel Brewery. He was an assistant to the vice-president on finance of Synthetic Textile Manufactures, Inc., and was also the assistant general manager of Filipinas Electro-Industrial Corporation.

Frank married Belinda Medrano on the 7th of September of 1958, in an elaborate ceremony in Saint Augustine Church in Manila. In 1968, he obtained a Bachelor's degree in Commerce with Management as a major. With Belinda, he raised three children: Fernando Gerardo Medrano, Viktor Emmanuel Medrano, and Paolo Franco Medrano. The whole family immigrated to Canada and landed there on the 16th of June of 1976. A few years after their arrival, Frank and Belinda converted from the Roman Catholic faith to a Protestant faith under the guidance of Baptist Filipino expatriates.

In his earlier years in Canada, Frank would involve himself with businesses dealing with imported handicrafts and various foodstuffs.

He was U.S. sales manager for an American-owned food manufacturing company based in British Columbia. His territory was the entire West Coast of the United States and Hawaii. In his later years in Canada, preparing for his retirement, Frank would take up computer applications and supervise a laboratory for students who study English as a second language.

Frank and Belinda's son, Fernando, married Lucinda Atwood, of English ancestry, in a secular ceremony in their home on the 4th of May of 1997. In the year 1998, their daughter, Tria Josefa Lucinda Jill Atwood Medrano, was born. In the year 2000, their daughter, Calla Belinda Lydia May Atwood Medrano, was born.

Genealogical Gratitudes

In the Filipino custom of naming, the format of a full name is generally:

{first name} {middle names if any} {mother's surname} {father's surname}.

For example, the father of Belinda Talambiras Medrano is Macario Aguilera Medrano and her mother is Josefa Palacios Talambiras; Belinda got "Talambiras" from the mother and "Medrano" from the father. (Interestingly, my own full name is actually Victor Emmanuel Medrano Medrano. Nonong is my nickname.)

Due to American influence, generally Filipinos do not use accents on their names. For example, the name Concepción is written just Concepcion. By using accents, the author

tries to be traditional in this article.

"Lolo" means grandfather in Filipino. And "Lola" means grandmother. For example, "Lola Bebe" is Grandma Bebe.

Special thanks go to everyone who supplied documents and other information about the family, especially to my grandmother Lydia Medrano née Rillo and to Vivian Cruz née Talambiras (daughter of Ramón Palacios Talambiras).

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(I used here the ISO 8601 standard for dates and times.

The previous family sections started in a Web-based form in 2002, but I created a paper draft for a genealogical project in high school during the 1980's. Work on it has been on ongoing since then.

The next section on beliefs was actually started on 2012-05-05.)

Religion or Spirituality

Meandering through religions is what many people do. Some people think that they have had the same religion with which they grew up, but probably they actually changed their view of reality as they became more mature, effectively changing their religion.

Religion is a serendipitous journey. People

open doors to the unknown. They travel a spiritual river by raft. They come ashore. And they leave the raft. Some climb stony mountains. Some wander a hot desert. Some live in a spiritual jungle. Whatever it is that people do with religion, it is a serendipitous journey.

A "mishmish" is an apricot in Arabic. This article is a "mishmash" of religious and spiritual ideas.

My analysis of religion is that there are two main facets: soteriology, the study of doctrines about salvation, and eschatology, the study of doctrines about death and final destiny. My life experience has shown me about Animism, Catholicism, Protestantism, Buddhism, and something Raëlistic. Every child is an Animist at the beginning. I grew

up in a Catholic country, the Philippines, from 1966 to 1976. By high school, already in Canada, my family converted to Protestants and so they affected me. As a child in the Philippines, statues of the smiling, fat Maitreya Buddha with children around him fascinated me. When I was in Japan, from 1992 to 1994, both Buddhism and Shintō, an Animistic religion, intrigued me. As a child in the Philippines, astronomy and the probability of extraterrestrial life overjoyed me. It was like Raëlism, a UFO religion founded in 1974. Although at that time, I did not know that religions formed around UFOs.

And indeed, many people prefer to talk about a religion's soteriology and eschatology. In Buddhism, salvation is from suffering. In the many forms of Christianity, Protestant or Catholic, salvation is from sin. In

Buddhism, destiny is the waning of humanity's interest in the dharma, the teachings, so that a Buddha will arrive on Earth again to teach humanity amidst Dark Ages. In Christianity, destiny is about the Tribulation, Resurrection, and Rapture upon Jesus' Second Coming. There are essentially three kinds of viewers of Christian eschatology: those who think that it already happened in the past, those who think that it is just allegorical or idealistic, and those who think that it will happen in the future.

My allegorical view about Christian eschatology is not standard allegorical. My viewpoint is that Christian eschatology is about a macrocosmic orgasm. My observation is that Christians who cannot often achieve orgasm at their microcosmic level are attracted to the futurist view of eschatology, whereupon orgasm may be achieved

macrocosmically.

Indeed, sex should not be sliced out of religion. To psychologists of the Freudian background, everything a human does has something to do with sex. So, sex should be an inherent facet of any religion. Whether one feels guilt and shame about sex, or whether one has a neutral, liberal, natural feeling about it, depends on religious background. A human has genitals. Sexuality affects religion. Religion affects sexuality.

By 1930, Olaf Stapledon had written the book *Last and First Men*, in which he expounds the hypothetically long roller-coaster history of two billion (10^9) years of future human evolution, of 18 species of humans in sequence, we *Homo sapiens* being

the first. The number 18 is significant because after two billion years of numerous ups and downs, humanity is still a teenager. (This story is popular now in Japan, where a Japanese translation is available.)
Eschatology can be radically different.

Some religious people are not too interested in soteriology and eschatology, but prefer the rituals of their religion. They may enjoy their prayers, or their meditations. They may enjoy the architecture of their church, or their temple. They may enjoy being with other spiritual people. They may like the music. They may like the liturgical language. They may enjoy the art.

Religious art can be tragic. The Nazism in Germany during World War II was a form of sadomasochistic religion. The Nazi flag's

Swastika was reminiscent of a symbol from Hinduism, a religion with caste. The killing of Jews was a perverse form of martyr adoration. Some Germans thought that every Jew was Jesus Christ by metaphor.

Although I do have Semitic heritage, which is a family including not only Jews, but Arabs, Akkadians, etc., I maintain that Judaism, because they have had many converts of people from other races, is not a race in itself, but just a religion. One does not say that one is of the Catholic race. To refer to Jewishness as a race is an error, in my opinion. It is similar to the term Hispanic, which may encompass different races, the Spanish language holding them all together. A Jew is not a Buddhist. A Buddhist is not a Jew. People get confused in the West because they have a Jew-Gentile dichotomy. (The Semitic languages are a

branch of the Afroasiatic language family, which also includes the branches Berber, Chadic, Cushitic, Egyptian, and Omotic.)

Christianity affects the whole world. Modernization or Westernization often includes some aspect of Christianity. So, even places like Japan, China, India, etc. experience this phenomenon. People in pagan countries cannot often sift out what is Christian from the modernization process.

Perhaps, "pagan" is still a good term. Paganism is from the Latin paganus, meaning "country dweller" or "rustic." It is an umbrella term, often used to refer to many different non-Abrahamic, indigenous polytheistic religious traditions.

Some religions describe alternate worlds from

our own. Catholics, besides this Earth, proclaim that Heaven, Purgatory, and Hell exist. Christians argue whether these places are allegorical or physical. (Indeed, on the densely cloudy desert planet Venus, the surface temperature hovers over 450 degrees Celsius and it rains sulfuric acid.) Buddhists and Hindus alike believe in many different worlds from our own and in each, there may be sentient beings of various divine expression. The term worlds may be too ambiguous. In the 19th century, one might have used dimensions. But today, the same concept may be rendered as universes. Maybe confusingly, the worlds described may be inside our own universe. Where would these places be? We humans are on Earth. We do not know if on a different moon or planet the psychic environment would be dissimilar or not as affected by fields or forces unknown to us today.

Buddhists and Hindus alike believe in a "layered cake model" of several Heavens, intermediate worlds, and Hells. According to one's good or bad karma, actions, one would go up or down the layers.

In A.C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupāda's own commentaries about the Bhagavad-Gītā, the Hindu sacred book, he uses the word "planets" to describe places like Vaikuṇṭha, the heavenly abode of Vishnu. It is common practice now to use the term "planets" when celestial places are described in Hinduism. It seems wise to use a frame of reference that is not so fantastical and is based on current verifiable knowledge. Such are things that people do know really exist. The universe is grand enough in reality to accommodate what people think would be imaginative.

Often, fact is stranger than fiction.

Our human civilization has about 5000 years of literate history. If one imagines that some other sentient beings may have millions or billions of years of literate history, then humanity would be powerless against such a force. These beings from other worlds may have stealth capability, so that they cannot be detected upon entering human territory. They may be called angels, devas, or whatever. The Urantia Book tells about zillions such beings.

Indeed, to an alien visitor far advanced from the human level of civilization and development, the whole Earth may seem like the space version of Papua New Guinea, a primitive islander place. To some other aliens, we humans may be threatening like

wild wolves or crop-eating slugs. It depends really on the differential of civilized level. Tuesday Lobsang Rampa, a writer about the paranormal and ufology, expounds in his books about the "Gardeners," esoteric custodians of the Earth as they plant as "crops" different species of people and sometimes they have to "weed." And Earth is not their only "cropland."

Indeed, in professional circles of astrobiology, the Theory of Panspermia is hotly debated. It postulates that space objects like comets carry biotic substances that land and infect zillions of planets and moons. So, the universe could be full of life. It is either that postulation or life in the universe is extremely rare, as it develops independently on each biotic world. Or, one could conjecture the Middle Way: Life density would be somewhere in the middle of jungle

and desert. On our own war-torn world, indeed it is our true hope that life existence elsewhere in the universe is highly probable.

Christians are afraid of fire because of their notions of Hell. Zoroastrianism, the ancient pre-Islamic religion of Persia, postulates that sacred fire purifies the soul. Zoroastrians' temples are decorated with ongoing fires, about which they chant sacred words. Their prophet is Zarathustra, or Zoroaster. They believe in the dualism of Good and Evil. The world is a battleground. The destructive force Angra Mainyu counters the creative force Spenta Mainyu. "Good thoughts, good words, good deeds" is the triple motto of Zoroastrianism. The Avesta is the Zoroastrians' main Scripture, in the Avestan language.

Syncretism is a tendency in religions. In 1875, in New York City, the Theosophical Society was founded to foster universal fraternity, religious comparisons, and paranormality. Their approach to all religious creeds was syncretic. In 1844, in Persia, the Bahá'í Faith began, which syncretized existing religions. Adherents have fostered the belief in a universal language, whatever it may be.

Over more recent years, in the early 21st century, a colour scheme has surfaced reflecting belief systems. White, it seems, has become Buddhism with its expectations of the Four Noble Truths. Black, it seems, has come to represent something like Secular Humanism or scientific enquiry, being free of fixed doctrines, the universe being always a dark mystery.

Other colours have surfaced. Blue, the colour of the artificial language Interlingua, becomes linked to Catholicism and sometimes Capitalism. Green, the colour of the artificial language Esperanto, is congruent to white, and therefore, to Buddhism. The conspicuous colour purple, often congruent with black, represents the artificial language Lojban. Yellow are the forms of Chinese languages and Daoism, an Animistic religion. Grey is generic Animism and Amerindian cultures and languages. Red is Japanese, Animistic Shintō, and sometimes Communism. Brown is often Spanish, an alternative rendering of blue, which may encompass all Latinate languages. Pink is often English, especially its effeminate side. Orange is the colour of the artificial language Vling, as well as the fantasy of Romanized Oriental languages or Oriental languages

with other phonographic writing. Of course, these colours vary in meaning, but a colorology has developed indeed.

Tagalog, it seems odd, is often black, sometimes turquoise. Tagalog being black is not in accordance with Secular Humanism, but with Africanism, Primitivism. Black seems very multivalent. Everyone is a kind of slave, in some respect. The human body is like a prison of biology. Not everybody likes his or her work. People expect reward, but do not get any. Everybody feels suppression. Everybody is locked between birth and death. Everyone is a kind of slave...

Tagalog may be black because nobody can explain the mystery of its global xenoglossia. There may be a Secular Humanist explanation, some people are hoping. I often

use turquoise for Tagalog because it is a language from a country of many islands and seas.

The colours may be arranged as in optical physics: ROYGBIV; red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, and violet. The human eyes cannot see beyond this visible spectrum. Beyond red is infrared. Beyond violet is ultraviolet. Some animals can see colours that humans cannot.

A belief system involving colours has evolved with taciturn aspects. A numerology has evolved with it, but numbers do not agree with many women. Numbers are more benumbing. Colours and numbers seem to be a collective religious experience.

Some religions forgo asceticism, monasticism,

and the like. These religions do not give people an alternative to family living, which arguably is inherently more materialistic and worldly. Living as a monk in a monastery or a nun in a nunnery is just as or even more fulfilling than family life, in my opinion. In China, monastic religions have been suppressed because their government seduces their people to family life combined with Secular Humanism. Yes, in some places of the world, spirituality is wilting.

In Jainism, a religion in India, one of the two main sects is interestingly called Digambara, "Sky-clad." Their monks, as a form of asceticism, wear no clothes. So, one could see them in some towns in India as they walk around nude. In India, spirituality is still thriving.

Nevertheless, Secular Humanism is spreading around the world. It assumes that humans are neither inherently evil nor innately good, and they are not above nature, not superior to it. In the beginning, around the 1930's or 1940's, Secular Humanism represented Christian values without Christian faith. By the 1960's and 1970's, the term "Secular Humanism" was embraced by people who were anti-religious. The philosophy postulates that humans are capable of being ethical and moral without religion or God. Secular Humanists reject superstitions. It seems that China promotes this philosophy.

The Soviet Union was a so-called Communist state for seven decades. Perhaps, it was a misnomer. A better categorization might

have been Authoritarian State Capitalism. In those many years before its fall, religion was tightly suppressed in favour of so-called Scientific Atheism, which was essentially Secular Humanism. But this forced secularization failed in the end. After the fall, only about 5% remained atheist and religiosity came back with a vengeance.

In China, religious repression continues. Anything like a religious movement such as Falun Gong or Esperanto has become targets. But as in the Soviet Union, forced secularization may fail in China in the end.

Buddhism is a kind of stealth religion that spreads over people without them knowing it. It happened to me as a child when I was seeing smiling, fat Maitreya Buddha statues. By the symbols, I have come to know

Buddhism intuitively. Buddhism began in what is today Nepal or Northern India. He was Siddharta Gautama, the historical Buddha, who is different from Maitreya Buddha, the Buddha of the future. Amitābha Buddha is another different Buddha, the Buddha of the Pure Land. In Buddhism, anyone may have the potential to become a Buddha.

Buddhism focuses on the Four Noble Truths. One, in life, suffering, discomfort, uneasiness, anxiety, and the like exist (Pāli dukkha, Sanskrit duḥkha). Two, the cause of dukkha is craving, desire, and the like. Three, there may be an end to dukkha. Four, there may be a method to end dukkha. So, a helpful acronym is ECEM.

The Buddhist way to end dukkha is The

Eightfold Path. They are the correct view, the correct intention, the correct speech, the correct action, the correct livelihood, the correct effort, the correct awareness, and the correct meditation. Intuitively, I just remember that there are 8 of them that are correct.

There are thirsts or hungers that trouble people. Buddhists are aware that people seek pleasure, people seek to become something else, or people seek to be nothing.

Buddists practice The Middle Way. Moderation in everything is the key. Excess leads to abuse and the like.

Buddhists have The Three Marks of Existence. One, there is always impermanence in everything. Two, there is

dukkha, often translated roughly as suffering. Three, there is the Not-self. So, a useful acronym is ISN. The Not-self is that one's self is seen as merely an illusion. There is no real soul, but a stream of constantly changing consciousness. Although impermanence is a condition in existence, Buddhists do believe in durability as Japanese attest in craftsmanship.

A key concept in Buddhism is Emptiness. As the new Physics would tell me, everything is really intangible. Nothing exists substantially. Everything is made up of waves or particles, depending on how I look, in mostly empty space.

The goal of a Buddhist is Nirvāṇa (Sanskrit; Pāli Nibbāna). It is the extinction of craving, ignorance, and therefore dukkha,

and freedom from the spirals of involuntary rebirths (in Sanskrit and Pāli, Saṃsāra).

Many Buddhists depend on sacred writings. In the Mahāyāna ("Great Vehicle") branch, adherents depend on Sanskrit texts. In the Theravada ("Ancient Teaching") branch, adherents depend on Pāli texts, which are the Tipiṭaka, "The Three Baskets."

I learnt Pāli chanting at Wat Yanviriya, a Thai Buddhist temple converted from a Christian church, in East Vancouver. There, I indulged in socializing with a Sangha, a multiethnic Buddhist community. It was Theravada.

Zen Buddhism is a sect that steers away from words. It is non-logocentric. It is the sect most famous in the West. Zen is a sect that

was impacted by the paradigm of simplicity of Daoism, centuries ago.

In all Buddhist sects, and there are many, meditation is important. It promotes mental stability. Many Buddhists really focus on it. At Wat Yanviriya, I learnt different methods of meditation. One way is to repeat a seed word in the mind whilst breathing in rhythm. Another is to let the mind just wander. One can be walking back and forth, maybe on hardwood floors such as at Wat Yanviriya, or outside in the garden. Or, one can sit in a yogic pose, or some pose that is comfortable, on the floor with a mat, or even on a chair. Meditation can be as short as 5 minutes or it can last more than 30 minutes.

The seed word can be anything that sounds comfortable. Maybe "Aum" or "Om" is one to

try. It can be in any language. One time, I tried "tcati" meaning "tea" in Lojban. One can do counting, also, with numbers. Or, one can go through the Greek alphabet, from Alpha to Omega.

There are other methods of meditation. One can focus on an object. Maybe a precious stone is one to try. Even a plant is useful. Meditation can be done whilst at work, maybe when that work is repetitious, then it is an opportunity. Playing music is meditation. Doing laps in a swimming pool is another. Hiking up a nature trail is a possibility.

Reliance on oneself is a strategy in Buddhism. One cannot really rely on others. Most Buddhists do not pray to a god. But Pure Land Sect Buddhists chant Amitābha

Buddha's name, so that they may end up in the Pure Land to achieve Enlightenment easier there. Buddhists may believe in devas, divine beings of different kinds. Buddhists believe that there are other sentient beings who are not human.

In Theravada Buddhism, an arhat (Sanskrit; Pāli arahant) is someone who has reached Enlightenment and will not wait for others to attain it, which is the difference with Mahāyāna Buddhism's bodhisattva (Sanskrit; Pāli bodhisatta), who also has attained Enlightenment, but through compassion will wait for others to do the same. These beings are on their way to Buddhahood.

Guānyīn is a famous Chinese bodhisattva who is a woman in China, but a man in India, where he is known as Sanskrit

Avalokiteśvara. Guānyīn is the equivalent of the Virgin Mary in Buddhism. (Maybe, it is the same being. Who knows?) Guānyīn is the Goddess of Mercy.

Some people mix Buddhism with other belief systems. In Thailand and Japan, people mix it with local Animism. In the Philippines, some people have bilateral altars with the Christ Child (Spanish Santo Niño) on one side and Buddha on the other.

Besides reading sacred texts, in their translation or in the original language, a good source about Buddhism is the Buddhist Dictionary by Nyānatiloka Mahāthera, who was born on the 19th of February of 1878 in Wiesbaden, Germany and died on the 28th of May of 1957 in Colombo, Ceylon. His birth name was Anton Walther Florus Gueth. He

became one of the earliest Westerners in modern times to become a Bhikkhu, a fully ordained Buddhist monk.

Anātman (Sanskrit; Pāli Anattā) is the essential Not-self in Buddhism. Japanese and Thais try to reconcile their Buddhist beliefs with Animistic beliefs of having multiple souls or spirits. Somehow, they do manage to do it, and they have no religious conflict. Buddhists believe in the perpetually transforming fluidity of consciousness.

Religion with the prominence of a liturgical language is increasingly in demand. These days, the liturgical languages may be Lojban, Esperanto, and Interlingua. At different degrees, I know all these liturgical languages. They are all very amusingly spiritual. Some

languages are playful. Some languages are prayerful. Some languages are laborious. Language may be spirituality.

I am a believer in the Japanese concept of *kotodama* or "sacred sound" or "word magic." The Japanese believe that a language that has good *kotodama* is a language that sounds like Italian. I have hesitations about my own language creation Vling because words there sound like "a big dog in a bog." Vling is a cat language in reality. I have thought of it as Asia's counterpoint and response to Esperanto. The colour orange is often its cue. Maybe, Tagalog does have good *kotodama*. Stressed and unstressed syllables there may alternate between [i] and [ɪ] respectively and between [u] and [ʊ] respectively, the language becoming reminiscent of an Australian Aboriginal language. The grapheme <a> in Tagalog represents a sound that is slightly

raised from the "continental" [a] as it approaches the English "uh" sound [ʌ]. Spiritually, it scares some that Tagalog sounds Animistic.

Indeed, the true Eskimos are Animistic. The Animistic Eskimos believe that names have souls. So, a person with several names have several different souls. The Eskimos, or Inuit, are famous for their wild sculptures scattered in the vast Arctic tundra. Their most ubiquitous is the inuksuq (plural inuksuit), which is "that which acts in the capacity of a person," a form of communication in the cold desert when no real people can be seen around the vastness. It tells where is good fishing or game, etc. It looks like a pile of rocks, bones, lichen, etc. Similar to the inuqsuq, but in the "similar shape of a person" is the more famous innunguaq

(plural innunguaiA). It could look like a rocky man standing with arms stretched out. The inuksuapik is what is considered the most beautiful of the inuqsuq. Meanwhile, the inuksullarik is a very important and very ancient inuqsuq, constructed by their long-ago ancestors the Tunniit.

The Australian Aborigines are Animistic. They live in the vast, empty, hot desert Down Under. The Dreamtime is the sacred era when ancestral totemic spirit beings created the world. The Aborigines are full of their mysterious stories. The Dreaming may refer to a tribe's set of spiritual beliefs or to the Creation Time itself. There are the Kangaroo Dreaming, the Shark Dreaming, and so on. The Amerindians of the Americas are similarly full of Animistic beliefs.

Daoism, an Animistic religion, engenders strange paradoxes. There is strength in weakness. There is hardness in softness. And there are more of the like. Bending with the wind as the tall grasses in a vast field is the paradigm of the passivity doctrine of Daoism. (There is a Fire School which does promote being more active.) Being simple like a driftwood is another doctrine. Returning to one's origin, the pilgrimage to the Mecca of one's self, is another. The home garden is a microcosm of everything there is, the macrocosm. Daoism has scripture, mainly the Dàodéjīng, but there are others. The origin of Daoism is unknown. Probably, it evolved out of wild tribes from Central Asia or thereabouts. Yellow often is its cue.

Daoism's prescribed sexual behaviour is to

withhold ejaculation of sperm. This prescription affects the entire psyche of Chinese life. It leads to self-suppression, the withholding of expression. Their communication is a silhouette of reality. It seems an antithesis of Western culture.

Yīnyáng is an important doctrine in Daoism. It is the interconnected, interdependent polar opposites in nature. It is the dark and the light. The other cannot exist without the other. There is unity in duality. The idea of Fēngshuǐ is wind-water, the geomancy involving Yīnyáng. It tells one where is a good place to drink tea or coffee, where is a good place to take a stroll, what colour carpet is good for the house, and so on.

Daoists believe that a person has multiple souls. There may be the figurative 36 000

divine beings (shén) living microcosmically in the body as a reflection of the macrocosm. Some Daoists believe that at conception, there are 3 Yáng souls, who meet with 7 Yīn souls at the person's birth. The harmony of these souls reflect one's health. Stray demonic Yīn souls are called Guǐ.

Chinese tradition essentially views black, red, blue-green, white and yellow as standard colours, corresponding to the five elements of water, fire, wood, metal and earth, dictated in traditional Chinese physics or alchemy. Daoists have been looking for the Elixir of Life because they believe in physical immortality here in this world. Probably, in ancient times, the life of Chinese aristocrats was so good that they thought that life was worth living forever.

The treatment of knowledge in Daoism is paradoxical, yet again. In the Dàodéjīng as translated by Gia-Fu Feng and Jane English, Chapter 18 says, "[...] When wisdom and intelligence are born, the great pretense begins. [...]" Chapter 47 says, "[...] Thus the sage knows without travelling; he sees without looking; he works without doing. [...]" Chapter 58 says, "[...] Who knows what the future holds? There is no honesty. Honesty becomes dishonest. [...]" Chapter 71 says, "Knowing ignorance is strength. Ignoring knowledge is sickness. [...]" Then Chapter 81 says, "[...] Those who know are not learned. Those learned do not know. [...]"

Strangely, the Chinese written language is anti-Daoistic because it is too complicated. If it were all Romanized as in Pīnyīn, it would be more Daoistic. Simplicity is an

emphasized concept in Daoism.

Shintō is Japan's indigenous spirituality. Red is its cue. Adherents believe in ichirei shikon, "one spirit, four souls." The person as a hand may be a metaphor. Destiny after ordinary life may be the eternal land beyond the ocean, or the astral world, or the underworld, or the mountains whereupon one could look over and watch over one's descendants. The torii is an entrance to the spirit world. The torii looks like a gate. In some Shintō ceremonies, the sex act is mimicked in public. In Shintō, a large wooden phallus may be carried during a festival. People run around practically nude. Cleanliness being next to godliness is a doctrine there.

There are other Animistic traditions. There

is Santeria in the Caribbean and Latin America. It is a syncretic religion combining African beliefs and Catholicism. Haitian Voodoo is something similar. Wicca is Animism in Europe. There is Bon in Tibet. The Eskimos and the Amerindians and the Pacific Islanders, of course, were Animistic before much Westernization. All primordial peoples around the world were Animistic. But today, there is still Animism.

Animists believe that throughout Nature, spirits abound, in the plants, in the animals, in the rivers, in the mountains, in the rocks, in people, in the sky, and so forth. There are continuous interactions between these spirits. The spirits may be good or evil, or anything in the middle.

One's concept of self is always in question in

spirituality. Is one always part of a group? Can one exist uniquely, individually, like a unicorn without expectations from a group? Is religion a collective experience? As a unicorn, I am free of responsibility and burden of ethnicity. In a pluralistic society as here on Lulu Island, being a unicorn is possible. Not everyone is special enough to be a unicorn, but one never knows the limits.

The Chinese have some kind of cult mentality concerning the individual in a collective. They think that no one is really unique in a group. They superimpose one personality over another, and judge that people are really dispensable. It is what people think and do in a cult-like organization, but in this case, it affects the over-a-billion tribe of the Chinese. In Japan, tinting hair a different colour from the usual jet black is a sign of rebellion from

the norm. Individuality helps creativity.

Circumcision is sometimes a religious question. Is every circumcised man a Jew? Maybe, they are not necessarily Jews. In my French book *Histoire de la circoncision* by Malek Chebel, I have discovered that some Muslims are indeed circumcised, like some in Indonesia and the Middle East. I know that most men from my native, mostly Catholic Philippines are circumcised. The rate in Europe and Latin America is much less. In North America, it is higher. An astounding fact is that in Aboriginal Australia, the men, as well as the women, are circumcised. Since the Korean War, circumcision has reportedly become popular in Korea. The debate about circumcision continues. Some estimates are that a quarter or a third of all men in the world are circumcised.

Some theologists believe that Christian Baptism may substitute for circumcision. Judaism obliges boys to undergo physical circumcision. This argument is like the Eucharist where the bread is arguably either the actual or the symbolic body of Christ.

The theme of sacred writings is polemic in Christianity. Some denominations focus more on the New Testament, whilst others focus more on the Old Testament. The Catholics maintain that many things about the Church are extrabiblical, not mentioned in the Bible. The basis of the Old Testament is the rearrangement of the Jewish Torah (Pentateuch), Prophets (History), and Writings (Wisdom), three collections of Jewish sacred writings which also include the encyclopedic, non-Christian Talmud, in

which the debate-filled Mishnah and the Jerusalem (or Palestinian) Talmud and the Babylonian Talmud are integral. Before the 4th century, early Christians were following various different books. The New Testament canon was not yet standardized. By the 4th century, the contents of the New Testament became more established.

There were many kinds of early Christians. Some sects never made it to the present time. One of them was the Ebionites, from the Hebrew ebyonim for poor. They revered Jesus' supposed brother James the Just, but rejected the missionary Paul of Tarsus. They believed that Mary was not a virgin and that Jesus was adopted by God. The Ebionites were vegetarians. There were many other extinct sects of Christianity. At that time, the distinction between Jews and Christians was not really clear-cut.

Another sect that is extinct today is the Marcionites. Marcion of Sinope (circa 85-160 CE) wrote books that did not survive to the present day; one book that he wrote was The Antitheses. Unlike the Ebionites who still followed Jewish Law and thought that Jesus was human, not God, the Marcionites rejected Jewish Law and thought that Jesus was God, not human. The Marcionites believed that there were 2 gods, the Creator God of the Jews and the God of Jesus. Jesus was the God of mercy and love; he was to save people from the wrathful Creator God. Docetism is the term used for thinking that Jesus was a phantasm that appeared human. Marcionites believed that Jesus was not born into this world. Their canon was something like the New Testament, but more compact, and phrases that Marcion thought were scribes' earlier modifications had been

elided.

In Europe, Cathari were a sect at odds with the Catholic Church during the 11th to 13th centuries. They believed in 2 gods, the evil Creator God Rex Mundi and Jesus. Like Marcionites in the 2nd and 3rd centuries, Cathari in the Middle Ages were dualistic. It is unclear whether Catharism was a continuation of Marcionite thinking.

The Hindu's Vedas are probably more ancient than the Bible. The discussions are comprehensive. There is a theme on the primordial existence when there would be neither death nor immortality. There is a point about knowing the truth, not trusting or loving or any of that sort. This knowing is not merely intellectual. The Bhagavad-Gītā is a Hindu sacred book, which I have read.

It seems really deeper than the Bible, in my opinion. It talks about other worlds. My favourite commentaries are A.C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupāda's.

The Mormons believe in a Third Testament, The Book of Mormon, first published in 1830 by Joseph Smith, in like Early Modern English of the King James Version of the Bible. The text, Mormons claim, contains writings of prophets who lived in the Americas about 1500 to 4000 years ago. The text was said to have been revealed on golden plates in an original language called "reformed Egyptian." Historical authenticity is challenged, but nevertheless, its dubious authorship is seen as divine inspiration. The Mormons believe in polygamy. They encourage the study of extensive genealogies, so that people know their place in family. Subliminally, Mormons believe in the

limitations of human intelligence. Religion is from the creative side of the brain. This sect is otherwise called The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. Their door-to-door promoters are often handsome men in suit attire.

Jehovah's Witnesses are another famous sect of Christianity. They disbelieve in the Trinity. They distinguish between god with a small g and God with a big G. They believe that there will be paradise on Earth in transformation into something like the Garden of Eden, after Armageddon and Resurrection. At the end of a thousand years, Satan will be released to mislead perfect humanity as a final distillatory test. Jehovah's Witnesses win adherents because of their fascinating eschatology.

Like Christianity and Judaism, Islam is a so-called Abrahamic religion. Muslims, as Islamic people are called, repudiate Christianity's Trinity which alludes to polytheism. Islam is strictly monotheistic as they believe that there is only One God, Allāh. Their sacred writings are in the Qur'an, divided into 114 suras, containing 6236 āyāt, verses. Muslims believe that the Qur'an is only perfect in the original Arabic because any translation would be deficient. Their main prophet is Muhammad, the messenger. Muslim eschatology includes bodily resurrection at the Day of Resurrection, Yawm al-Qiyāmah, when everyone will be judged for good or bad deeds. Trials and tribulation precede and coincide with al-Qiyāmah, the time of which no human knows. (I read somewhere too that in Islam, being in hell may be an impermanent condition.) Like other

Abrahamicists, Muslims believe in angels. Muslims believe in predestination or divine preordainment. Muslims must pray 5 times during the day. The prayer rituals are called Ṣalāh. Like other religions, Islam has subdivisions, as the Sunni and Shia, the contention being the successor, Abu Bakr or Ali respectively, to Muhammad. (The Islamic religion's progression and overall ambiance are depicted in Frank Herbert's Dune series, which is set thousands of years from now in outer space. There is a desert planet called Arrakis.)

Sufism is the inner, mystical dimension of Islam. Practitioners are called ṣūfī. Scholars judge that Sufism cannot be learnt from books, but rather can be learnt as a disciple of a qualified teacher.

Gnosticism was a religious movement older than Christianity. There were both types of Christian and non-Christian Gnosticism because there was syncretism, or mixing. They believed that humans were trapped in their bodies and in this evil material world that was created by a cosmic disaster, by a malevolent deity who was not Christ. Christian Gnostics believed that Christ was one of the aeons or divine beings from the Pleroma, the Divine Realm, as described in the Apocryphon of John, part of the Nag Hammadi Library of Gnostic literature. Salvation was by esoteric knowledge, although ultimately self-knowledge. Gnostics believed in the dualism of the good spirit and evil matter. The material world was an evil place from where Gnostics had to escape. They believed that not all humans had the Divine Spark. The aeons emanated from the Ultimate God, the Monad in the Pleroma.

The origins of Gnosticism are unclear today, but probably it came from Persia or further east. It had a lot of Greek influences. Today, after the discovery of the Nag Hammadi Library as leather-bound papyrus codices in a sealed jar in Egypt, in 1945, some people are trying to revive Gnosticism. Gnōsis is Greek for knowledge.

Part of the Nag Hammadi Library, the Coptic Gospel of Thomas contains Jesus' sayings which are not found in the New Testament. Some sayings are parallel with those in the New Testament and may be more original in form. The author is Didymus Judas Thomas, the twin brother of Jesus, as claim many. The introduction to the Coptic Gospel of Thomas says, "Whoever discovers the interpretation of these sayings will not taste death." Gnostics seek secret knowledge.

In the Gospel of Thomas, one may find reference to sexuality:

> 114. Simon Peter said to them, "Make Mary leave us, for females don't deserve life."
>
> Jesus said, "Look, I will guide her to make her male, so that she too may become a living spirit resembling you males. For every female who makes herself male will enter the kingdom of Heaven."

Gnostics believe that the male-female dichotomy should be transcended by the female, the unformed male, transforming into a full male. It is the aim of the female to become male to enter Heaven. (My own interpretation of this part is that Heaven is outer space and it requires a masculine mind to venture out there.)

Sexual orientation is a question dealt with some ambiguity and secretiveness in many religions. One reason that most religions probably promote heterosexuality is because leaders want to expand the population of their adherents despite the lifestyle desires of their people. My belief is that people are really "ambisexual," being able to adapt to a sexual orientation depending on circumstance. An amphibian can go on land or in water.

Sex may be a religious experience for some. For many, it is just a secular act. There are many robotic types. Their spirituality is limited to a few domains in life. They have to learn that sex is part of religion.

Baptists are a Christian sect that my other

family members have encountered. They focus on the doctrine that baptism should only be performed by professing believers, as opposed to infant baptism as in the Catholic Church. Some of my family members converted to Baptists, a Protestant sect. Although, later in their life, my own parents go to a Pentecostal church, a different Protestant sect with lots of singing. Both these sects mentioned are "Bible-thumpers." Pentecostals believe that "every moment is eschatological" in that at any time, Christ may return to Earth. Amongst Pentecostals, "speaking in tongues" is a divine gift that engenders saying fluent, unintelligible utterances, a phenomenon called glossolalia, or speaking in an alleged natural, not previously learned language, a phenomenon called xenoglossia. Such may be angelic in origin.

I should point out clearly that Baptists and Pentecostals are the choices of my other family members, but are not of my own predilection. Many are attracted to these mentioned, so-called Fundamentalist sects because of their "futurist eschatology." These people are waiting for a world war. They may be disappointed because the war will not be the war to end all wars. Some people are afraid that the world will go on indefinitely and even after they are dead. They are kind of selfish.

I was baptised twice in my life. Firstly, it was infant baptism by Catholics in the Philippines, in 1966. Secondly, a specific New Religious Movement (NRM) baptised me by chilly immersion outside a building in Tokyo, sometime during the fantastic years 1992-1994. I did not know the name of the cult, but I was picked up by a young

Japanese woman at a train station and was led to their church. After the event and talking to one of their men, I was treated to a bowl of hot ramen in a nearby restaurant, by the same woman, on that cold, sunny day. They mentioned that baptism should only be done once in life. They seemed grateful that they "saved my soul."

My religious stance today is "syncretic," a mixing of ideas from different religions. I do not commit to any one religion, really, although I may be more heavily influenced by one over another.

The concept of God is polemic. Perhaps, one does not like the English word God. Perhaps, the Japanese word Kami, whose meaning overlaps with spirit, is more pleasing. Perhaps more suitable is the Amerindian

Guaraní word Ñandejára /ɲa.nde.'dʒa.ra/ or Tupã /tũ.'pã/. If one believes in God, then the word should be pleasing to the ear.

Is God a Triune, being three in one? Or is God zillions in one? Number is a human limitation. Those people who say that God is just One are giving a limit to That Who Is Ominipotent. Are these divine persons just incarnations of the same God? Or, are they totally separate individuals? Is divinity a gradient, like temperature? When a Hindu says that he or she, the Ātman, becomes one with Brahman, the Ultimate Reality, at Mokṣa, does it mean that everyone is an incarnate of God?

In the Dvaita (Dualism) School of Hinduism, Mokṣa is by flawless devotion and understanding, the God being a personal

form of transcendental Vishnu or Krishna. At Mokṣa, the Ātman (Self) becomes part of Brahman (the impersonal God) and eternally retains individuality in a loka (heaven). The Dvaita is said to desire to "taste sugar," whilst the Advaita is said to desire to "become sugar." In the Advaita (Non-dualism) School of Hinduism, the Ātman, like a drop of water, joins the ocean Brahman, the Self losing individuality and becoming identical with Brahman in all respects. Mokṣa brings an end to the spirals of involuntary reincarnations.

Does a person have a soul, a definite quantum? Or is a person a composite of several quantized souls or spirits? Or as Buddhists think, is there a "stream of consciousness ever-changing," fluid? In the new Physics, everything is a made up of waves or particles, depending how one looks.

One can learn about spirituality from sci-fi, as I have. From the TV show Babylon 5, I have learnt of the esoteric alien race, the Minbari, who believe that the soul is outside the body, like a projection. Many religions just assume that the soul is internal to the body. The "soul being outside" intrigues me. One can learn from sci-fi.

Buddhists and Hindus alike believe in rebirth, reincarnation, transmigration, or Saṃsāra. By the Law of Karma, one can be reborn as a god, demigod, human, ghost, animal, or hell spirit. One can follow the ordinary norm, so that by good actions, one will be reborn in a better position. Or, one can follow the extraordinary norm, so that by inaction, renunciation, one will achieve Nirvāṇa, or Mokṣa. Being reborn

continuously is not seen as an opportunity, but rather a burden. Nirvāṇa or Mokṣa is the goal. Reincarnation is seen as a caterpillar crawling from one grass blade to another.

People try to answer difficult theological questions. When I was in university, at UBC, I sometimes wandered into the Theological areas of the campus, there I admiring the monastic-like ambiance. Then as now, I had a scientific approach to spirituality. Albert Einstein said, "Science without religion is lame. Religion without science is blind." I am still like that university student.

On Lulu Island, my Canada-born Japanese neighbour, Neil Matsuo, thinks that I do not believe in "God." Perhaps, he thinks that I think that the word "God" is too

anthropomorphic and anthropocentric. Perhaps, he thinks that I tend to believe in something like the Dào, the way, the forces or essences or patterns that make the Yīn and Yáng balance and counteract in the world, in Daoism. There is the Qì, the flowing energy or force of life. It is like the Sanskrit prāṇa, the breath, the vital life-sustaining force or energy.

In a bit of current numerology, 3 is Hindu or Christian; 4 is Buddhism; and 5 is Secular Humanism. Some Japanese think that 3 is also Animism. There have been numbers for languages, but their placements have seemed unstable for some years. One stable language number is 6 for Mandarin, which does require someone being like a Jew to learn it, Judaism being also 6. 17 has to do with Australia, Tagalog, an Austronesian language, being assigned sometimes this

number instead of its older number 5. Lojban can be 5, 9, or 14. Spanish is sometimes 3. English is often 12, it being my second language. Esperanto is sometimes 4, 16, or 28. Interlingua is usually 8 or 26. The compromise number for Esperanto and Interlingua may be 27. Japanese is usually 7. (Japanese for 7 is *shichi* or *nana*, rhyming with *banana*.) 21 is sometimes Hebrew. 10 is the metric number. 1 and 2 are such basic numbers that their assignments have seemed really unstable. On New Year's Day of 2005, I declared a language numerology from 1 to 10:

> Nowadays, I maintain linguadiversity in my life by alternating among my hobby languages: French, Indonesian, Spanish, Esperanto, and Tagalog. I study also some Mandarin, the language of the purring cat, here and there. My true perennial love is Japanese, having a

beautiful Polynesian-like phonology combined with elegant Chinese-derived logograms. For visits to the psychic vineyard, there is always baroque Interlingua. Always a curiosity is Lojban, the language of the purple alien. And via Toki Pona are ubiquitous sunny beaches. Immersing myself in different cultures, I am able to maintain my identity: I am Eurasian.

Some of these number placements have adhered to society, like some religion. Some number assignments are passé. People want to believe in fashion.

Since writing that cited paragraph, I have come to accept that I have ancestry from all 4 major human subspecies, the Caucasoid, the Mongoloid, the Negroid, and the Australoid. So, a concocted racial term for me may be "Holoid" from the Greek holos, "whole."

The categorization of subspecies into those 4 is controversial even today because some researchers believe that there may be more than 4 human subspecies, sometimes called "races." For example, it is polemic whether to include Amerindians ("Native Indians") into the Mongoloid category.

The hair colours of Lojban, Esperanto, and Interlingua, if one tends towards anthropocentric or anthropomorphic thinking, are debatable. Many may opt that Esperanto has blond hair, but in fact, it is just a Latinate language with some Germano-Slavic influences. Esperanto's plural endings of J that sound like Y are as in Greek: verdaj okuloj, green eyes. Possibly, all 3 liturgical languages are hairy, black-haired men with probable other racial admixture.

One's anthropomorphic vision may be different from that of someone else. It does not really matter. One does not need to think anthropomorphically. That inclination is the trouble with many people; they tend to think too anthropomorphically. Languages, instead of people, could be landscapes or vehicles, for example, if one wanted to do away with so much abstraction.

In traditional East Asian numerology, 3 is life or birth, and 4 is death, corresponding to the colour white. The Chinese grab onto life and revere 3. The Japanese use reverse psychology and revere 4. (The Japanese often reverse things around and use reverse psychology.) 3 means having children because the third is the child. To Japanese, probably if a couple had to have children at all, then they should have 2. (There would be a family of 4.)

As my social function, I inform the public. It seems that the locals in the Greater Vancouver Regional District are more interested in languages, religions, and sexuality.

Informational distribution is via my worldwide telepathic broadcasts. Gerald Feinberg, the Columbia University physicist, futurist, and author, coined the word tachyons, which are theoretical faster-than-light particles. He also suggested that psychic powers may be due to particles that he called psychons. So, I may be emitting tachyonic or psychonic waves from my body. These waves or particles give me psychic power. This capability is why I think that I am not human.

There is evil in this world. In Christianity, the bad side is controlled by Satan, the Devil. In Buddhism, Māra is the demon that tempted Gautama Buddha. The demons lure people away from spirituality to wallow in the mundane.

Religion is a serendipitous journey...
Religion is really very personal...

Some people think that, perhaps, they should just learn more about psychology, than dwell in religion, in order to cope with reality. Psychologists study the brain, the rational left "sequential" hemisphere and the creative right "parallel" hemisphere. The brain can be seen as a Triune with the innermost reptilian complex, then the paleomammalian complex (the limbic system), and the outermost neomammalian

complex (the neocortex). Psychologists have to learn some biology. Then, they learn human behaviour. They learn models of development. They learn the defects and ailments of the human mind, and how to try to fix them. Advanced psychology may replace religion. In retrospect, Buddhism may be perceived as a psychological methodology. Christianity, too, has use of psychology, of course. Psychology is not an exact science. There is room for more research. If people knew more about it, then society may be in less trouble than it is now.

Youth derives from imagination. During my teenage years, my family a few times went crabbing at the wharf with my uncle, whom we called Tito Bert, and with his family. It might have been dark before sunrise. I have been having a deep interest in invertebrate biology because I link it with astrobiology, I

thinking that life elsewhere beyond Earth could look dissimilar to what is on Earth. In grade school in Canada, I read a strange vintage sci-fi novel where giant crabs inhabited a desert planet being colonized by humans. In the Philippines, at a much younger age, I read a Dr. Seuss book called *Bartholomew and the Oobleck* about green, gloopy precipitation from the sky. The king was tired of the regular sunshine, rain, fog, and snow, and wanted new weather from his magicians. So, he got his wish. In a different Dr. Seuss book *The Lorax*, there was an environmental plight when *Truffula* trees began to be chopped down as they were needed for *Thneeds*. Anyway, I have liked sci-fi and fantasy books since I was very young. Decades later, I still do. Reading text and watching shows in those genres are a means of travelling in my mind. There is something between sci-fi and fantasy, it is

called science fantasy. "Citadels" are not just in fantasy. For some people, reality is not enough. Many people want to live fantasizing. I have read many vintage books from these imaginary genres, dating even from back in the 1940's, 1950's, 1960's, and 1970's. These days, some could only be found in secondhand bookstores.

Is religion just fantasy? Is it a phantasm from the creative side of the brain? Science is different from religion because it is a self-correcting paradigm. Theories are formed, and when they are proven, then they become fact, but when they are disproved, then other theories supplant them. Scientific thinking has spread all over this world. From what was once a mainly Caucasoid endeavour, it has spread to Mongoloids in East Asia, and Negroids in Africa, and Australoids in India. Science, then its application, technology, has

allowed humans to manipulate their material environment. Their power is greater than the monkey who uses a twig to pry into an anthill, for example. Many women especially, are confused by what is technology. A horse and its carriage in the 19th century were technology. A transoceanic ship from the 16th century was technology. A fancy automobile today is, of course, technology. A toaster is technology. A television set is technology. People have had to live with some level of technology, whatever that level is. Technology scares some people. Science is different from technology. Science deals with many more abstractions. Technology, as in engineering, is its application.

Some people like the Transhumanists believe that technology will redefine what a human is. It will reshape humanity for its

betterment. People today are trapped in a jelly-like mass supported by a delicate framework called the skeleton. Perhaps, inorganic parts could support the body in the future. Better knowledge of psychology would help the human mind. Such is the essence of Transhumanism. Can people wait? It may take generations. Humans will progress into something beyond what is human.

Singularitarianism is another technocentric ideology and social movement defined by the belief that a technological singularity—the creation of an artificial superintelligence—will probably happen in the medium future. Singularitarians opine that deliberate action must be taken to ensure that the Singularity benefits us common humans.

Science is a self-correcting paradigm. The

wave-particle duality of our physical reality is the current paradigm, which has been proven. What it needs is augmentation. Different groups of physicists today are busy working on the different forms of String Theory, which postulates that subatomic particles are like very thin strings that are vibrating like tiny violins. Matter then may be an orchestra. A paradigm shift in physics is in the making. String Theory requires multidimensional mathematics, so that beyond the 3 spatial dimensions and 1 temporal dimension that we humans experience, their mathematics may require 10, 11, 26, or more dimensions. Physicists are still working on this theory in various proposals.

I have watched all incarnations of Star Trek and other sci-fi shows since early childhood. Along with close friends, we call our ethnic

group Trekkers. Watching Star Trek and other sci-fi shows has been a way to explore the universe without limits to creativity. We also read sci-fi and fantasy literature. It is the Church of Startrekology.

Some intellectuals venture to say that sci-fi films and literature are fuzzily impacts of Orientalism. For some Westerners, looking at a sci-fi film or reading a sci-fi book resembles an adventure into the Orient. For the Westerner, it is the Self versus the Other. James Alexander Brown wrote his dissertation "American Science Fiction Cinema, Orientalism, Self & Other" to expound on just that sentimentality in the West.

This feeling of "Orientalism" in sci-fi cannot be universal for humanity. Japanese animés

are mostly sci-fi, in the subgenre of science fantasy maybe. For Japanese, sci-fi is not about "Orientalism." Sci-fi for Japanese is usually a spiritual endeavour, an extension of their existing Animistic and Buddhist traditions maybe. The production and effect of sci-fi are different in Japan, compared to the West. Japan is more spiritual.

I think that I am an Oriental. When I read sci-fi or watch sci-fi, it is not about "Self versus Other," but of the "Self."

In the end, there may be just two essential religions, the Cat Religion and the Dog Religion. Which is Dog, or Cat? Are these animals appropriate totems? Is this dualism a valid paradigm? What is the alternative model?

Sci-fi and Fantasy

I have travelled extensively on this Earth: 25 countries in Asia, Europe, Africa, and the Americas. I have known for some time that what seems like pervasive doldrums reality in one place is not reality in a more colourful place of the world. One time and place may be more organic than another time and place which may be more inorganic and mechanical. One country may seem like a different planet from another. One may be an anthill, another a herd of cattle grazing.

As we move into the 2010's here on Lulu Island, many are thinking that the future should be about destruction and not about progress with the possibility of space exploration. Humankind, many think now, is not worthy of furtherance. Only a small

minority of humankind is interested in astronomy. Most have no notion of space in their mind. They think that everything happens on Earth. Their view of reality is very commonplace. What would it take to awaken them? Their view of reality has been programmed by television with random consumerist notions with no real purpose, but to be dissatisfied with life. Does one really need that shampoo today? Many in North America have a "screwed up" work ethic in which work is just for money and work is not desirable and everything is just work. They think with complacence that Market Capitalism is the natural order. Money is their enslaving god that lives in a centralized banking computer. As we move into the 2010's, will people still learn? What is reality?

Many North Americans have stopped

believing in "life preservation" because they think that their culture and its artifacts are not worth enduring in time. Even, they complain about their bodies. What can be done about these people? They seem desperate to see the end. They do not believe in eternity. Such may be the effects of some malformed, distorted variants of Christianity.

The "man-woman" dichotomy becomes the "industrial-agrarian" dichotomy. It turns out that a language that cannot express science, technology, and sci-fi is agrarian, like Tagalog is. Why Tagalog has been chosen for the Global Xenoglossia is a mystery. Perhaps, it is to tell people of Earth in the early 21st century that their mind is like Tagalog. They may be using cellphones and such, but their mind is still agrarian. An agrarian mind is a subset of the industrial mind. Sci-fi frees the mind to explore.

Religion is like fantasy. An agrarian mind is like a prison. That reason is why one sees them wandering around looking bored in the suburbs. With scientific knowledge, one can effect change in the environment because it is factual. The industrial mind understands reality more than an agrarian one. Science is a never-ending, self-correcting paradigm. It is different from religion.

I have experimented with writing sci-fi in Tagalog and it sounds awesome. I am a rare Filipino. Filipinos are still mostly agrarian. Besides in English, I read sci-fi in Latinate languages like French, Spanish, and Portuguese. The Latins are very much agrarian. Their sci-fi, mostly translations from other languages, is geared for a privileged minority to which I belong. The Latins do not produce sci-fi much domestically.

I think that in some ways, languages like Japanese, Malaysian, and Indonesian are like Tagalog, except that they went through a period of maturation whereupon they absorbed and concocted words for industrialization. I also, from time to time, read sci-fi books and watch anime in Japanese. I do enjoy them. The Japanese are industrial.

Nevertheless, Tagalog is in transition. The Philippine government's Komisyon sa Wikang Filipino recently published the article "Ang Ortograpiya ng Wikang Pambansa" dated on 2007-08-01 to address the issues of Tagalog spelling and intellectualization. It is a step to becoming more and more like Indonesian and Malaysian. Hopefully, someday, one would see a thick sci-fi novel written in

Tagalog. It would be Tagalog with an industrial mind. Tagalog is still evolving.

On Lulu Island, my neighbour Bruce whispered to me, "Filipinos don't fight!" after I mentioned to him the poor people that I have witnessed in the Philippines. In fact, Filipinos have been fighting even before the 19th century, against foreign intrusion and poverty. Perhaps the fight is not effectively fought. Only now are some politicians there realizing that the language which is an infrastructure is very important in all affairs. Some politicians have resigned from the language issue and support English wholeheartedly. I am not against English because I think that it is good for sci-fi, but balance is needed in the Philippines. The national language Filipino (Tagalog) needs to be fortified. If all the more English is promoted, hopefully the supporters also

promote sci-fi in English. (I promote sci-fi because I think it is a good way to expand one's intellect. The propelling imagination required in sci-fi allows one to escape the mental jail of an otherwise agrarian mind.)

My all-time favourite sci-fi, fantasy, and paranormalist authors, whose fascinating books are mostly originally in English, but I also read them translated into wonderful French, Spanish, Portuguese, Japanese, and Esperanto, are J. R. R. Tolkien, Ursula K. Le Guin, William Olaf Stapledon, Frank Herbert, Tuesday Lobsang Rampa, Piers Anthony, Isaac Asimov, Tove Jansson, Arthur C. Clarke, Anne McCaffrey, Robert Heinlein, Samuel Delany, Ray Bradbury, Doris Lessing, Larry Niven, Edgar Rice Burroughs, Robert Silverberg, James Blish, and some whom I may have unwittingly missed. This set is ample literature. Maybe, even, all of the

novels may sound better in Tagalog translation. My author list is not exhaustive of my interest as I also like other authors.

One should not confuse science fact with science fiction (sci-fi). There are those only interested in factual matters. Sci-fi is a brainstorming field for people with a science background. Its brother, the genre of fantasy of warlocks and witches, is like sci-fi really without all the scientific "mumbo-jumbo." Often, the two genres have the same audience. I do read both of them.

Nowadays, there is an umbrella term for both sci-fi and fantasy. It is called "speculative fiction," which is a really convenient term.

I have my own individualistic culture. I believe in the "Young-Old Old-New

Paradigm" (YOON). As of now, my beard has bits of white on rufous black. So, one could say, as many people are, that I am in the "process of dying." Yet, my imagination is still vibrant like a young person's. Still, sometimes, I feel as though I am thousands of years old in a body that has not really fully matured. I look forward to progress of all sorts, yet I like antiques. The Japanese think that I am like Seren Arbazard, a rebellious Japanese language inventor, who created the language Arka, perhaps alluding to Noah's Ark. I am a goldfish out of my fishbowl. YOON. "Yoon" /jo.ˈʔon/ in colloquial Tagalog means "that one yonder."

My neighbour Brian on Lulu Island, with the two dogs Rafa and Chino, believes that people now live in an age of ignorance. He believes that about 98% of humanity lingers on without questioning the afterlife,

questioning what is beyond Earth, etc. Brian and I are two of the remaining 2% of humanity with more curiosity. Brian believes that outer space may be already inhabited by other sentient beings. Earthlings here do not really know what is "out there." Brian is a ufologist, collecting literature and broadcasts pertaining to UFOs. Talking to Brian, I sometimes think, is like talking to myself. He says that he is from Okanagan, of "Yugoslav" ancestry, if I remember correctly. He says that his wife, with whom he cohabits in a nearby townhouse condominium, is a spiritual "atheist" who has explored different religions. Perhaps, the relevant dichotomy is not really about "industrial-agrarian," but the estimate of "2% versus 98%" proportions of "curious versus incurious" in the human population. The 98% dwell in their preconceived wealth ideas and religious

notions acquired externally in society, whilst the 2% go beyond what most of society accept. I have mentioned to Brian of my UFO sighting on 2010-07-09, of an orangy linear object in the eastern sky beyond the balcony of my family house. It was travelling towards the southeast. It was orangy because of the sunlight that clear morning at 5 o'clock. Perhaps, it was the side view of a saucer object. Other times, I have seen gigantic shadows, of still unseen, large-spanned wingèd creatures, cast on the road or on the snow, during different seasons. Some things are inexplicable. Brian has good intuition about reality.

Brian has striking similarities to my own personality; however, one of our differences is that he does not like sci-fi. His favourite genre is ufology. His ideas about religions are that they have been invented, artificial, so

one must look beyond religions. His ideas about the afterlife are uncommitted and varied, however. He speaks as though he has a university degree, but he has not, which I find consoling about people in general. He is awe-inspired by the notion that there are greater things in life, but which are mysteries to us common people, who are like little atoms in the infinite vastness.

Brian looks for a view of reality in his research in ufology, which he distinguishes from the paranormal genre. He prefers the scientific non-fiction literature of an author like Isaac Asimov, who wrote the Foundation sci-fi series about the Fall, Interregnum, and Renaissance of a Galaxy-wide Empire, controlled by a single sentient humanoid species, which may be human, as I have assumed, until Brian tells me that we are all "aliens" because I previously have told him

that there seem no "aliens" in that sci-fi series. I do prefer Asimov's sci-fi over his non-fiction. Brian thinks that sci-fi literature is about regurgitating dreams. In Asimov's case, it is about the Roman Empire in outer space. Brian finds that sci-fi is rather disturbing because it is not reality. I just think that sci-fi is brainstorming ideas.

Brian thinks that the existence of more advanced interstellar cultures, which may be "billions of years older than ours," I add, does preclude our own human overtures in space colonization. He does take a liking to my "Earth-as-PNG" idea (Papua New Guinea).

There should be more philosophers like Brian, but the masses wallow in superstitions and television muck. Brian says that there

are always some obstacles so that we people are unable get along well, even if we all had "grey skin," I add. His heritage is Yugloslavia, now a country sliced like pizza into smaller countries because people could not get along well.

Brian may be partly Amerindian. My suspicion is that, in North America, he is one of the many white people who do not know their genealogy fully.

Sexology in Society

Freudian psychologists, who think that sex has everything to do with human activities, may opine that today's world is full of people with sexual dysfunctions. A worrying trend is that more and more people use drugs like

marijuana to substitute for sexual activities, be they solitary or with companions. Endorphins ("endogamous morphine") and dopamine are released during orgasm. Some people rely on external drugs as substitute. Alcohol is a drug. There is a drug in smoking cigarettes. Religion is affected. Because some people cannot achieve orgasm at their microcosmic level, they await a big event like a war as metaphor for a macrocosmic orgasm. Sex may be everything. Perhaps, drugs cannot replace sex. Sex is like eating and other bodily functions. It is an inherent part of living. Would a pharmaceutical engineer someday produce the "orgasm-in-a-pill"?

Some think that sex is just a job. However, it is a job that needs doing. If people were allowed to masturbate in lobbies and public spaces as if smoking, all the better society

would be.

The Japanese know that I prefer someone like a Buddhist as a life partner. This special person as a life partner I have not found in reality. I have not been really looking hard enough and my instincts fight for solitude.

What can one ascertain about the Global Tagalog Xenoglossia? Some entity can manipulate the memory of all the billions of people on Earth. They do not talk openly about it. Is the memory volatile? Will it last for some period of time? Will it last indefinitely?

Of Humanity

How should we Earthlings ourselves think about us humanity? Sometimes, I think that the Earth is too small for humanity. There are some 7000 language tribes on this world, but most hear about only a handful of these wonderful variations. In the early 21st century, humans number over 7 billion (10^9) already. (I have read or seen a few sci-fi stories in which the population drops tremendously for some reason and so the scarce people are able to live in big haciendas.)

We humans try to divide ourselves in many ways. It is in our nature. There are those people admired for their metaphoric and indirect communication skills. There are yet others admired for their concise and vulgar

directness. There are those admired for their rhythm or musicality. People are divided by their appearances. What kind of body covering does that man or woman have? Does his or her eyes look different? What is his or her height? Is he or she old, young, old but young, or young but old?

Should we people believe in ourselves, humanity? What is outside of our home, the Earth? Are there people like us out there? Do they not look like people? Are they richer than us?

Humanity is feeling uncomfortable that now in the 2010's, we are yet in the beginning of something. In the 1990's, we were at the end of something. Some people are looking for the end of something. Where is it?

On Lulu Island, my young neighbour Wesley insinuates that living space is always finite. My guess about him is that he advocates the Anti-Growth Equilibrium for Earth Paradigm (AGEFEP). People and industry should be stabilized. Growth should be halted or curtailed. Wesley may foresee that space colonization may not be feasible for humans any time soon. Ergo, expansion would not be possible. A really big war may not be inevitable, even.

Another paradigm is my Expansive Growth in Space Paradigm (EGISP). As time passes, more and more industry would be oriented or propelled in outer space. The acceleration all depends on how Earth's industries would produce new technologies and how much of them would be geared for outer space and how fast they would be produced over time. Eventually, outer space, and perhaps

different moons and planets, may be colonized by people. Superstructures in space would be megaprojects. Habitable enclosures on worlds may be needed. These projections are possible.

Since my teenage years, my inclination has been to think of outer space as very scantily, even rarely, inhabited by sentient beings like ourselves, humans. I have inclined to the Desert Model of the Universe (DMOTU). Talking to Brian, the dog owner of Rafa and Chino, I have started to think that outer space may be just full of aliens as Brian's Outer Space Is Full of Aliens Model (OSIFOAM). I add to this perspective the notion that the Earth may be a primitive enclave like Papua New Guinea in relation to massively advanced space cultures. Such thinking may scare EGISP supporters.

On the French-language network TV5, I have encountered the phrase Les Trente Continents, The Thirty Continents. Some elite French believe in the gradual colonization of various moons and planets, what are figuratively called The Thirty Continents. They expect to live in luxury in outer space and those worlds.

On a game show on TV5, the French have proclaimed that the rest of our Solar System is uninhabited. Perhaps, they are thinking that although we Earthlings may have secretive guests from outside our Solar System, it does not preclude humanity's Spatial Manifest Destiny (SMD), the human expansion outside of Earth.

The carrying capacity of Earth may be

somewhere between 4 billion to 16 billion. Humans number now over 7 billion. Have we passed the carrying capacity? Are we overpopulated? Do we need to get out? Do we need to find other resource locations?

No one can foretell the future. Over 50 years ago, no one really predicted the Internet or Web. There may be things in the future that people today cannot yet imagine. One of the things that may have conservative change is how people interact with one another, the psychosociology.

Many of us humans have resigned to the fact that we cannot get along with others. We look then to individualism. The group does not work for us. Sometimes, we force ourselves to be with them just for a time, then split off on our own. I live in North

America, much admired elsewhere in the world for its wild individualism, the hallmark of creativity. Yet here, we suffer from inorganicity and mechanicalism in society. Others in the world long to be in North America. Effectively, the whole world is here, yet not here. I long to be elsewhere, even vicariously as I do now. I have travelled to 25 countries in 4 continents. There is beauty in this world if one looks for it.

What is it about wars? The killing instinct, my Lulu Island neighbour Martin insinuates by spraying herbicides, weed-killer, is high amongst those who perceive themselves as monoracial and being threatened by another race. I come from the Philippines where mixed-race people buffer between races. Would the future of humanity be plagued by wars, hindering upward progress and creating ups and downs in history, shattering

hopes and dreams? Olaf Stapledon, a historian and sci-fi writer, writes in *Last and First Men* about the future history of two billion years of 18 sequential species of humanity, in many ups and downs, in peace and war. Even, he does not discount space colonization of the Solar System, but it would take hundreds of millions of years. Venus would be the next home for humanity, then hundreds of millions years later, Neptune. This timeline is extremely sluggish compared to Arthur C. Clarke's *Imperial Earth*, in which Saturn's moon Titan already has a well-established human colony in 2276. In Samuel R. Delany's *Triton*, there would be established colonies on Mars, Saturn's moon Tethys, and Neptune's moon Triton in 2112. In Delany's *Babel-17*, there is talk about "the worlds of five galaxies," insinuating intergalactic travel already existing. In Larry Niven's *Ringworld* and

Known Space universe, the nearest stars' planets would be colonized a few centuries from now. Each author presents a different timeline.

War in the timeline could disrupt humanity's exploration. However, war could accelerate technology as was seen in World War II because there would be more motivation to produce. Will there be a World War III? Many people are betting on it. Their life is just too sedentary. Everybody needs action, they opine. People need change, they add. My prediction is that it would not be the war to end all wars. Life would continue thereafter.

Nevertheless, there are those people like my Lulu Island neighbour John who likes to believe in the Post-Apocalyptic Cockroaches

and Under Theory (PACAUT) in which the only survivors would be plants and animals the size of cockroaches or smaller in the aftermath of a great war. These people do not believe in human survival. The biosphere may not even withstand the shock of future weapons. In that case, it alternatively would be the Post-Apocalyptic Dead Biosphere Theory (PADBT). As I have mentioned earlier, humanity's hope is that there would be life elsewhere in the universe. Hopefully, life would not be unique on Earth. So if we humans extinguish ourselves, we could be reassured that life would still exist somewhere outside the Earth. Indeed, there is always hope.

On the French-language network TV5, a game show announcer declares that what might happen in the future is that Earth may be vulnerable to war destruction, but its

outer space colonies would survive like hatchlings from eggs. Earth would then say « Adieu ! Allez ! » (Goodbye! Go forth!). Some elite suppose that humanity would survive in some form in space. Goodbye, Earth!

Wars may be classified into two kinds: a Big War that uses nuclears and a Small War that uses conventionals only. So, even if a single nuclear were used, orders of magnitude greater than those in World War II, the war would be a Big War. So, 4 nuclears would be a Big War. Thousands of nuclears would be a Big War. It may be possible that people who have waited for a Big War would be disappointed in the end. Say, for example, that "44 million people died" or that even "444 million people died" in the aftermath of a Big War with maybe only several nuclears used, people would adjust and

accept it, and life would go on with the billions of survivors. However, history would have changed. Deadliest so far, World War II had an estimate of about 60 million casualties, then about 2.5% of the world population. I think that warmongers will be disappointed in the end. Things are more mundane in reality. Life is not a Hollywood movie.

Nevertheless, some people want to witness the end of humankind. Maybe, they are old fogeys or whatever. In Arthur C. Clarke's Childhood's End, superior devil-looking beings called the Overlords look after their "crop" of Earth's humanity to be "harvested" for the Overmind. The last man witnesses the end of humanity. It is a dream of some to witness humanity's end before they themselves die. Some think that their life would be insignificant without this finality's

witnessing. It would be rather selfish. (Arthur C. Clarke, born British, emigrated to tropical, Buddhist-Hindu Sri Lanka for the marvellous scuba-diving and did die there.)

If the casualties of a Big War were to amount to something over 4 billion, one could then say that it would be Humanity's Near Extinction Stage (HNES) as the species teeters closer to death. Survival would be dubious in the following years. There may be climate change. There would be radiation floating in the air, flowing in the waters, and seeping into land. Many people disregard that humanity may be being watched by outworlders. If that were the case, would outworlders allow the catastrophe to happen? How would they view humans, as savage primates, or needy children?

Authors have written many Post-Apocalyptic fictional stories. Davy by NYC-born Edgar Pangborn is a favourite of mine. Therein, a somewhat medieval existence does survive after the Big War. The setting is the Northeast of North America. There are lots of Post-Apocalyptic tales in sci-fi. People should read these tales to make them think more about the whole issue. I read some mostly during my teens.

Movies in the Post-Apocalyptic sci-fi subgenre are good too. There have been many over the decades.

In George Lucas' movie THX 1138, subterranean colonies survive in what seems to be Post-Apocalyptic Times insinuated. People underground wear all white. The walls are white. The floors are white. The

survivors' cities are like extremely hygienic mental-hospitals-cum-shopping-malls. Arbitrary items to buy are brightly coloured origami-like geometric objects, which are then disposed at home in a vacuum swoop. Commerce, the centralized computer system, and their meditative religion are tightly bound. Monks in grey hoods wander the corridors. Everybody shaves his or her head. They watch 3D holograms instead of television. Life moves on.

Religious Climax

Having talked to friends Leo and Ami Medriano of Jehovah's Witness, I have come to more understanding of at least this facet of Christianity. They believe that now is not yet the time of the Great Tribulation, the climax of which is Armageddon, or World

War III, after which is the Millennial Reign, 1000 years of "perfect" humanity on Earth ruled from the Kingdom of God in Heaven. Both righteous and "vile" people who have already died will be resurrected to live in the Millennial Reign. The word "resurrection," not "rapture," is used because "rapture" is not Biblical. "Vile" people are those who previously not heard about Christianity. At the end of 1000 years, there will be another war, which I would call World War IV. Satan that time will be released from imprisonment. Whether World War III will be greater than World War IV is contentious. The casualties in World War IV will be "like grains of sand."

New "scrolls" will be revealed in the future to contain extrabiblical information about what will happen after the Millennial Reign.

It is highly probable that genetically both Buddha and Jesus were mostly Mediterranean Caucasoid in features, but Jesus, from the Levant, might have had trace amounts of Negroid and/or Australoid (Veddoid variant) genes. Buddha, being from Northern India, very likely also had Australoid (Veddoid variant) genes, and had a slight probability of having Mongoloid genes also. But no one knows for sure what Buddha looked like; he might have looked more Mongoloid like someone from neighbouring Tibet. One can speculate.

The nature of one's soul or consciousness stream is a matter of more speculation and belief. Is it eternal? Does it dissipate after several different lives? Is there just one lifetime and out it goes like a light bulb when one dies? The whole matter is about

belief and speculation.

(I initiated the following language article in 2546 B.E. (Buddhist Era) or 2003 C.E. (Common Era).)

Linguaphile Lullabies

Languages always intrigue me. As a child growing up bilingual, I make up nonsense words that only family members and nannies understand, like 'brábintai' for dragonfly, 'numnumbúbit' for wanting a drink, and 'múninghai' for a full moon high in the sky. I was born in the Philippines in 2509 B.E. (Buddhist Era = Western Era + 543 years). My native language is Tagalog, an Austronesian ("South Islands") language like Hawaiian and Indonesian. I learn English starting from nursery like all upper and

middle class children in the Philippines at this time. From ten and under, I speak almost exclusively in Tagalog with family and classmates, but read mostly in English. I move to Canada when I am Grade 5. I am ten years old. My English is all right, although of course I still have a Filipino accent, not yet a Canadian one at this time. I am still confused as to what a 'quarter', 'nickel', or 'penny' is. I am still confused about 'nap' and 'nip'. One time a Canadian teacher asks me to close the door for the class, but instead, I stand outside the door, thinking I did something wrong, having misunderstood. Another teacher finds me sulking and waiting outside the door. She is wondering why a good student like myself would need to be "disciplined." Canada is eerily foreign. A neighbour kid taunts me, saying, "Hey, go suck an egg!" and I am bewildered as to what she says. Some people

are speaking English a little too fast for me.

In Canada, common items like cereal boxes and soup cans are labelled bilingually, in both French and English. At this time, I think the French labels are English words that I yet still do not know. It is my first encounter with French. I have no idea where France is or know anything about Québec. My Grade 5 class learns a few phrases of that, to me, odd language. I learn how to say 'Il fait froid' (It's cold), 'Il fait chaud' (It's hot), and 'J'ai faim' (I'm hungry).

Throughout Grades 6 to 12, I am an avid reader of science fiction and I become proficient in English. To my dismay, my speaking ability in Tagalog rapidly deteriorates because of my constant daily use of English. Even when my own parents speak

to me in Tagalog, I would respond in English. My parents never really complain and encourage my adjustment in the Anglosphere. Besides, in Canada there is never much Tagalog reading material around to keep up the interest. As far as I know, there are no such things as science fiction novels, my staple genre, in the Tagalog language. Anyway, Filipino culture is highly aural-oral.

In high school, I win top awards in English (and French). Although, early on, I am not aesthetically pleased with English because to my ears it sounds mumbled compared to languages in which one opens one's mouth wider when speaking, languages like Spanish, Japanese, and my native Tagalog, which sound a lot clearer to my ears. Also it bothers me that the spelling in English is so unsystematic, unlike my native Tagalog in

which words are phonetic (or "phonemic" as linguists would more correctly put it).

In high school, I begin to be fascinated about other languages. From the public library, I borrow books about exotic languages like Japanese, Yoruba, Swahili, Ancient Egyptian, Blissymbolics, and others. I would just browse the grammars without really the intention of learning how to speak them, as I am just curious about the "architecture" of other languages. The grammar and phonology of Swahili especially fascinate me:

> *Viazi vyako vikifaa nitavinunua.*
>
> (If your potatoes are good, I will buy them.)

It is also in high school that I spot *Teach Yourself Esperanto* in the public library. I

am enthralled to learn about Esperanto, a planned, artificial language with the Utopian ambition of becoming the International Language of a peaceful world. The vision intrigues me. I think it is a great idea. But I do not learn to speak Esperanto in high school; that task has to wait many years later until 2540 B.E. when I would begin a more serious, but not too serious, study of it. In university, I take first-year courses in Japanese, Spanish, and French as just art electives in my hectic engineering, then later science, program. Incidentally, also in the first year of university, I encounter an Esperanto Club on campus. I show up a few times, but they are a sparse group and meet sporadically. Anyway, my heavy courses do not allow too much extracurricular activity. I do not yet learn the language. I am still curious. Again, Esperanto has to wait for a more serious

commitment from me much later...

After switching from Chemical Engineering, I eventually graduate with a Bachelor's Degree in Computer Science in 2532 B.E. In my last year, I take a lot of AI (Artificial Intelligence) courses, as they are all the rage. Throughout my years in university and before, I learn about a dozen computer languages, including the AI languages Lisp and Prolog. I have an outlandish viewpoint regarding human and computer languages. I have an equal interest in both and see parallels in their theoretical structures and uses. If my parents were wealthy and I would not be needing to support myself, I would go to deeper study of Linguistics in university. But alas, I think having expertise in computers would make me financially independent. Anyway, human and computer languages are both languages. So I am happy.

After graduation from university, I land various software engineering jobs. I even work in Tōkyō, Japan, during the years 2535 B.E. to 2537 B.E. as a software engineer. It is a prestigious software firm that is a well-known trademark, Microsoft. My stint in Tōkyō is like my second childhood as everything is new: the sights, the sounds, the language, and the cuisine among other things. There are the exciting strolls in the "Las-Vegas-on-steroids" neon jungle of Shinjuku, the walks among octopus vendors and sweet potato stalls in the park of Ueno, the promenades among fashionable teenage rockers in Harajuku, the meanderings among the flashy electronics bazaars of Akihabara, and the hikes about the gorgeous ancient temples of Kyōto. In a sense, Japan is like one big amusement park for me because much of what I encounter is amusing. Japan

opens my eyes, my mind, to new possibilities. There, I begin my interest in Eastern religion and philosophy, especially Buddhism. I haunt the Shintō shrines and Buddhist temples in Japan.

In Japan, my company has me take Japanese classes on cultural orientation and language. The language classes ameliorate my knowledge accumulated from first-year university. In the milieu of Japanese society, I quickly learn to speak Japanese. I learn a few more logograms, the Kanji. Japanese is relatively easy to learn for colloquial conversation, but to read newspapers and books is a totally different story. My cri de coeur about Japanese is that learning to read it requires an enormous amount of commitment. There is a hidden romance there; I fall in love with my Japanese-language teacher. She is a couple of years

older than I am. Every class we have is like courtship. But alas, I am deluded. That experience is not all of it; I also fall in love with my boss' secretary who is good at ikebana, flower-arranging. Japanese women enrapture me...

I return to North America. For a while, there is a feeling of sensory deprivation. North America seems bleak and unstimulating compared to Japan. But I soon get over that and find a routine to keep a stimulating life. I travel a lot still. I have been to more than two dozen countries in Europe, Asia, Africa, and the Americas.

In 2540 B.E., after some searching on the Web, I find an Esperanto group in my city in Canada. I contact the local leader and am told to come to a meeting in a bohemian café

called La Quena. Then I go to monthly club meetings. At first, I just observe the other experienced speakers talk in Esperanto, and then I later participate more. Considering I could only speak it for about an hour or so every month, I learn, miraculously, to speak the language: a testimony to its ease. My Esperanto colleagues are a diverse group of political radicals, religious about that language which Dr. Ludoviko Lazaro Zamenhof, a Jewish oculist, invented in 2430 B.E. in Russian-occupied Poland. I imagine the vision of people at the time coincident with the building of the Eiffel Tower in France. To me, Esperanto seems like a language for the foggy and misty lanes of European cities along with their ghouls and vampires! I imagine myself in a black cape whilst wandering a grand old castle and speaking that language. Childishness aside, I am highly enthused for a long while,

listening to online newscasts and reading books and magazines in the surreal language. When I read the visionary resolutions of The Prague Manifesto, I am really inspired by the ambitions of the Esperanto Movement of a peaceful world bound by a universal (second) language that is democratically easy to learn for everyone. I even write poems in Esperanto to practice:

la drako gardas
en subtera kaverno
la brilan lunon

(the dragon guards
in an underground cave
the shining moon)

Esperanto is not perfect of course. It is a bit Eurocentric. I am part European by blood,

but my Asian side seems a little hesitant to call an essentially simplified, streamlined Romance (Latinate) language with Germanic and Slavic flavouring as "the International Language," but "an international language" would be better maybe. Yet, I have to admit, it is still better than the imposition of English, which I find chaotic in structure, especially the spelling.

Esperanto is a macho language. There is the asymmetric default masculinity of nouns, a phenomenon copied from natural languages. In Esperanto, a boy is a *knabo* and a girl is a *knabino*; a poet is a *poeto* and a poetess is a *poetino*. Unfortunately, there is no official word for a unisex singular third-person pronoun ('he/she'), so that traditionalists would have one say 'he' (*li* in Esperanto) when one does not know the sex of the subject. In contrast, my native Tagalog has

the unisex pronoun siyá for 'he/she'. The tidy proposal called Riismo actually addresses the gender issue in Esperanto, but needs more support from the speaker base. Riismo introduces the pronoun ri for 'he/she'. But my exposé is a bit like finding faults in the Mona Lisa. Esperanto is a work of art with all its human quirks. All in all, though, my interest in Esperanto is more of a hobby than something political or revolutionary. I like Esperanto as an arta objekto ("art object").

After my trip to Spain in 2541 B.E., I begin to fall in love with Spanish, a language far more complicated than Esperanto. In Madrid, I buy the heavyweight classic Don Quixote de la Mancha by Cervantes. It is the ultimate Spanish souvenir. When I get back to Canada, I realize that there is not enough Spanish media where I live to sustain my

immersing in the culture. (I have no satellite TV.) So I drop Spanish for French.

I resume studying my French in the spring of 2543 B.E. I have the idea that immersing myself in a different culture through Québecois or Parisian radio and television would enhance my lifestyle. I have not studied French since college. My resumption of it is a landmark for me, having been unimpressed with languages with muddled spelling. But then, I begin to appreciate the artistic aspect of French and the intellectuality of the culture that speaks it. I also realize later that my learning French is, in fact, a form of self-psychotherapy, so that I would grow to appreciate English's horrendous spelling system and repertoire of ambiguous phonemes or sounds. French and English both use the Roman alphabet illogically and sound mumbled to my ears,

but at least French sounds more fluid whereas English sounds choppier... Some languages have better fēng shuǐ than others. To encapsulate my feelings, I write a Tagalog poem (sprinkled with controversial technical words from a dictionary, New Handy Webster's Dictionary: English-Tagalog Tagalog-English (2529 B.E.), predating the People Power Revolution):

Naglíliwalíw sa Sansinukob
ang halintigál na panuós,
ang buntót ay labás dínagipík.
Nagháhanáp siyá ng liboy dagítabbaláni
galing sa malayong talumpón.

(Traversing the Universe
is the gyroscopic computer,
ejecting plasma at its tail.
It searches for electromagnetic waves

from the distant star cluster.)

In 2544 B.E. and in 2546 B.E., I revisit the Philippines. On both trips, I buy, in total, more than two dozen Philippine-related and Tagalog-language books, including a novel, *Luha ng Buwaya* (Crocodile Tears) by Amado V. Hernandez; a world history book, *Ang Kasaysayan ng Daigdig*; and some collections of poetry and proverbs. I buy dictionaries of different Philippine languages like Cebuano, Ilocano, and Bikol. It is a passing interest in the linguadiversity of my motherland. Once in a while, I would read a Tagalog chapter here and there. There is not much Filipino media where I live in Canada, not until TFC (The Filipino Channel) and FTV (Filipino Television) come out on the cable box.

In the Philippines itself, I notice a

remarkable change; many more television programs are now in Tagalog, even the cartoons. Definitely, when I was a child there, the cartoons were in English. Now, even made-in-Japan animated cartoons, or animés, are dubbed in Tagalog. The maids and housewives watch extremely popular Tagalog-dubbed versions of soap operas from Latin America and from Taiwan and Korea. Philippine society changes for more indigenization of the media. In fact, some reports indicate that the use of English in the Philippines has declined in recent years; this trend worries some politicians. I return to Canada, thinking that there are much hope and improvement of self-esteem in contemporary Filipino culture. My perspective is totally different from other visitors who think the Philippines is a kind of disaster area. I know that Filipino politicians will flip-flop on the language

issue for years to come.

Back in Canada, my interest in Esperanto comes like the waves in the ocean. On different occasions, I share the idea of Esperanto with family members with mixed reactions. Two of my aunts love the idea, but a lawyer uncle of mine shivers from the idea of "uniformity," the imposition of seemingly complete regularity in language forms, which I perceive as "crystalline essence." Well, it is something new to him and the subject comes up during breakfast on a holiday trip in Victoria, B.C. My grandmother would like to learn the language, but it gets more difficult for her to remember. My cousin likes the idea of learning French instead, but she does not really know what kind of enormous learning curve is involved in that pursuit. My father promises to learn Esperanto when he has time away from the TV. Well, at least

I have, in the city, friends who speak Esperanto, if not family members.

In the autumn of 2545 B.E., I visit Lojbanistan, the magical sanctuary of the Lojban artificial language, scientifically designed with a syntax based on predicate logic. I find its scope highly comprehensive and philosophical in nature. Like a shiny metal box with neon lights, it is beautiful in an exotic way. But it is daunting at first to learn because of its weirdness. It has some advantages over Esperanto in that it is not Eurocentric. Its vocabulary is composed of computer-generated words based on the six most popular languages of the world: Chinese, English, Hindi, Spanish, Russian, and Arabic. Another feature I like about Lojban is its repertoire of words to express emotions, rather like spoken emoticons. That feature is very cool, I think. Also, tense is

optional, so a speaker could make beautiful timeless expressions. A democratic feature of Lojban is that it is not so gender-conscious like Esperanto is. Lojban was originally designed to research the Sapir-Whorf Hypothesis, which is basically the idea that our perceptions and distinctions about the universe come from our language. I discover that quite a number of people know Lojban on the Internet. My favourite Lojban phrase is:

> mi zu vu zasti
>
> (A long time before or from now, far away, I exist, existed, will exist.)

In the summer of 2546 B.E., I experiment with Interlingua, an artificial, yet naturalistic, language with wabi-sabi aesthetics and with more resemblance to

French, Italian, Portuguese, and Spanish than does Esperanto. Millions of Romance-language speakers can easily read text of this mellifluous language with little or no knowledge of its grammar, being a kind of happy medium for Mediterranea... Compared to its source Romance languages, Interlingua has the advantage of highly simplified verb conjugations. Moreover, Interlingua uses the conventional 26 letters of the Roman alphabet without accents, a real convenience over Esperanto's 28-letter alphabet with unusual accents. Interlingua has a bit of a "Casablanca Retro" feel to it compared to Esperanto, but it has more organic irregularity compared to crystalline Esperanto. I write a poem in Interlingua:

delicatessas in
le parve pastisseria
un strata de briccas

(delicacies in
the little pastry shop
a street of bricks)

Also in the summer of 2546 B.E., I study a bit of Tibetan and Thai, and I become spellbound by their esoteric scripts, ancient as moss-laden trees. Altogether, I opine that Thai has an easier grammar than Tibetan. Then I venture into Indonesian, an islander's language written in Roman letters.

At the start of 2547 B.E., my Asiatic "mango-and-coconut-flavoured" mind swerves away from Eurocentric "cabbage-and-potatoes" Esperanto, which I have outgrown like a crimson butterfly from its once useful, viridescent chrysalis. I entertain the idea that Indonesian aka "Bahasa Indonesia"

would be a good candidate for an IAL (International Auxiliary Language). I am not too serious about the idea, but I think there is some kernel of logic there as, in fact, Indonesian is a very simple Malay-based artificial language, designed by academics, and is the official language for a multiethnic country of over 230 million inhabitants. A fantastic feature about Indonesian is its "timelessness" in that it does not have verb tenses; extra optional adverbs are used to indicate time: *"The cat eat now;" *"The cat eat yesterday," *"The cat eat tomorrow;" et cetera... *"The cat eat" is essentially timeless. This phenomenon is a trait shared by Chinese. It chimes with non-linear thinking. Also, Indonesian, unlike Esperanto, has a unisex singular third-person pronoun ('dia' or 'ia' for 'he/she'), so it is more gender-fair. Indonesian also has a comprehensive technical and scientific

vocabulary. As an added bonus, it is in the same language family, the Austronesian family, as my native Tagalog, so that many words are similar; for instance, "bunga" is a fruit in Tagalog, but a flower in Indonesian. Indonesian seems a language worth learning if not just to fantasize about being back in tropical Bali.

The following is an excerpt from an Indonesian science textbook, *Rangkuman Pengetahuan Alam Lengkap* (2540 B.E.), for Grades 4-6. Perhaps the reader can guess the meanings of some of the words:

> Benda itu terbentuk dari partikel-partikel yang sangat kecil yang disebut atom. Kita tidak dapat melihat atom karena sangat kecil. Atom itu terbentuk dari partikel-partikel yang sangat kecil.

Jenis partikel-partikel itu adalah : elektron, proton dan neutron. Elektron mempunyai muatan negatif. Proton mempunyai muatan positif. Neutron tidak mempunyai muatan (netral).

Indonesian text looks beautiful and solid. In my local university, I have found books in Indonesian on all sorts of subjects, including economics, biology, linguistics, politics, philosophy, and so forth. The potential for good reading for me definitely exists. The maturity and range of Tagalog literature sadly pales in comparison, but I hope that gets better... Tagalog has no verbal tense, but has verbal aspect, which makes for vivid narratives. Japanese has verbal tense, but in common narratives, tenses are oddly mixed unlike in Western-language narratives.

In our home kitchen, my family and I have an intense argument as to whether Tagalog has verbal tense or not. I assert that Tagalog has verbal aspect, but not verbal tense. However, both my Grandmother Lydia (slowly approaching 100 years old) and my father adamantly assert that Tagalog has verbal tense. A simple test is to translate "While they were fishing, they saw the bird" and "While they are fishing, they see the bird." Both in Tagalog would be translated to "Nang nangingisda sila, nakita nila ang ibon." Tagalog has no verbal tense. I am correct.

The current extent of Indonesian literature is also a definite advantage over Esperanto or Interlingua; however, from a linguistic engineering perspective, Esperanto does surpass Indonesian or Interlingua in terms of syntactic flexibility, morphological

regularity, and innovative expressiveness, making it suitable as a potential, valuable learning tool. By the late summer of 2548 B.E., the engineer inside me and the artist inside me reorient me towards a complex Esperantocentric universe with convenient dichotomies and satellites: Esperanto and Lojban as the veteran and the neophile; Esperanto and Interlingua as science fiction and baroque fantasy; as well as Esperanto and Indonesian as temperate cool and tropical warm.

Sometimes, I think of a language like a shoe. Some shoes fit better than others. Sometimes, I think the "English" shoe does not really fit me; it is either too tight or too loose. In other words, my mind is such that some different language might be more suitable. I do care about the fēng shuǐ of different languages. So throughout my life, I have been searching for

that elusive shoe.

I have often wondered if reforming English orthography is feasible. This idea seems possible if one were to endorse an artificial dialect standard, notably of North American brand. My attempt is called Pingk, named after the pink grapefruit. It is an entirely phonemic system which has 25 consonants and 12 vowels. The resulting text looks harsh to my eyes, though.

Intermittently throughout my life, I create conlangs, constructed languages, mainly for serious fun. This tonguemaking exercise is either linguistic engineering or glossopoetry (language poetry), depending on outlook. Out of various components from existing languages mainly from the Orient and the South Seas, but also from Africa, Native

Americas, and elsewhere, I concoct my own visions of linguistic beauty. Rarely is the result a Frankenstein. Most results are good, I am happy to say. My philosophy in conlanging revolves around the bonsai language, a language which epitomizes minimalism in phonology, vocabulary, grammar, et cetera. Vling, a tonal East Asian conlang, is my best pet project.

Meanwhile, I still browse the grammar books of different natural languages, not necessarily to learn to speak them, but to learn their sounds and structures, or their "architecture." By now, I have dozens of grammars and dictionaries of various languages around the world, including Arabic, Greek, Hindi, Lao, Swahili, Thai, Nahuatl, and many more. I envision language very much like music. Speaking and listening to English all the time would be equivalent to singing and

listening to the same kind of music all the time. I need linguadiversity. Furthermore, I find that language is so fundamental to our everyday being that it is difficult to ignore. In fact, it is fascinating!

Thinking fancifully, if I were in charge of high school curriculum, I would certainly include some of the more exotic languages as elective courses. I think such languages would stretch the minds of students, turning them into clear and flexible thinkers. I highly recommend Lojban and Esperanto for students. I would also include some aboriginal languages as electives, languages like Inuktitut (Eskimo), Cree, and Nahuatl (Aztec).

By the 2550's B.E., I am able to buy through the Web hundreds of books in French,

Spanish, Portuguese, Italian, Catalan, Japanese, Esperanto, and Interlingua. I am able to strengthen my knowledge of these languages. With Spanish and Portuguese (Brazilian) especially, I have become stronger. By November of 2554 B.E. and thereafter, I return to study Lojban and have become stronger in that language, as well. Writing practice in Tagalog since January of 2555 B.E. has made me stronger there too. I try to keep my Interlingua-Esperanto tandem learning going. (I am more interested in artificial languages than natural.)

I have come to accept by 2555 B.E. that the "noisy" aspect and "variety" aspect of the English language are factors in its attractiveness to many people. Besides, I like sci-fi in English.

(I initiated the following money article on 2012-03-27 and have expanded it since then.)

Money Woes

For many, the only true reward is monetary. How can employers reward employees other than, for the majority of the time, with money?

For many, the idea of wealth is essentially about money. It is financial. For many, wealth can only come in dollars, euros, rubles, yen, and so forth... What else could wealth be, but a number in a bank?

Is the Communists' dream of a moneyless society just a fantasy? How could a large

society implement a system where no money is used? Would a barter system work? In a barter system, would not one need to attach some kind of representative value to the object for bartering? Would not that some kind of representative value be essentially money, even if it were an electronic number in a computer? What is an economy being moneyless mean?

Maybe Communism would only work if everyone in the society were hyperintelligent. They would have to be to reach a high level of sophistication in socio-economics. Yes, what is a moneyless society?

What are other forms of wealth? There is environmental wealth. Maybe one lives in a cosy neighbourhood full of beautiful, comfortable homes. Maybe one lives near a

forest or countryside where one could take a nice stroll. There is informational wealth. Maybe one owns a gigantic set of National Geographic magazines. Maybe one knows how to speak an exotic language. Language is informational. Maybe one is an expert in tropical botany. It is information. Some cultures love information. Wealth can be having a different sense of time from everyone else. One says that truly rich people live slowly. That reason is why some cultured people promote slow food to counter fast food. There are other forms of wealth...

Other forms of wealth may include memories or experiences. Perhaps, one is wealthier because of experiences of cruising the Mediterranean, the Caribbean, and the Pacific. Maybe one has had a variety of sexual encounters. Maybe one grew up in rural Guatemala and cherishes now the

quaint memories.

For many, wealth is the accumulation of things. Maybe one has a collection of vintage toys of bygone eras. Or, one has a collection of Pacific Islander statues and masks. Whatever things one likes can be wealth.

Anyway, many people are engulfed in trying to define their level of wealth. Should they compare themselves to others? Maybe he is an Apple. She is an Orange. Should an Apple compare himself with an Orange?

Canada may be classified as a Socialistic Market Capitalist economy, more precisely, a Market Capitalist economy with slightly more Socialistic features than, say, the USA, which is also Market Capitalistic.

Market Capitalism is different from State Capitalism where the government is run like a big corporation. Market Capitalism believes in a Stock Exchange which is really a big centralized casino, the pigsty source of major insecurity in the system.

In a Socialist economy, heavy taxes are an onus of the citizen in order to pay for government services and products. In true Communism, there would be no taxes. In State Capitalism, taxes would not really make sense in the scheme of things as money becomes less of a focus and more of an exchange convenience.

According to some researchers, barter economics may date back at least 100 000 years. But no society seemed to have relied heavily on barter as non-monetary societies

relied more on gift economics and debt. In gift economics, the gifts were considered reciprocal altruism. Social status was awarded in exchange of gifts. It was like that way in the very ancient times.

Then commodity money was invented circa year -3000. Mesopotamia's shekel was originally a unit of weight of barley. Gold and silver coins were made. Shells of cowry were also commodity money in other places of the world.

Representative money was developed originally as receipts for commodity money. Paper money, bank notes, were developed in the Song Dynasty in China, the years 0960/1279.

The gold standard was developed to back

representative money. But by 1971, the USA removed the convertibility of the dollars into gold. Soon representative money around the world was unbacked by anything except the governments' fiat of legal tender and the exchangeability into goods and services.

Money became like a ghost...

And so, in modern society, the ghost that is money has become like an enslaving, poor god. It lives in a central computer...

In his book *The End of History and the Last Man*, the American political scientist Francis Fukuyama expounds that Liberal Capitalist Democracy is the end of socio-economic evolution. He thinks that it is like a dead end. He is counter to Marxists.

The USSR and PRC never implemented Communism, their eventual aim through Socialism, because Communism is supposed to not use money. Those countries were really Authoritarian State Capitalist economies where the government was run like a corporation. Private property did not exist, which was concordant with Communism at least. Communism was never really implemented in a large, nationwide scale. Maybe, one could consider to be Communists the Native Indians a long time ago, or any such peoples...

Anyway, should people believe Francis Fukuyama? Is it a dead end? Are we blue to the bone?

People today are still confused by terminology. The USSR and the PRC were

not Communists, but Authoritarian or Totalitarian State Capitalists, which are different from Democratic State Capitalists, which are different from Democratic Market Capitalists. Fukuyama's Liberal Capitalist Democracy is Democratic Market Capitalism.

Sometimes, poverty is in the mind. Some Western religions as passed on from generation to generation give virtue to living in poverty. They believe poverty exists. In Japan, poverty can be an art form, a refined state from their wabi-sabi traditions.

People have had to live in some kind of poverty. Even billionaires like Bill Gates or Queen Elizabeth experience poverty. Maybe they do not know an exotic language that they have been wanting to know. It is a poverty of the mind. Maybe their life is full

of "left-brainy" affairs, things that are not artistic, creative, or holistic. Maybe they think that their physical body does not suit them. Such are kinds of poverty.

Sometimes, poverty is in the mind.

A Tagalog Play

Kuwento sa Ibáng Planeta: Sa malayong planeta, may dalawáng araw sa bugháw na langit, si Malakás at si Magandá. Nagtanóng ang isáng anák sa kanyáng iná, "Nanay, bakit may dalawáng araw sa langit?" Sabi ng iná, "O, anóng klaseng tanóng iyán? Ilán ang matá mo? Dalawá. Ilán ang kamáy mo? Dalawá." Sumagót ang anák, "Pero, nanay, isá lamang hô ang ilóng ko..."

(A Story on Another Planet: On a faraway planet, there are two suns in the blue sky, Strong and Beauteous. A child asketh the mother, "Dearest mother, why are there two suns in the sky?" Saith the mother, "Oh, what kind of question is that? How many eyes hast thou? 'Tis two. How many hands hast thou? 'Tis two." The child respondeth, "But, mother, I have but one nose...")

My Schools

preschool	The Mount	Manila, Philippines	1970/1971
preschool	Miss Nena García's	Manila, Philippines	1971/1972
elementary	La Salle Green Hills	Manila, Philippines	1972/1976
elementary	James McKinney	Richmond, Canada	1976/1977

elementary	John T. Errington	Richmond, Canada	1977/1979
jr. high	Charles E. London	Richmond, Canada	1979/1982
sr. high	Steveston	Richmond, Canada	1982/1984
college	Langara	Vancouver, Canada	1986/1987
university	UBC	Vancouver, Canada	1984/1989

University Vines

Meanwhile my gang from high school played many games... And time passed. We (I, Ken Meiklejohn, Philip Yu Tan, Graeme Silvera, and Kevin Denny) graduated in 1984. We eventually found ourselves in the most prestigious provincial university, the University of British Columbia.

Kevin Denny did not take a language elective in high school. He ended up in another university (Simon Fraser University) that did not require a second language.

University life was a struggle to keep the gang together. We had all taken drastically different educational paths. But we tried. We carpooled together.

In 1986, the World Exposition was at Vancouver. I had an interview, but I was not accepted; however, Philip Yu Tan was hired. But in the summer of that year, I got a job at Vancouver's Pacific National Exhibition, the PNE. I was a table-wiper in a beer garden. I enjoyed it. There were a few perverts there. At lunch, I would eat a large serving of strawberry waffles with whipped cream in

the food court.

One time at the washroom of the beer garden, there was a young, darkly brown-haired man who was urinating in the urinals. He boasted how big his penis was to an older white man, also urinating, beside him. The old man left, saying, "And your father was Charlie the horse..." Then, the young white man quickly glimpsed at me as I was squeezing a squeegee or a wet rag...

Later, I obtained a good part-time job in a suburban mall as a money-changer in a spooky video game arcade, owned by a Swede, Mr. Ragnar Nilsson. And that time was when old gang friendships started drooping. There was jealousy at all corners. But we still tried to keep together. As a last hurrah for the gang, three of us, myself, Philip Yu Tan, and

Ken Meiklejohn, in 1987, vacationed in Hong Kong, then in the Philippines, specifically in Luzon Island and Cebu Island. It was great fun: eating mangoes, having siesta, walking on the beach, ballroom-dancing, going bowling, river-rafting in the rapids, doing all the sight-seeing, talking with relatives, and window-shopping.

In Hong Kong, we spent time in a huge high-rise apartment of Philip's relatives; it took up most of the whole floor. Philip's relatives, a boy and a girl, both our age, studied Japanese as it seemed popular amongst the young crowd there. One night, the girl and I went shopping together amongst the festive city lights and I bought many cheap wrist-watches, whilst the other guys, including Philip and Kenneth, played basketball, which I thought was a waste of valuable time in a foreign place. She gave me a small box

full of porcelain cats and kittens. In their apartment was a Filipina maid who did all the cooking.

In Luzon, we stayed in Metropolitan Manila; there, I sojourned at Auntie Vicky's and we visited Auntie Mila. We dined in Uncle Joe's favourite exclusive club and then we watched traditional dances with the dancers in full native costume. In Cebu, we stayed at the family estate of Philip's relatives; there was a factory that made dried mangoes there. The owners were kind, gentle, and cultured. They had a bireligious shrine to worship both the Buddha and the Santo Niño. There was a Daoist temple on top of a mountain on that island. Then back in Luzon, I separately went to Quezon City, Metropolitan Manila, to sojourn at Auntie Mila's. Together with my Uncle Joe, Auntie Mila, and cousin, I went to Pagsanjan, in which there were a

jungle river and waterfall, for river-rafting on a wooden, bamboo boat. We got all soaked, including my camera. Pagsanjan was the jungle location for the old movie Apocalypse Now, which was about the Vietnam War. Then I went off to Ibaan in Batangas province to visit Tita Bella and other relatives. In Batangas, Tita Bella, my cousins, and I had a beach excursion to the little Lugpô Island. Whilst all those happenings, Philip and Kenneth went to some other island, probably Bohol Island.

As the last leg of our trip, I, Philip, and Kenneth stopped over in Narita Airport near Tōkyō, Japan. We then took a day-trip to Akihabara, the electronics district of Tōkyō. It was actually my first time in Japan that went beyond the airport.

During all that vacation time, Graeme Silvera had gone to visit his native Jamaica.

Later in university, my gang from high school had begun to separate and make new connections. And it was a new life for all of us.

In Chemical Engineering classes, I was a friend of David Ho, a Hong Kong Chinese, who eventually switched to Economics and ended up in Real Estate as a career. In those engineering classes, I also knew Michael Meszaros, a pimple-faced Hungarian-Canadian who was a religious proselytizer. Another was a carpool buddy, Goffrey Gosonhing, a big Chinese-Filipino whom I knew from high school English 11 class.

David Ho had a strange Cantonese accent.

His English syntax reflected his Chineseness. For example, he would describe "a person wearing a blue jacket" as simply "blue jacket guy." Someone in several of our Chemical Engineering classes had the surname Ng. David told me how to pronounce it. It was all a pure nasal without any vowel. I said, "That's not a word!" He turned to other Chinese classmates and said, "He is making fun of it!" Then one of them said to me, "You look like an Indian..." I was not sure if he meant "East Indian" or "Native Indian."

David often wanted my advice on English grammar. He found it to be a difficult language.

David lived in an impressive family home which was of the Tudor style in the wealthy Shaughnessy area in Vancouver. He had

many brothers and sisters. He was the first to introduce me to an IBM PC, which I thought at first was a strange machine because I was so accustomed to Apple machines. The family had a white, long-haired, roundish cat with bright blue eyes. Its name was something like "Mou-mou."

Esperanto...

Mia unuajara universitata Anglalingva kurso, «English 100», estis interesa. Mi havis junan blankhaŭtan profesorinon, brunharan, sed preskaŭ blondharan. En unu el miaj eseoj, mi uzis kelkajn vortojn, ne tro ekzotikajn, kiel «goodliness» kaj aliajn, pri kiuj ŝi indikis sur mian paperon, ke ili ne ekzistis en la lingvo. Poste, mi skribis citaĵojn el kelkaj vortaroj pri ilia ekzisto kaj donis al ŝi. Eble ŝi surpriziĝis. Ŝi legigis al

la studentoj oldajn romanojn, kiel unu libron de la Polo, Joseph Conrad. Tiuj estis tro longaj kaj enuigaj, ke mi legis nur la ĉefajn partojn. La studentoj verkis multe. Unu el miaj eseoj traktis Bizancan perspektivon de la Kristana religio, kio estis interese. Unu sunbrilan tagon, la profesorino decidis marŝi kun mi laŭ la arboplena ĉefa avenuo de la universitato. Pri tio, mi pensis iom stranga...

In my high school English classes, I had the highest grades of all the students. Amazingly, I did not pass the ECT, the English Composition Test, in university the first time. I had to retake it and passed the second time. My guess was that my writing sounded too foreign and unconventional to the marker, or that my surname sounded very non-English, or that maybe I was just too nervous and I liked to take my own sweet

time to write anything. Goffrey Gosonhing reported this event to Ms. F. Raber, my favourite Jewish English teacher, on a visit to our high school. They knew that I was like a foreigner...

In university, there was also another interesting fellow, Pham, who was from Vietnam. He always carried a yellowish canvas bag. He had a funny accent and seemed a very intelligent student in my Chemical Engineering classes. I did not know why, but Philip Yu Tan was wary of him...

Esperanto...

Baldaŭ, Philip Yu Tan havis novan amikinon Viviana kun oranĝe tinkturita hararo. Ŝi, Ĉinino, estis lia unua reala amantino.

At the UBC Aquatic Centre, Kenneth Meiklejohn, Philip Yu Tan, and I tried some dangerous stunts. We all took turns diving into the swimming pool below from a very, very high diving board, which must have been several metres from the ground. Looking down was very scary. It was Philip who coaxed the other two of us into this crazy peril. Much later, I heard that Philip would try skydiving from an airplane. That rumour was from a high school classmate Behzad Shroff, who also tried it.

Khalid Al-Skait was a handsome "sheik" from Saudi Arabia. In and out of UBC, he became a good friend of mine. One day, we spontaneously decided to hike up Black Tusk Mountain, whilst he had leather shoes on. It must have been still spring season because

once we made it all the way to much higher elevations, there was still snow on the ground. Khalid lived in an apartment near the planetarium at Vanier Park in Vancouver.

Esperanto...

Iam, en unu el miaj laboratoriaj klasoj en Kemia Inĝenierarto, ni studentoj eksperimentis. Laboratoria asistentino, kiu estis Mandaren-parolanta alta svelta longhara Ĉinino, diris al mi, «Pensu!». Mia vizaĝo eble montris tro da kalmo antaŭ tiu averto, kvazaŭ mi meditis. Kaj la aliaj studentoj ŝajnis ekscitataj tiam.

I did take Chemical Engineering, but I really wanted to take Bio-resource Engineering, which dealt with anything combining

engineering and biology, such as fish-farming, artificial body parts, hydroponics, et cetera. The course was looked down upon by other engineering students who thought it was the easiest course amongst all the engineering courses, including Engineering Physics, Electronic Engineering, Mechanical Engineering, and others. Most thought that Engineering Physics was the most difficult. It was too bad because Bio-resource Engineering was really interesting and there was much camaraderie in that group. They had all to themselves a little barn-like clubhouse near the vast peripheral parking lot.

Esperanto...

Unu bio-inĝeniera studento estis Vuk, kiu estis nigrahara blankhaŭta belulo. Li estis amikema. Mi kelkfoje renkontis lin en la

Akva Centro. Li ŝatis uzi la saŭnon.

My friend David Ho started out in Carnegie Mellon University in Pennsylvania, then transferred to UBC. Telling me how good it was at Carnegie Mellon, he persistently criticized UBC, but I was not sure of the objectivity of his statements.

I, later, switched to Computer Science in UBC. My grades were not outstanding in Chemical Engineering because during examination time, a fire partially destroyed my home. It was December of 1985... My parents' friends, Charlie Ang and his wife, were visiting my family then. His wife accidentally put a live cigarette into the wastebasket in one of the bedrooms. Charlie was a strange man, a Chinese-Filipino, with a business selling antiques like wooden cherubim. Whilst I was

studying for examinations, he distracted me about bizarre occult matters, affairs of magic and the supernatural...

Subsequently, I took a French course from Langara College. I did it all remotely without an instructor. It was all self-study and the actual study time for it was minimal, so it freed up my schedule for studying my other courses at UBC. I went to Langara College just for the few examinations. I then transferred the credits to UBC. I also took Assembly Language, a low-level computer language, from Langara College, but it was not to my liking. Assembly Language was more difficult than higher-level computer languages, I thought, especially if it involved an old mainframe system.

Back at UBC, in Computer Science, I fraternized with Steve Kwong and Glen Lee, who were both Hongkongese-Canadians whose home language was Cantonese. Steve was an ice hockey player and a fan of the Japanesque; he studied both Japanese and Mandarin as language electives. Glen was a chubby, gentle guy, who was adept at badminton and liked the French language.

Glen and I had a mutual friend, Lance Colins, who was a tall, slim black from the Caribbean and had impressive, advanced mathematical abilities. He often haunted the ancient, ivy-covered math buildings on campus and befriended eccentric math professors. I sometimes ate lunch with Lance at the University Village where there was a comfortable well-established Chinese restaurant. It was peculiar that he often could not finish his large serving of chow

mein. He mentioned to me more than once that he thought that it was peculiar that many East Indians wanted to look like Italians or that they changed their names to sound Italian. That comment probably had a subliminal message...

There was a Japanese professor named Dr. Kanda at Computer Science. He always seemed to look as if he were drowsy. Lance mentioned, perhaps jokingly, that the professor might have been under the influence of drugs. A few times, Dr. Kanda wrote Kanji on the blackboard as a sort of joke. Perhaps, only Chinese students could at least partially read it. Dr. Kanda's class involved very difficult mathematics related to Computer Science.

One time, there were visiting industrialists

from Japan. They talked about Japan's Fifth Generation Computer Systems project in front of some students and professors. The visitors seemed somewhat secretive.

Esperanto...

Mi havis multajn profesorojn en Komputila Scienco en UBC. Doktorino Moyra Ditchfield, mia instruistino pri la komputila lingvo Pascal, rememorigis min pri Ripley, la stelulino Sigourney Weaver, kiu estis la forta alta protagonisto en la sciencfikcia filmserio Alien. En UBC, Doktoro David Poole estis bela viro el Aŭstralio. Li instruis pri la komputila lingvo Lisp uzata en esploroj pri Artefarita Inteligenteco.

Karim Badrudin Dewsi was my friend who was an Ishmaili East Indian from East

Africa. We did some assignments together. One time whilst we were having lunch together in a classroom, two Cantonese students were talking too loud to each other in their native tongue. Karim shouted at them in order to silence them. That classroom was almost empty except for us. Perhaps the sound of their language was not to Karim's liking, or else he was jealous of their language, or else they were plainly talking too loud.

Grace Al-Khoury was a Lebanese girl with whom I also did assignments. She asked me things like how does one say "Thank you" in Japanese.

Glen had a buddy, Michael Sam, a Hongkongese-Canadian who was a real dwarf. I got angry at Michael because he did

not seem to take his share of the workload for one of our projects. I thought that my altercation with him irritated Glen, who lived in Sam's neighbourhood. Anyway, Steve, Glen, and I became my new core gang in university. We did all our major projects together on Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Computer-gaming. It was tough, but it was fun. I learnt many higher-level computer languages, including Lisp, Pascal, Modula-2, FORTRAN, Prolog, and C. Our machines were IBM PC compatibles, Apple Macintoshes, UNIX workstations, and the campus mainframe.

Esperanto...

Steve kaj mi havis Indoneziajn geamikojn, ĝentilajn gefratojn Susana kaj Marcel Sutanto. Ili estis palhaŭtaj kaj Ĉinaspektaj.

Marcel estis en la fako de Komputila Scienco. Mi, Marcel, kaj Steve ofte ekzercis en la ekzercejo apud la universitata naĝejo. Ambaŭ Marcel kaj Susana havis fortan ŝtonan akcenton kiam ili parolis Angle.

All through our UBC days, my elder brother and I timeshared a brand-new, small, Korean automobile, a yellow Hyundai Pony, which my parents financed. It was an economical vehicle. That time, the Korean automobile industry was still at its infancy.

I had some interesting university summer jobs, which required very minimal supervision. I credited these part-time jobs partly to jolly Dr. Vince Manis, a rotund black-haired white man, who was part of the selection committee.

One summer, I worked for a Vietnamese professor, Dr. Son Vuong. He had a shaved head and looked like a Buddhist monk in a suit. The job entailed a special computer communications language, called Estelle; I continued the work previously done by Isaac Chan, a Hongkongese-Canadian, who would reappear during my later career.

Another summer, I worked for an East Indian professor on parallel computing and multiprocessors. It was a difficult undertaking. The professor's name was Dr. Clarence de Silva. I wondered why it was that he had a Latinate name. Perhaps, he was from Goa in India. He was an East Indian, definitely.

Esperanto...

Kiam mi laboris por Doktoro de Silva, mi uzis grandan ĉambron en la Konstruaĵo de Mekanika Inĝenierarto. Tie troviĝis ankaŭ mia amikema kunulo, pli aĝa Ĉino, Mandaren-parolanto, certe el Ĉinujo mem. Li nomis sin Jimmy C. Yang de la Laboratorio de Industria Aŭtomatigo de la Departemento de Mekanika Inĝenierarto. Dum mia esploro, mi legis paperojn, inkluzive de tiuj, kiuj havis Japanaĵojn pri robotoj.

Dum someroj, mi ofte vizitis la urbocentron en Vankuvero per la flava Hyundai Pony. Tie mi esploris la librovendejojn, ĉefe sur la strato Granville, kie estis plene da pornografio. Iam mi forgese ŝlosis la aŭtomobilon kune kun la ŝlosiloj ene de tiu. Mi iris al librovendejo. Poste, mi revenis al la aŭtomobilo. Subite mi ekkonstatis. Mi devis voki teknikiston por malfermi la

pordon per speciala ilo. Malfeliĉe, tiu brunhara blankulo preterpagigis min.

Fojfoje, mi vizitis la straton Robson, la ŝikan distrikton kun multaj alilandaj restoracioj, galanterioj, kaj vendejoj. Tiam ekzistis multekosta altgrada desertejo Le Milieu.

Dum kelkaj varmegaj tagoj, mi provis nudismon sur la plaĝo Wreck apud la universitato. Estis tre liberiga sperto.

Wreck Beach during the lazy days of summer was full of nudists. Only relatively healthy people could reach it as the forested paths going steeply down to the sands were quite treacherous. At the sands, one might see a wandering, handsome, tanned nudist selling cans of beer. Between the logs on the hot sands, nudists would be lying on their towels.

A heat wave would distort the field of view as if the air were crinkling. Some nudists could not help to express their sexuality in the bushes...

When it was not summer, in university, I obtained part-time work shelving books in the ancient Main Library, which looked like a stone castle. That time was a relaxing job.

I enjoyed life in the university campus where there was a mishmash of different architectural styles from different periods. I used to hike all over the place. I haunted the libraries: Sedgewick, Main, Biomedical, and Math. I was fond of the postmodern Asian Library where I could peruse especially box-wrapped Japanese books, odd-looking books with Indic scripts, and Indonesian science texts. A few times, I visited the Museum of

Anthropology and the Japanese Gardens. I trekked along nudist Wreck Beach where there were old garrisons from World War II. I sometimes ate at the Student Union Building, the SUB, where there was a video game arcade in the basement. But usually for lunch, I would find a secluded place to eat, like an empty engineering draughting classroom or an empty math room with old wooden chairs or one of the empty high-ceiling rooms of the airy Old Computer Science building. I often munched on giant cinnamon rolls or Chinese pork buns and curried beef buns. The Aquatic Centre was where I often waded and swam in the shallow parts of the swimming pool; I pretended that I was a manta ray. I relaxed in the bubbling Jacuzzi and in the steamy sauna there.

Moma...

:: Wan taim in da Akwatik Senter, a yang wait man expozd himself neiked in da shalow pul. Den in da men'z shawer rum anoder taim, a yang Chainiz man had a konspikiuwus erekshon wail oder neiked men wer shawering. In diz pleisez, men had tu lern tu kontrol deir erekshonz. Samtaimz, ai did nat wer kontakt lensez, so wan taim ai enterd da wimin'z shawer rum bai misteik. Da yuniversiti waz ful ov yang pipol... ::

There was a museum in the lobby of the modernistic Geology building. I had rare occasions going to the remote Law building and the ancient-looking, Victorian-era-style Theological building. The 1960's-looking cubistic Buchanan buildings were where many of my Art (Humanities) classes were

held.

Moma...

:: Ai ofen went tu da Saund Laibreri ov :: Sedgewick :: Laibreri in UBC. In der wer meni lisening buts wid hedfons. Meni ov da rekord disks tu wich ai lisend delt wid experimental en etnik miuzik or powetri, inkluding rekordingz ov :: Nahuatl :: or Aztek verses. Der wer sam elektronik miuzik az wel. ::

My favourite subjects in UBC included my Artificial Intelligence courses, which involved creating games and "expert systems" using interesting and beautiful computer languages such as Prolog and Lisp. I also liked my human language courses in Spanish and Japanese. For Spanish, my

professor was a stubby, black-haired, almond-skinned Peruvian, Dr. Antonio Urello, who, I imagine, might have had some Incan blood; he was perhaps a mestizo and not a pure Spaniard. He told the class that his fellow-countrymen roasted cavies as delicacies back in Peru. I initially learnt to speak Spanish with a South American accent. One time, Dr. Urello was not able to be in the class and we had a substitute instructor, who had a rugged complexion. He marvelled at my accent in Spanish as though it were my mother tongue. (In the very beginning of the Spanish course, I was in a different class with a woman professor whose mother language was Portuguese, not Spanish. I detected a strange accent. There was at that class a Chinese girl who was already flirting with me. Because of rearranging my schedule, I had to switch to Dr. Urello's class.) In Japanese class, my

professor was Dr. Kramer, a funny, white, brown-haired American who had for some time lived in Japan and had a love-hate relationship with his adopted language. His teaching assistant was also a white man, who had long blond hair; being the son of a missionary, he grew up in Japan. (His name was something like "Brent.") He had mastered even Japanese body language, like different kinds of bows for all occasions. Some of the girls in the Japanese class were amazed at my calligraphy of Kanji on the blackboard exercises as if it were already natural to me even then. Dr. Kramer marvelled at my seemingly genuine Japanese accent as if the sounds were so natural to me. I am like a parrot actor.

I found in the stacks of the ancient Main Library some plays and such written long ago in Esperanto. I only considered them a

curiosity at the time. The idea of an artificial language created a century ago intrigued me. My interest in artificial languages continued since my high school days when, in the Richmond Public Library, I discovered a captivating Esperanto comic strip in Heavy Metal magazine; it depicted soldiers speaking the language. Also from the same place, there was a book called Teach Yourself Esperanto. I told myself that someday I would really try to learn that language. In UBC, I found other intriguing constructed languages, including BABM, pronounced **/bɔ.ʔɑː.bɔ.mu/**, created by a Japanese man, Rikichi (Fuishiki) Okamoto (1885/1963). He first published a book about the language in 1962.

I graduated from university in 1989. Sometimes, I wish I had gone further to graduate study.

Being curiouser, I started taking extracurricular sport and art classes in the community to expand my horizons. I took a creativity class of combined poetry, sketching, and martial arts in Richmond. Then I took tennis lessons in Richmond. There, I met this peppy girl from Ireland, Deborah Manning, who stayed over in Canada as a nanny. She had a funny accent. She had dark reddish brown hair. Evidently, she was looking for a soul mate. She was not too successful in her short stay and would eventually go back to Ireland. I tried telephoning her at where she was staying in Richmond and the house lady said that Deborah was not present then and was intending to return to Ireland soon. Maybe, she was upset. She hinted that I was more interested in "Eastern ladies" when she noticed my stares at Chinese women on the tennis courts. There was this matchmaker

East Indian lady Tara Sammy from Trinidad who liaised betwixt the two of us. One time, Deborah winsomely told me that I had a "violent streak" and she was correct. After tennis lessons, I took an eight-week, two-days-a-week Cantonese language class in Vancouver at a time when I was fond of wearing black clothes as was the fashion then.

At that time, I had a vintage yellow Volkswagen Beetle. It was the second car that I used, but it was the first car which I bought with my own money. The brakes were not good and one time I almost died; there was a close collision near a bridge.

Esperanto...

Dum miaj universitataj jaroj kaj post ili, la

favorita restoracio de mia familio estis Estía, kiu estis bona Greka restoracio en Vankuvero. Tie troviĝis granda bufedo. Ni ĝuis.

Wandering to Distant Lands

I found travelling fun, but the experiences were too ethereal, effervescent, and ephemeral. There was no lasting physical change in the environment as one had to go back home eventually. One was left only with photographs and memories. I decided much later that there was a more permanent way to enjoy living "outside" and that way was by learning a different language.

My home was in Canada, but I travelled

quite a bit. I travelled intermittently to the United States: Washington, Oregon, California, Nevada, and New York. In 1987, I visited the Philippines and Hong Kong. At Christmas time in 1991, I went to Egypt. In September of 1992, I went to Cancún, Mexico.

In 1992, I visited Japan several times for work assignment. I moved to Japan in 1993 to work on a "permanent" basis and to enjoy living in that "Disneylandish" country, then eventually came back to North America in 1994. My passport was stamped with at least nine entries into Japan. I also visited South Korea in July of 1993, where I shopped for masks at H'aewon Street in Seoul.

In May of 1995, I went to France and the Netherlands. I passed through Belgium by train; on the way was a lot of graffiti. At

this time, I did not thoroughly enjoy Europe because I was unprepared for the trip and decided on going too spontaneously and capriciously. It was as if I were attempting to "run away" from Canada. But that time, I somewhat did enjoy Amsterdam with its magnificent canals and Germanic surroundings. I met a bearded Egyptian at Hotel Kabul and told him that I once visited his native country. In Amsterdam, I saw that Indonesian restaurants were quite common. (Indonesia was a Dutch colony.) In Paris, I took pictures of the Eiffel Tower at various, multitudinous angles. One of my hotel rooms in that city was very heavily perfumed and had an excellent baignoire for bathing. Looking for accomodations on the spot was difficult. I initially landed in a much cheaper accomodation with no shower. I was taking then medicine which made me drowsy and groggy. At a pizza stand, the

French vendor asked, "Do you speak English?" I did not feel totally safe with that backpacking experience. I experienced culture shock then as I saw so many antiquated organic buildings.

During the winter of 1995-1996, I revisited the Philippines and visited Thailand. In November of 1998, I went to Spain, Portugal, and Morocco. Although I was more looking forward to seeing Morocco than Spain and Portugal before I left, I thoroughly enjoyed Spain and Portugal when I got there because of the beautiful architecture and the rugged people.

I would remember when, in Madrid, I browsed a bookstore. On the upper deck, there was a selection of sci-fi books in Spanish. One of the novels I really liked. It

was Un mundo feliz by Aldous Huxley. It was the translation of the book Brave New World, which I read in high school. Well, later, I instead decided to buy the classic and famous Don Quijote de la Mancha by Miguel de Cervantes Saavedra. At the checkout counter, there were two brown-haired Spanish women. One of them seemed disappointed by my selection. I suspected that they were monitoring by video camera. Probably, they thought that I was a Mexican, or even a Japanese. Indeed, sci-fi books were for the young and intelligent...

In Madrid, I went to a café bar. There, from a handsome, young, black-haired bartender, I ordered "Coke!" to which he replied with a question, "¿Coca-Cola?" I said, "¡Sí!" (Yes!). Smiling, he gave me the drink. I was wearing my green camouflage army jacket and my green camouflage army hat. He then

asked, "¿De dónde vienes?" (From where do you come?), to which I replied, "¡Cánada!" Then, still smiling, he corrected me by saying, "¡Canadá!" As I left the premises, he winked at me... I was feeling somewhat "inebriated" because I was not taking my medicine for supposed "schizophrenia."

In Madrid, another time, I went to a grocery. I browsed a box of cherimoyas (Annona cherimola), fruits native to the Andes in South America. Then a young lady grocer with dark brown hair came to inspect my pick, and said gently, "¡Blando!" I was not sure what she meant by that Spanish word. I tried a French word with her by saying "Molle!" (Soft!), to which she responded, "¡Sí!" Then she looked for firmer ones. Then after buying, I went back to my hotel room...

In Spain, most people had black or dark brown hair. As people would pass by, they would say "¡Hola!" A complete stranger walked up to me and said in rapid "machine gun" Spanish that it was a waste of fuel to travel on airplanes. I just gently said, "¡No comprendo!" (I do not understand). Probably, he thought that I was from a poor country in Latin America or the Philippines. Maybe my green outfit made him think that I supported the Green Party...

In Salamanca in Spain, I ventured in the night through the stony architecture of that university town. The place was full fantasy. A group of black-haired students shouted cheerfully in the distance, "Charlie! Charlie!" They wanted to talk to me, I suppose...

In Torremolinos by the Mediterranean Sea, I often promenaded after midnight during strange, dimly lit hours. Usually, there were only a few people walking around then. One whom I saw looked like a Mexican. The beach was very quiet in the silent darkness. Up on the slope, I joyfully photographed a white-marble-encased, green-gated door that had the phrase "Jardín de las Mercedes II" (Garden of the Mercies II) and the number "28" above it. The lavish, quiet nighttime spectacle seemed in my imagination like a subliminal advertisement for Esperanto...

I actually travelled with my family. Our tour guide throughout the trip was Isabel Vergara, an elegant, multilingual, svelte Spanish woman with dark brown hair. It seemed as though she spoke to our bus driver Mário in Spanish and Mário replied in Portuguese as he was from the neighbouring

country. Otherwise, they spoke in a mixture of both languages and managed to understand each other. In Spain, we travelled through the cities of Madrid, Córdoba, Granada, Costa del Sol, Sevilla, and Salamanca. Our tour group comprised mostly Anglo-Saxons, but we were in close affiliation with a rebellious Filipino family from the East Coast of the USA; one of them, a Filipina, had her eyebrows tatooed on her face. These Filipinos were so rebellious that when Isabel pre-announced that no one should eat ice cream on the bus, they went ahead and did just that which the tour guide prohibited. There were a few other Asians too, including Vietnamese and Koreans.

We crossed the Strait of Gibraltar into Morocco in North Africa. We toured several cities including Fès, Marrakech, Casablanca,

Rabat, and Tanger. The environment was a bit like Southern California with all the palm trees, deserts, and such, but of course, the culture was markedly different. The inner part of each city was called the medina, where the structures were ancient and some people still rode donkeys. But in Casablanca, there were plenty of modern Bauhaus buildings. Part of the way through the long desert drive in the bus, we watched the Hollywood classic *Casablanca* (1942), but I fell asleep through most of it. In Marrakech, the avenues were wide and lined with trees. Besides Arabic and Berber languages, many spoke French in this country. The people were mostly olive-skinned, black-haired Mediterranean Caucasoids, but here and there, one would see a few Negroids. Indeed, some people were mulattos, part-Caucasoid and part-Negroid. Moroccans were quick to show aggression.

Jealous teenagers would spit by a nearby busload of Western tourists. In a medina, a robe-wearing lady vendor waved a knife by a passing Anglo-Saxon lady who belonged to our tour group and photographed the Moroccan lady. But when I passed by that vendor and took a picture, she did not do anything. I looked a bit brownish, or non-Western, or male...

Another country was Portugal, back in Western Europe. Again, the architecture was superb. One imposing structure was red in colour and had onion tops like the Kremlin. Lisboa—Lisbon—was very comfortable for me as I walked around the brick-laden streets, where one should really watch one's step for a brick sticking out! Lisboa was full of immigrants from ex-Portuguese colonies. Especially conspicuous were Negroids from Africa and Brazil. One black man

approached me, then asked something in rapid Portuguese, to which I responded, "Não falo português..." (I do not speak Portuguese). The black man retorted in surprise, "Não?" (No?). Most Portuguese just looked like Spanish people. I felt like taking the Metro to see other places, but we sojourned in that city for only a wee while. I investigated a couple of bookstores and was amazed at the selection of Portuguese-language books, even technical books; there existed some computer programming textbooks translated into Portuguese. Portugal was the third country of our Iberia-Morocco 1998 tour.

In February and March of 1999, I visited Singapore and Bali, Indonesia. In April and May of 2000, I toured the Vatican, Italy, Austria, Germany, Liechtenstein, Switzerland, France, and Britain. This time, I thoroughly enjoyed Europe, probably

because of my light-hearted exposure at home to Esperanto, a sort of cultural appreciation.

I, with my family, travelled through Europe on a tour bus group, comprising many Australians, and a few Canadians and Americans, so these people were mostly Anglo-Saxons. Maria, a woman with dirty blonde hair, was our tour guide, who had a British accent.

Italy was our first stop. We landed in Roma, then we toured the major touristy areas, such as the Colosseum, the Catacombs, the Vatican, et cetera. We had a chance to use the Metro a little bit, there in a train to witness a handsome guitar player playing some snappy Latin music. Most people in Italy had black or dark brown hair. Then by our tour bus,

off we went to Firenze to see more antique buildings. At some point in the trip, whilst I was buying a small doll as a gift for my niece, the handsome vendor gave me a selection of one plainer doll at a lower price, and another doll with an Italian-flag design at a higher price. I chose the latter. But when he turned around to get a box, he said in Italian, "Stupido!" I suppose that he was dissuading me from buying for whatever reason; perhaps he was gay or was just being philosophical. Another city stop was Venezia, there to marvel at the labyrinthine canals and intertwining streets amongst majestic edifices. Whilst I, wearing a purple T-shirt, rested in some ancient corner, three French teenagers, wearing what looked like heavy jackets, stood by for a few minutes. Then about to leave, one of them said in French, "Tu es un goût!" (You are a taste!). Along the country roads were vast fields full

of yellow canola flowers.

A very memorable country stop was Austria, a German-speaking land. The architecture in Wien—Vienna—was wonderful and medieval. The many sushi restaurants all over the city surprised me. Near Wien, we sojourned in the quaint town of Baden, in a hotel called Schloss Weikersdorf. Baden reminded me of the Hobbits' Shire in the fantasy writer J.R.R. Tolkien's Middle Earth. Then off to Salzburg, the birthplace of Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756-1791), we went. It was a beautiful, quaint town by a river. Then to the mountain-encircled town of Innsbruck we went. Everywhere in this country, as in much of Europe, was well-preserved ancient architecture. Near Innsbruck, we actually stayed in the mountain village of Igls, there to witness some kind of festival involving wooden logs. At

Igls, in Hotel Bon Alpina, we had the best accommodations—a wide, spacious room with the view of snow-capped mountains. There was a rustic cemetery in a spooky churchyard. At some point in our Austrian excursion, we ate roasted pork at a traditional restaurant. There, we all obligatorily danced a little, feeling a bit awkward as if we were forced into "having fun." One of the dances involved almost squatting on the floor with each of our arms intertwined with the shoulders of another whilst our legs alternatively kicked to and fro. The interesting part of the dinner was when an Australian lady at our table recounted a story about her daughter learning Indonesian. Apparently, Indonesian was a popular language in high schools in Australia.

At some point from Innsbruck, we

reconnoitred into German territory to see the town of Oberammergau and the nearby castle Schloss Linderhof.

From Austria, we snaked the highways and ended up in the town of Vaduz in Liechtenstein. It was regrettable and unfortunate that I did not have a picture taken of myself there in what was one of the smallest countries in Europe, or the world at large.

From Liechtenstein, we found ourselves in Luzern in Switzerland. Yet more glamorous architectures were there. There were four official languages in Switzerland, the intersection of Europe. Luzern felt cool and relaxing.

Then we went farther to Paris in France,

there to see a cabaret at La Nouvelle Ève and visit the Eiffel Tower, which at that time had the alphanumerical sign in light—"An 2000"—Year 2000. A beautiful stop was the Palace of Versailles, where I meditatively sipped crème de menthe at a nearby café.

Through the Chunnel, we crossed the Channel to England. A funny memorable thing was when we passed by a sign which said "1 m" to some place. In most of the world, "1 m" meant 1 metre, but there it meant 1 mile. The usual abbreviation for mile was really "mi." All of mainland Europe was metric. Britain was still undergoing a switch to metric, and their road signs were still using the archaic system. In London, we rode the Metro a bit too. And I had the best fish and chips with vinegar and a can of Dr. Pepper in an area called Barbican. Instead of going to see the

Stonehenge, we decided to tour the city of London, which ended our Europe 2000 tour.

During the winter of 2001-2002, I revisited the Philippines. In May of 2002, I toured Greece and a bit of Turkey. That time, I had more of the Volapük language on my mind, but carried an Esperanto dictionary for browsing throughout the trip. I encountered a dark-haired Dutch girl wearing an Esperanto T-shirt in the ruins of Olympia. She said to me, "Ni estas tendumantoj" (We are campers), but I did not know that word "tendumanto" then; I realized that my Esperanto vocabulary needed upgrading indeed.

In Greece that time, we hopped by cruise from one island to another in the azure sea. On Patmos, one of the islands, we failed to

land because there was a little collision between our ship and another. The islands were full of white-washed stone buildings, seemingly more Asiatic than European. A regrettable event was when I did not bring my camera when I walked through labyrinthine streets to serendipitously arrive at an ancient synagogue—a Jewish temple. On the Greek mainland, the most memorable location was Meteora, a place full of escarpments and mountains, on top of which were various monasteries. In one of the monasteries, at the cashier's, we met an Australian brunette girl who told us that when she came to Greece, she intended the trip as merely a vacation. But then she decided to stay, learn Greek, live in Greece, and become a nun there at her chosen monastery.

All over Greece, I was taking photographs of

town settings with the intention of using them later to publicize the Volapük language on the Web. The Greeks were an outgoing people with a propensity to talk to strangers. Their skin colour was what people usually called "olive-skinned"; some had more of a mocha tone. Most people had black or dark brown hair, although I saw a few blondes. Of course, the peoples of Europe had been mixing since ancient times. Probably, in the ancient times, hair colour was a mark of one's perceived "race," but one knew in modern times that such was only the effect of varying pigmentation.

Thassos, a tall, brown-haired man, was our Greek tour guide throughout our trip of a group consisting mostly of Anglo-Saxons. Thassos, who was somewhat arrogant, had a British accent. He said that Greeks, who learnt English, learnt their accent, whether

British or American, primarily from their teachers. In Greece, ordinary people really did not speak English. There were some Filipinos who resided almost or seemingly permanently in Greece. Of course, they had to learn Greek.

In one city in Greece, I looked for books for learning Greek in a bookstore. But the handsome dark-haired vendor dissuaded me and told me that I should look for a person to teach me Greek. He insinuated that it would be the best way. Anyway, I rummaged through the bookstores for poetry books in Greek.

Everywhere in Europe were the Gypsies, nomads who entered the continent centuries ago from India, and many of them still spoke an East Indian language amongst themselves.

European society often marginalized the Gypsies, so many of them turned to criminal activites to survive. This sentiment in Europe would pop up often when discussing about the future of India; Europeans would underestimate the intelligence of these darker-complexioned peoples. The Gypsies would pop up discretely playing guitar in tourist areas, or cajoling travellers to buy roses, or doing other activities of that sort.

My fourth revisit to the Philippines was in August and September of 2003. Then, I carried a French translation of the sci-fi novel called *Triton* by Samuel R. Delany for reading in Ibaan, Batangas, where I stayed. It seemed as though that there had been a lot of changes in my homeland. Don José Heights in Quezon City was now full of houses and tall green trees. Looking down from the cliff behind my old house, which still looked the

same but was a little rougher than in the 1970's, was a wet market where some underprivileged people lived. All gone were the vast, uninhabited, yellow-green, knee-high grassy fields. The soil was no longer red, but more ruddy brown. The trees now thoroughly covered the view of the distant mountain range. Manila was now full of tall buildings of the Bauhaus style prevalent in all major cities of the world. Commonwealth Avenue, which led to my old home, was now six lanes on each side, but was only a single lane on each side back in the 1970's. I felt like a time-traveller.

My third voyage to Paris, France, was in June of 2004. At that time, I was learning Indonesian in the hotel because I wanted to read Harry Potter books in Indonesian. Then was my most intense trip to Europe, as if time had slowed down indeed.

In Search of the Pharaohs

[1991-12-21/1992-01-04]

[1991-12-21] I joined a group tour to Egypt. It was a small friendly group. We flew from Canada and arrived in Cairo the following day.

[1991-12-22] In Cairo from the airport, our bus snaked through the city at night. The most interesting thing I remembered was the blazing neon-lit signs in squiggly Arabic. We made it to our hotel for dinner.

[1991-12-23] We had a full day's sightseeing at the Great Pyramids, Sphinx, Memphis, and Saqqara. The sky was not its

usual crispy blue, but tinted grey. Nevertheless, seeing these sites was a quasi-religious experience. There were vendors at the Pyramids selling stone scarab beetle ornaments.

[1991-12-24] In the morning, we had a tour of the Egyptian Museum, which included the glorious treasure of King Tut. Then we toured the mosques. After a free afternoon, we boarded an air-conditioned sleeper train for our overnight journey to Luxor in the south. I joined the Theessen family, who were a couple with their two tall teenage daughters, for a little Christmas celebration in one of the smoke-smelling compartments.

[1991-12-25] It was my fondest memories of Christmas in Luxor. We stayed at a hotel by the Nile. I could sit poolside with a view of

the lily-filled river whilst classical music would be blaring from the pool deck sound system. I could remember that most of the tourists there were French. It was a grand buffet for dinner. I could remember a tall "Christmas Tree" made of cream-puffs.

[1991-12-26] We rode by caleesh, a horse-drawn carriage, under crispy blue sky to the incredible temple of Karnak, an enormous religious site. I walked around the town of Luxor. The atmosphere was very rustic and Arabic. One had to haggle in the markets for souvenir items. (The vendors learnt even bits of German and French.) People were so friendly when they wanted to sell someone something... I became friendly with the foursome Lee family, who were a couple with a daughter (in her twenties) and her aunt. Mrs. Lee lent me her books about Egypt.

[1991-12-27] We had a two-hour donkey ride through the dangerous narrow paths in mountains leading to the Valley of the Kings. A taxi ride would have taken 15 minutes. From up on top, I could see where the desert and the green parts nourished by the Nile met, an incredibly distinct demarcation. At the Valley, we had a guided tour of King Tut's tomb, as well as other pharaohs' tombs.

[1991-12-28] We had a free day at Luxor for more souvenir-hunting. I haggled for statuettes of Egyptian gods and hieroglyphic scribblings on papyrus.

[1991-12-29] We left Luxor and headed for Aswan by bus. Along the way, we visited the Kom Ombo Temple where ancients worshipped the Crocodile God. Again, the

sky was crispy blue. Then we made it to the Edfu Temple, home of the Falcon God, Horus.

[1991-12-30] We drove deep into the desert coming to within 50 km of the Sudanese border as we visited the imposing temples of Ramses II and his sister-wife Nefertari. The temples were hewn from the living rock at Abu Simbel. We spent the night at the Aswan Hotel.

[1991-12-31] It was a free day to enjoy the beauty of Aswan with its African atmosphere. At New Year's Eve, I was at the Club Med at Amun Island in the middle of the Nile. There was a little wine-drinking.

[1992-01-01] We rode by graceful Felucca sailboat to Elephantine Island and its museum. We had a 25-minute camel ride

across the desert to the ruined Christian Monastery of St. Simeon. Amongst the ruins, I saw a small group of Catholics having mass! Again, the sky was crispy blue.

[1992-01-02] It was a free day to explore Aswan. Eating in the restaurant was quite memorable as I bit into some sand. A bit of sand in the food could not be avoided in these parts. In the evening, we headed for Cairo in a sleeper train.

[1992-01-03] We made it to our hotel in Cairo. It was rather a very rugged hotel. We walked around a bit. The Cairo skyline was quite distinctive, a mixture of modern buildings and old mosques with their graceful turrets. A wispy haze overlaid the ancient metropolis.

[1992-01-04] On our flight from Cairo to Canada, we had a stopover at New York City. We had a quick city tour. It was a rainy, grey day, but it was a blast to see Manhattan.

Neon Nonong

Back in Canada, an American megacorporation called Microsoft from Washington State eventually bought out our medium-sized software company, Consumers Software Inc. Things started to roll. They moved the office from rustic, brick-laden Gastown, Vancouver, to a bigger, modern building with gold-glazed windows on 888 Dunsmuir Street in Downtown Vancouver.

Several people quit or were laid off before the move. Microsoft preferred workers who seemed proactive and productive. Grant Watson, the tall, gangly, brown-haired, bespectacled hippy was one of those who quit. On his last day at work, he broadcasted to everyone a strange e-mail which described company people and organizations as amoebae which divided and coalesced wildly and continuously. Patrick Black, the redheaded, bespectacled engineering manager, also quit. Some people looked up to his leadership and he would be sadly missed.

From the USA came a medium-height, stocky, grey-haired, bearded, bespectacled, Jewish-looking man named Tom Evslin, who became the top manager of the whole Vancouver subsidiary. He was tough both in e-mail and in person.

I became the Engineering Lead for the Japanese electronic mail project Banzai with the black-haired, moustached, not too skinny American David Irwin as Program Manager. Subordinate engineers were skinny, brown-haired Patrick Jennings and handsome, brown-haired, mesomorphic Jonathan Morrison, just average Anglo-Canadians who became also my friends.

Moma...

:: Wud meik mi saund gei dat ai waz indid in lav wid :: Jonathan Morrison, :: hu waz slaitli toler en kronolojikali yanger dan mi. Hiz feis glowd samwat redish on hiz chiks. Hi waz kyut en had a kyut personaliti, bat ai niu dat hi waz a big man. Waz :: Brian

Bray'z :: aidiya tu rekrut dis yang man intu mai grup. :: Jonathan, :: ai spekiuleited, waz an "oral sex" gai bikoz hi laikt saking lolipop aiskrim... ::

The manager of all the program managers, including David Irwin, was a sexy, tall, grey-haired, moustached American named Mark Jennings (who had no familial relation to Patrick Jennings). It was Mark Jennings who initially made me think seriously about transferring to Japan by prompting me with questions.

There were several Americans, besides Mark Jennings and David Irwin, who transferred to our subsidiary in Vancouver from the headquarters (HQ) at Redmond, Washington. One of them was a very energetic, short

brunette named Jeannie Schmidt. She was a software tester at HQ, but became a program manager in Vancouver as a promotion. She was really overloaded with work, though. Another American was Barry More, a big, stout, brown-haired, moustached man, who became the manager of all the software testers in the Vancouver office. One time, our subsidiary had a barbecue party in a grassy park under sunshine. He was the one cooking all the hamburgers. But it seemed that when it was my turn to get a hamburger, he was a little hesitant to serve. Perhaps, he was a little jealous or embarrassed.

There was an immigrant named Andrew from Australia. He, a software tester, usually kept to himself. His boss, Robert Vogt, who was a middle manager amongst the software testers, was upset when I made the allusion of

Andrew to Ozzy Osbourne on the RAID system, our bug-tracking networked software. Ozzy Osbourne, a then popular British Heavy Metal celebrity, was famous for grabbing a dove and biting its head off whilst he was intoxicated. My joke was the pun on "Aussie" and "Ozzy." Well, Andrew was really a cool-headed, skinny, brown-haired man, though looking a bit bored. I several times invited him to lunches or a movie, but my mostly Oriental gang intimidated him. Anyway, he was busy dating a nurse...

One day, a black-haired, bespectacled white man named Daniel Petrie, a top executive from HQ, inspected the premises at our subsidiary in Vancouver. He looked around my office whilst I sat at my desk. He quipped that my office looked very "palatial." Indeed, it was because it was at the corner of the

building with high windows. The theme was Japanesque with a large hanging woven mat as the centrepiece. Amongst the colourful decor was a transparent glass jar, inside of which was a plant growing on hydroponic gel. The flag of Japan, the Red Sun with Rays, protruded from the shelves.

I spent time in Japan and Canada, back and forth. I tolerated the jet-lag. But really, every time I was in Japan seemed like a long, intense vacation as if time had slowed down. I wish that the digital camera was available then. I saw much beauty there.

Esperanto...

Mia tiam komenca impreso pri Japanujo

estis, ke ĝi estis bela lando. El flughaveno, mi prenis modernan trajnon al la urbo. Survoje, mi vidis la verdan kamparon plene da bambuoj. Ĉirkaŭe troviĝis vastaj rizkampoj. La variaj domoj havis imponajn diverskolorajn ceramike tegolitajn tegmentojn, kiuj brilis sub la suno. Ĉio ŝajnis bonkvalita.

Mi agnoskis, ke Japanujo vere estus, por mi, lando de serendipa esplorado.

Narita Airport near Tōkyō was always an exciting place. The most interesting airports were in Asia because many of the signs were in different writing systems or scripts. At Narita, I saw animated neon signs in Thai script, in bright orange. I could not guess what they were announcing. In the frenzy, I

spotted several white men in orange monk robes; they were walking barefooted in the airport. That sight was incredible. They were probably Buddhists; if they were not, then they were probably Hare Krishnas. Whenever I waited for my flight and ate at the airport cafeteria overlooking the docking aircraft, I thought to myself that Canada was so very far away. This feeling of distance I would never forget.

I felt that Tōkyō was such a dense city, so much so that one would not see large parking lots such as in Canada. To Japanese, they were a waste of valuable space. Indeed, there were special parking machines, which lifted and piled up automobiles on top of one another. They looked like giant robots.

I was in regular contact with my Canadian team, which included Tim Snider who was a symbolic lead, Jonathan Morrison, Patrick Jennings, and others, via a geopolitical game which we played on the Internet. The object of the game was to form alliances with other countries and conquer others—a sort of wargame.

Eventually, I was given the opportunity to transfer to the Japanese subsidiary and I accepted. This was in the early 1990's. I did not know how long I was going to be abroad, so I sold my new car, the Acura Integra, to a chubby, blond Canadian co-worker, Kevin Funk. I got back most of the money that I used to purchase it.

Jeannie Schmidt told me how "romantic" I

was in my decision of transferring to Japan. Yes, she was right. I was a romantic.

In Japan, my duties entailed mostly on the side of Software Engineering Development with a little emphasis on liasing with Marketing as sometimes I would go on "field work" with other employees to other competitor software companies in order to research our market. Some of the competing electronic mail products were quite impressive. The packaging itself was a sight to behold: almost neon-coloured plastic boxes that looked like they contained candy.

Japan's personal computer (PC) industry was unique in the world during the 1990's. Different competing domestic companies fragmented the PC hardware market with

several non-IBM-compatible machines. This diversity actually hindered the domestic PC software industry. Japanese companies considered PC's at a lower end of the computer machine family. Supercomputers were at the top. Microsoft dealt only with PC software.

(Japanese actually themselves promoted some forms of diversity. Many teenagers tinted their hair different colours to reflect this tendency.)

From the start, our team only had the Banzai project, which was the pre-Windows version of electronic mail. But later, we added the Shōgun project, which was the Windows version of the product, and the Okinawa project, which was the advanced

SMTP Gateway. "Okinawa" was the name of the subtropical islands which were located south of the major Japanese archipelago and which were famous for goat sashimi or raw goat meat. Okinawa had its own local language, besides Japanese, but Okinawans were also Japanese. "Okinawa" was our secret code word for the Philippines as a sort of nostalgia.

The Tōkyō office was initially in the Shinjuku ward before its relocation to the Sasazuka district in the Shibuya ward. It was called Microsoft Kabushiki Kaisha or MSKK for short. I first befriended Robert Orndorff, a fun and funny Jewish-American from Washington State, as well as Hideyuki Inada, a tallish, sharp, darker-shade, magnanimous Japanese who was Program Manager. I liked the accent that he had

when he spoke Japanese. His favourite word seemed to be 'keredomo', which meant 'however'. Inada-san and Robert combined in managing as well as in being my initial tour guides, but both quit the company too soon. It led to a crisis. Inada-san defected to a competing company, Borland in California. And Robert fled to Washington State to wed his Chinese fiancée. (I later attended his modest wedding in Seattle.) Quickly, the American headquarters had to hire Tom Hensel, an American from Washington State to replace the liaison management. All through this time sat a friend of mine, a half-American, half-Japanese sumo-wrestler-looking fellow Jeff Muzzy, who was also from Washington State. Tom was a little uneasy in Japan because of all the pressure. He had his own style of humour; he bought and rode a pink motorized scooter through the streets of Tōkyō. He flirted a lot in the

Roppongi district, which was known for "party animals." Several secretly labelled him in the office as hen na gaijin (strange foreigner) or etchi (horny). They often misunderstood his free lifestyle. Tom was not alone in being labelled; Kyōko Oikawa, a young office lady, often labelled me as abunai (dangerous). She was hinting to me about the danger of STDs. (A similar-sounding word abunae meant "suggestive or indecent picture.")

Esperanto...

Dum la nokto en kelkaj stratoj de Tokio, prostituado estis evidenta. La virinoj venis el multaj landoj, kiel el Tajlando, Filipinoj, kaj Sudameriko. Ili parolis kvazaŭpiĝineskan formon de la Japana ĉar ili ne estis fluaj

parolantoj. Viro selektis virinon sur la malluma strato kaj ili iris al iu amorhotelo aŭ «Love Hotel» por amori dum horo aŭ pli da tempo. Oni ankaŭ banis en banujo. En kelkaj danĝeraj lokoj, se oni nur sidis kaj babilis, trinkante eble bieron, kune kun «laboranta» virino, oni devis pagi multe da mono. Sekso en Japanujo estis pli libera ol en aliaj landoj. Por Japanoj, sekso tre gravis kiel integra parto de kompleta sana vivo.

At my workplace, there was a curious fellow, a Japanese-American software writer named Arthur, who had been in Japan for several years. He preferred American values over Japanese. For instance, during a round of beer-drinking, he preferred to pour his own drink instead of the Japanese tradition of pouring someone else's drink reciprocatively. Thereto Jon Genka, a Japanese-Hawaiian,

giggled, stealthily disapproving. However, in a very Japanese fashion, Arthur meditated in the office whilst sitting on a counter and staring blankly at the other side of the room.

Esperanto...

Bertilo Wennergren, sveda rokmuzikisto kaj gramatikisto pri Esperanto, ofte nomis la japanojn «napokapoj» pro la blankeco aŭ pureco de iliaj meditemaj mensoj. Tio ekzempliĝis, kiam Charles Simonyi, sciencisto en Mikrosofta Korporacio, vizitis nin en Japanujo, ĉe MSKK. Li lekciis pri iu programada temo nova kaj tre teknika per la angla. Poste, estis demanda tempo por la juna aŭdantaro, sed neniu japano levis manon por demandi ion. Nur blankulo, Tom Hensel, demandis ion al sinjoro

Simonyi. Estis tipa japana meditema konduto.

La vera hungara nomo de la sciencisto estis Simonyi Károly. Li fariĝis usonano kaj riĉulo. Multe pli malfrue, li veturis al spaco, kiel «spacturisto» per rusa spacŝipo.

When I officially joined MSKK, I was treated to a fancy French restaurant as a welcoming lunch amongst other software writers and managers in the company. Some Japanese learnt French for fun and, one time, I heard a French announcement with an elegant female voice over the loudspeaker whilst walking through one of the major department stores; I thought that I was dreaming because practically all of the clients were Japanese. I suppose that it was a bit of surrealism for the

clientele. It is interesting to note that the Tōkyō Tower was completed in 1958 as an imitation of the Eiffel Tower in Paris, France. The two cultures seemed compatible with each other. But really, Japanese were more like Germans for their love of technology.

Amongst the native Japanese folk in MSKK, I also befriended Kyōko Oikawa, who was the office secretary ("OL" or office lady in Japanese); Yōko Maruyama, who was my Japanese-language teacher; Hiromi Matsuura, who was the tester lead; Kenzaburō Tamaru, who was the sneaky young development lead; Kazushige Kabayama, who was a heavy smoker and joked that his nickname was 'Kaba' (a pun on 'cover' or 'hippopotamus' although he was not fat himself); Juichi Takahashi, who was

a cultured person having learnt Mandarin Chinese in school; and Haruhiko Satō, who was a friendly young man in charge of translating all the manuals and text into Japanese. There was also Fumio Wakatsuki, who was a friendly programmer contractor, who treated me to a Thai restaurant. Our team leader was the Mona-Lisa-looking woman, Matsuura-san, who reported to Jon Genka, the handsome, darker-complexioned Japanese-Hawaiian, who then reported to Akio Fujii, a high-ranking manager. I was "Biku-chan" to all of them. I had that affectionate title "chan," whilst most others had "san" like "Genka-san," but it was "kun" like "Tamaru-kun" for junior staff, and it was "sensei" like "Maruyama-sensei" for teachers, and it was "sama" like "Fujii-sama" for very important people.

There were often insinuations about being either Western or Eastern. The dog and the cat respectively epitomized them.

Most lunch outings, I ate together with Takahashi-san, Matsuura-san, and Tamaru-kun, but also sometimes with the giant hapa (Eurasian) Jeff Muzzy. We tried almost a different restaurant every time, even those in hidden alleyways. We were a quiet bunch, as was not unusual with Japanese. I had my taste of seaweed on spaghetti and more exotic menus. It was tranquil joy.

Near the office was a restaurant called Vamos la, which served Japanized European cuisine. Next to it was the fitness club, in which one could not go without very clean clothes as there was an implicit dress code.

There was an indoor swimming pool, which one could not use without a rubber head cover.

Esperanto...

Kiam mi sidis en la naĝejo, la naĝeja gardisto staranta apud la rando diris al mi, ke mi bezonas kapkovrilon en la naĝejo. Poste, li diris kvazaŭflustre Japane la vorton «kodomo», kiu signifis infanon aŭ knabon. En vestejo post la vadado en la akvo aŭ uzado de ekzercejo, mi estis nuda tie kaj mezaĝa Japano pasis preter mi demandante Japane, «Nihonjin desu ka?» (Ĉu vi estas Japano?). Mi ne estis certe pri la procento da Japanoj, kiuj estis cirkumciditaj.

En iu manĝvendejo, mi pagis por kelkaj kolorplenaj cilindraj ladskataloj da varigustaj trinkaĵoj kun "nata-de-koko", kiu estis Filipina deserto, aspektanta kiel molaj travideblaj kubetoj. La juna komizino demandis al mi Japane, «Tabemasu ka?» (Ĉu vi manĝas?). Tio, mi pensis, havis multajn subsugestojn.

Mi lernis la oportunan vojon por prepari vespermanĝojn. Survoje revenante al mia apartamento el la oficejo, mi haltis ĉe vendejo, kie troviĝis bovloj da freŝaj legomoj kaj mariskoj kaj fiŝoj. Mi aĉetis bovlon. Hejme, mi boligis la tuton. Poste, mi ĝue manĝis. Kelkfoje, mi vespermanĝis ĉe la oficejo. La oficejo pagis. Tio ofte estis tielnomata "o-bentō" aŭ skatolmanĝo.

Jeff Muzzy was a science fiction enthusiast as much as I was, so we could relate to each other about Japan in this genre. We had an inside joke that MSKK was some kind of space station orbiting an alien planet like that of "DS9" in the popular Star Trek show at the time, Deep Space 9. We also joked about traditional Japanese kitchen utensils looking like weapons of the warrior race Klingons in Star Trek. And the Japanese had the sneakiness of the goblin-like Ferengi. And the Japanese were philosophical like the noble Vulcans. And the Japanese were pious as the ritualistic Bajorans. These were perspectives looking through the eyes as gaijin (outsiders). But really, Jeff and I were not full-feldged gaijin. Jeff was a hapa and I could be considered an Ajia-jin (Asian person). In fact, Takahashi-san hinted that I was more of a Chūgoku-jin (Chinese person) for that he wrote my name fully in Chinese

characters in jest. But maybe some thought that I was a Hispanic or something, but, indeed, some noticed that I was really a mestizo, a hybrid, a mixed-race person, a hapa, or truly a Filipino. In any case, my ambiguous appearance allowed me to blend in with the Japanese crowd as Craig Webber, a white American, mentioned to me explicitly...

Jeff Muzzy seemed like a special person in Microsoft. It was hearsay that he often set up the computer for Bill Gates, owner and mastermind of the megacorporation. However, Jeff was an adamant person. Sometimes we loudly argued about silly things like the Metric System. He seemed to think that the English system of measurement was an integral part of American culture. In Canadian schools, I

was educated in Metric. Japan and most of the world were Metric. Because I took Chemical Engineering in university, I knew that the English system was too complicated and was often the cause of erroneous calculations. That old system was so messy that it affected the work of engineers and technicians. Indeed, Japan was Metric, except for a few things like measuring the space in apartments; how many *tatami* mats would fit in them was the way to measure these places.

In the first year in Japan, 1992, I often lodged in the fancy Tōkyō Hilton in the Shinjuku ward. Tipping was not common in Japan as it was a source of inconvenience and of embarassment. One always expected good service no matter what. Often when I returned to my hotel room, there were paper

pieces of glossy, colourful sex advertisements slipped under the door. One time, I was in a more Japanese-style hotel called Shinjuku Washington Hotel, where it was common practice to carry one's own luggage. By 1993, I moved into a small, neat apartment called Leaf Court in the Hatagaya area of the Shibuya ward. The alleyways around there were festively decorated. One time, I played loud music and the apartment administration complained to MSKK. Then I eventually moved into a bigger apartment in the Yoyogi area in the Shibuya ward. My neighbours were Jeff Muzzy, Tom Hensel, and Craig Webber, all of whom worked for the company. I also had a middle-aged Filipina neighbour next door to me; she said that she worked for a Swedish company in the city.

Tagalog...

Yaong Pilipinang kápitbáhay ko, noóng isáng araw, ay kumatók sa aking pintô at nagbigáy sa akin ng isáng serámikáng mangkók na punô ng maputíng tapiyoka na may sabáw. Oo, nga, sabi namin sa isip naming pareho na para kamíng nasa Pilipinas. Alám niyá na akó'y lumakí sa Pilipinas at lumipat sa Kánada nang batà pa akó. Parang umuwî akó...

My then home address was:

Room 101, Residence Hayashi
4-36-17 Yoyogi, Shibuya-ku
Tōkyō 151, Japan

Telephone (03) 3379-2697

When my possessions, all packed in big blue plastic containers, were shipped from Canada and arrived in Japan, an office secretary told me that one of my knives was confiscated because it was over 15 cm long. It was a knife, or dagger rather, with a twisted goat's horn as a handle. I bought it in Egypt in 1991. The secretary said that she was very sorry.

My apartment was near a fast-food restaurant called Yoshinoya, which served its signature dish, the gyūdon, beef and rice in a bowl. There were foreigners, including a few Hispanics, that patronized it. Right next to my apartment building was a fancy bistro called Masutasshu ("Moustache"), which

served a kind of fusion cuisine of European and Japanese styles.

I brought my sturdy rollerblades from Canada. With a hard purple helmet on my head, I clumsily experimented skating around on neighbourhood asphalt. One time, Jeff Muzzy was walking by whilst he was with a brown-haired white woman friend visiting from America. They chuckled as they saw me skating.

Esperanto...

Ofte en Japanujo, oni aŭdis la Japanan adjektivon "sabishii". Ĝi temis pri rafinata simpla soleco. Viroj, kiel mi, kiuj marŝis solece, ofte aŭdis tion aplikatan de aliaj al

ili...

Ah memories... My landlady, Hayashi-san, knew not the tongue of Shakespeare. More accurately, she could not really speak good English and she had a strong, hard Japanese accent. With me, she alternated between English and Japanese. At the top floor of my building was a beautiful view of Tōkyō all lit up at night. It was so quiet up there above the hive.

On the roof of my Tōkyō building was the laundry room where of course I did my laundry. "Sentaku suru" was to do the laundry; "sentakumono" was the laundry itself. Tōkyō was strange in a way that the whole city felt like one gigantic village, an organic labyrinthine sprawl with a human

perspective intact from medieval times. Also, it was like a giant throbbing machine. The image of that luminous city is forever etched into my mind like a fine ukiyō-e woodblock print.

Each area of Metropolitan Tōkyō had a distinctive character. It was fascinating to just stroll and take the subway and trains to different areas. It was a big place. It was a giant amusement park. It was full of "eye candy."

I lived five minutes' walk from a train station. It was the Keiō Line at the Hatsudai train station. The next stop west was Hatagaya, then farther west was Sasazuka, which was walking distance from my workplace.

East from the Hatsudai station was Shinjuku, a neon paradise. From Shinjuku, I could take the Yamanote Line, which went around in circles with over 25 stops, including Shinjuku, Harajuku, Shibuya, Ebisu, Shinagawa, Tōkyō Proper, Akihabara, Ueno, Ikebukuro, Takada-no-baba, then Shinjuku again, in a full circle. Each stop at this circular constellation was like a different planet. That circle was part of a much larger web of subway and train lines.

Shinjuku was a neon jungle for amusement, very carnal or otherwise light-hearted fun. It was full of the so-called "Love Hotels" about which Westerners often heard. A frequent stop of mine in Shinjuku was the giant Kinokuniya Bookstore. Japanese people liked reading copiously.

Most Japanese were honest when dealing with money, but one had to be cautious with taxi drivers and at places like striptease parlours. They were sometimes dishonest. I watched one striptease wherein the woman on the stage had very pale skin. She was partly wrapped in delicate white chiffon. All the Japanese men were very, very quiet. But there were two white Americans who were excitedly shouting and whistling.

One day, I wanted to see the auctions at the fish market at Tsukiji. But I arrived too late. The auctions happened very early in the morning. Anyway, the area was very quaint. There was an old shrine or temple there.

I often visited Ueno where there were

museums and parks. There, on a chilly winter day, would be stalls on wheels that sold coal-baked sweet potato called 'yaki-imo'. I would smother its steaming tender orange flesh with melting butter. It was so comforting on a crispy cold day. Japanese would wait patiently and silently in very long winding queues outside to see ancient European paintings in the museum. A Peruvian band in colourful garb played traditional Andean music with their pan flutes.

Wandering the wooded areas in Ueno Park, I chanced upon a pond filled with bright orange koi or carp. I was all alone until a middle-aged Japanese man came by. He asked, "What are you doing here?" He then said, "It's carp. It's crap..." I guessed that it was his own kind of Zen expression. But

later, I found out that the word "koi" was a pun for love.

Akihabara was a district full of the latest electronic gizmos. Asakusa was a grand temple area, leading to which was an alley lined with shops of traditional Japanese wares. Kappabashi Kitchenware Town was where one could buy real-looking plastic replicas of food, such as plastic sushi, plastic ice cream parfaits, plastic bowls of plastic noodle soup, and so on.

There was also Harajuku where on weekends teenagers would dance on the streets to amateur rock bands. Near there was Takeshita-dōri, a street for inexpensive clothing, kamikaze headbands, and other curios. It lead to a park with a Shintō shrine

and a bazaar of antiquities. That place was where I bought the antique red Shintō wedding gown for my mother and an old green metal replica of a Shōgun's helmet. At Yoyogi Park in the weekends, scores of Iranians would loiter in one treed area to have tea. They scooped their tea from a big plastic container. The peaceful Meiji Jingū shrine was nearby, all in its wooden perfection. The high-class department stores like Mitsukoshi, Isetan, and others were everywhere. At the bottom basements of these places were virtual food festivals. I frequented Virgin Megastore, a store for music disks; it was reachable from the underground subway tunnels. Sometimes stray Iranians would come up to me and ask, "Terefon kād?" They were selling telephone cards. In the train, a young Iranian man was flirting or seducing a Japanese teenage girl; in a sense, they were both talking to me indirectly.

Many Iranians worked in the construction industry in the city. One time, whilst I was eating at an East Indian restaurant, two restaurateurs, both East Indian, were speaking Japanese quite fluently behind me. I guessed that they had been living in Japan a long time.

Black people used on billboards and advertisement posters were not uncommon in Tōkyō. Japanese opined that they were *kakkoii* (cool). There were few actual black people that I saw in Tōkyō. I could not tell if they were Americans or Africans. Whilst I was standing on temple grounds in the city of Kyōto with Takahashi-san, a school bus sped by and, from inside, a high school student in uniform shouted through the window, "Kokujin!" (black person). I was wearing a grey university sweatshirt with the big words

"HARVARD UNIVERSITY" on it. I supposed that he recognized me as a hybrid and wanted to reinforce my non-whiteness, or that maybe the sweatshirt looked too foreign, or that not wearing my eyeglasses at the time made me look Hawaiian with especially my wavy hair. But many Japanese curled their hair.

One time, Inada-san and I ate in a Chinese noodle restaurant. After the meal, we sat and chatted at the table. The Chinese-Japanese, middle-aged restaurateur stood by us. She made a reference to Ben Johnson, the black Jamaican-Canadian sprinter whom a committee disqualified for doping during the 1988 Summer Olympics. She used the term "Benjo-san" where "benjo" was the word for toilet. Apparently, she hinted that our speaking so much English was distasteful to

her. Or, she knew that I did not hate sex. And Inada-san previously indicated that I was from Canada. Ben Johnson was a handsome man. Evidently, she considered that Japan was a "black" country. Much of Japanese communication was of "double entendres."

Japan was a rich country, but Tōkyō had its share of the underpriveleged. They were few. Unlike bums that I saw in other countries, these Japanese bums were organized and showed neatness such as in the cardboard boxes they used to cover their sleeping areas. Some grew their hair long and Rastafarian-like, somewhat like ascetic monks. They were poor, but they were still neat and still waxed philosophic. Strangely, these people clustered in areas, such as train station exits, where there were many foreigners.

At one point, I was bicycling to work. I was a fast rider. It annoyed a few pedestrians. I usually parked and locked my bicycle in front of my office building. One day, I was surprised to see it missing and stolen. I told my apartment landlady Hayashi-san and she led me to the nearest kōban, a police box, to report it missing. Sometime afterwards, some days, I found a bicycle similar in shape to mine parked in front of my office building, but it was coloured green, the colour of youth, envy, and Esperanto. But I was not so sure. It was fishy. Then I decided to use the train to get to work. Very much later, I would suspect that the whole trouble encircled a word play on the Japanese words jiten (dictionary) and jitensha (bicycle). Indeed, all that I lacked were thousands of Japanese words... I would remember that I

also bought an electronic, portable Japanese dictionary, a Canon Word Super IDX-9500. Perhaps, some Japanese thought that it was a waste of money. Perhaps, not all Japanese were technophiles. Perhaps, they thought that I was really a traditionalist at heart with all my antiques in my apartment...

There were a few pranksters in the sometimes smoky office. One time, I booted up my computer, then on the screen was an image of a naked white woman. I had a communist Soviet pendant on my navy blue military-looking winter jacket. One day, the pendant went missing. I bought that precious red pendant from a vendor in a park in the city. Another day, I found broken my black music disk player that sat on my desk. All these things to Japanese had meaning...

My anthropological suspicion was that Japanese were varying concoctions of several human subspecies, namely the Northern Mongoloids, the Southern Mongoloids, the Proto-Mongoloids ("Amerindians"), and the Caucasoids. In ancient times, there were masks depicting "supernatural creatures" called *tengu*, which possessed often hairy faces and long noses. They were likely Caucasoids—perhaps both Nordic and Mediterranean types. (Japan was close to Siberia.) Or even, some of the *tengu* might have been East Indians (Australoid-Caucasoid mestizos), as India was a spiritual centre of Asia. Or, the *tengu* might have been Turkic peoples, or those physically similar.

In the colder northern islands of Japan, there was a mysterious, ancient, indigenous hairy-faced, round-eyed people called the

Ainu, who probably were at least partly Caucasoid and partly Mongoloid. But research showed that they preserved "Proto-Mongoloid" traits that the ancient Jōmon also had. The Jōmon shared many physical characteristics with Caucasoids, but some claimed that they were a separate genetic stock. However, like the Ainu, the ancient Jōmon were in the same genetic cluster as the "Northeast and East Asian." Perhaps, these ancient peoples were neither really Caucasoid nor Mongoloid, but some kind of intermediate form during evolution. Whilst Caucasoids and Mongoloids were diverging, there were people in the middle and became a distinct race. In recent times, Ainu and other more common Japanese intermarried and pure Ainu practically disappeared.

Traces of Negroid and Jewish ancestries

through mostly Caucasoid Portuguese, and perhaps Dutch, traders might have entered the Japanese gene pool in the early exploration period of European expansion, centuries ago. Australoid traces through Southern Mongoloids, Portuguese, or even possibly the Ainu also entered the Japanese gene pool. The Japanese today have varied appearances because of kaleidoscopic roots. But over all, Mongoloid today is the main attribute.

In much more recent times and today, all sorts of heritages enter the Japanese gene pool. Europeans, North Americans, Latin Americans, and other Asians, of varied races, intermarry today with Japanese. Crowds of Brazilian-Japanese, perhaps with mixed Amerindian, Negroid, Portuguese, and other ancestries, today become a minority part of

the Japanese spectrum. Portuguese-speaking Brazil today has the most Japanese immigrant population of any country in the world. So, the two countries intercommunicate.

I opined that Japanese were much like Filipinos, but their eyes were often squintier and their skin colour gradation tended to the lighter shades than Filipinos. But unlike Filipinos, Japanese retained still much of their culture despite some modernization.

Esperanto...

Ekzistis eble du ĉefaj korpotipoj en Japanujo. Estis la tipo, kiu aspektis pli Ĉina aŭ Korea kun pli hela haŭto kaj kun pli strabismaj

okuloj. Kaj estis la alia tipo, kiu aspektis pli Indiana aŭ Malaja-Polinezia kun pli malhela, pli bruna haŭto kaj kun malpli strabismaj okuloj. Multaj homoj estis miksaĵo de ĉi tiuj du. Kiel termometro, ekzistis gamo inter la ekstremoj. En la antikvaj jaroj, Nagasaki estis centro de internacia komerco kaj multaj Eŭropanoj, ĉefe Portugaloj kaj probable Nederlandanoj, intermiksiĝis kun Japaninoj, rezultante en mestizoj. Tra jarcentoj, tiaj genoj etendiĝis tra la lando. Multaj Japanoj havis pli da korpoharoj, kiuj estis eble aŭ ne eble la rezultoj de tiuj genoj.

In ethnology, a popular theory was that many present-day Japanese were descendants of both the indigenous Jōmon people (during the years circa -14000/-00300) and the immigrant Yayoi people (during the years circa -0300/+0300). The earlier Jōmon,

perhaps, were anthropologically more of Proto-Mongoloid ("Amerindian") or else Southern Mongoloid (Malayo-Polynesian) in nature, these two being different, whilst the latter Yayoi were more of Northern Mongoloid in nature. There was much race-mixing in the islands. Probably, there were multiple waves of peoples coming from different directions and their ethnic identities would be yet unknown. (I used here the ISO 8601 standard for dates and times.)

Esperanto...

Antaŭ jarcentoj, Nagasaki estis centro de Kristanismo kaj Eŭropa lernado en Japanujo. Post la bombado sur Hiroŝima la 6an de aŭgusto de 1945, Nagasaki estis bombita la 9an de aŭgusto de 1945. La nuklea bombo

de uranio-235 sur Hiroŝima nomiĝis «Little Boy» kun ekvivalento al 12-15 kilotunoj da TNT (trinitrotolueno) aŭ 50-63 teraĵuloj; ĝi ja mortigis almenaŭ 140 000 personojn. La nuklea bombo de plutonio-239 sur Nagasaki strange nomiĝis «Fat Man» kun ekvivalento al 20-22 kilotunoj da TNT aŭ 84-92 teraĵuloj; ĝi ja mortigis almenaŭ 80 000 personojn.

The address of the old office building was: Microsoft Co., Ltd., K-Building, 7-5-25 Nishi-Shinjuku, Shinjuku-ku, Tōkyō 160, Japan.

The address of the new office building was: Microsoft Co., Ltd., NA Building, 1-50-1 Sasazuka, Shibuya-ku, Tōkyō 151, Japan.

At first, the Microsoft office was at the K-Building in the beehive of the Shinjuku ward, then administrators had it moved to the Sasazuka NA Building in the Shibuya ward. I took the train of the Keiō Line at the Hatsudai station, then headed west skipping the Hatagaya station, then onto the Sasazuka station, my final stop.

There were other foreigners working in the office. One was John Talbot, a Japanized Englishman, a software writer who lived with his Japanese wife and baby. He seemed fluent in Japanese. John previously worked for Lotus Corporation in Japan. There was also a Filipino guy there, a software writer. He spoke Japanese and had been in Japan for a long time. And there was a Chinese man who spoke Mandarin with Takahashi-san. There were an Anglo-Canadian

Richard and an Anglo-Australian Steve Gilbert, who worked in the technical support department. They spoke Japanese pretty well. There were other white Americans, including lively Randy in marketing, who could speak Japanese.

There were a few people kind enough to show me around. With Robert Orndorff the Jewish-American, I made it to Kamakura and other smaller towns in Japan. With Takahashi-san, I attended tea ceremony practice. He, together with some Japanese women dressed in kimonos, showed me the itsy-bitsy details of that art of o-cha. I had to wear, along with clean white socks, a nice suit, which he exclaimed was "Kakkoii!" (Cool!). Also with Takahashi-san, I made it to glorious, ancient Kyōto, there to see ancient Japan.

Like a hippy, Takahashi-san drove, if I could use a slang term, a small old beater, which maneuvered speedily through constricted alleyways. Most automobiles in Japan were in good condition as there were strict regulations.

With the Ogasawara family, I made it to Mt. Fuji and Lake Biwa. The Ogasawara family was that of the student named Masāki, who stayed in my home in Canada. And there were memorable karaoke nights with the office gang and separately with the Ogasawaras. Usually, I sang easy Beatles lyrics and La Bamba. Singing in front of people, I thought, was rather un-Japanese because it encouraged selfhood.

Eating was a real pleasure in Japan. Sensuality permeated everything that Japanese people did. Restaurant-hopping was a hobby for me, Jeff Muzzy, and others. Also, we had lavish buffets at the Tōkyō Hilton. Inada-san treated me to whale meat cuisine at the Kujira-ya, literally "Whale Shop," in the Shibuya ward. That restaurant took the whale meat from quotas of scientific expeditions. I felt a little guilty eating whale.

Oikawa-san was an expert in the art of ikebana, flower-arranging, and demonstrated it silently in the office. The plants, which she used in the arrangement, looked like things that grew in the marshes. As time passed, the plant things in the arrangement grew fuzzier and hairier. It looked like an erotic Zen greeting. Maruyama-sensei was

my Japanese-language teacher. I fell in love with both these women and I compared them to the characters May and Consuela in the science fiction movie Zardoz, starring Sean Connery as Zed and set in the year 2293.

One time, there was an industrial exposition in Chiba Prefecture, in a big convention centre called Makuhari Messe, which to my ears sounded a bit German. There was a booth for Microsoft. After the hullabaloo, my crew, including Jeff Muzzy, hiked outside. There were palm trees along avenues. There was a nice beach. Although, on that day, it was cloudy.

Jeff often reminded me of the fat Maitreya Buddha in Chinese culture. His skin was of darker shade which made him look

somewhat Indian, or even Hawaiian or Samoan. Being part-Japanese, he had relatives in Japan.

Esperanto...

La familio Ogasawara invitis min al sia domo. Sinjoro Ogasawara donis al mi instrukciojn por metroe atingi la lokon. Kaj la vojo al ĝi estis iom malsimpla, tiel ke mi estis iom malfrua. Ĉe la domo de la familio Ogasawara, kune kun ili, mi manĝis ravajn Japanajn manĝaĵojn kuiritajn de sinjorino Ogasawara mem. Krome, ni manĝis iom da «Kentucky Fried Chicken». La gesinjoroj antaŭe loĝis dum kelke da tempo en la orienta marbordo de Usono. Ja, ni ĉiuj ŝatis ambaŭ okcidentajn kaj orientajn manĝaĵojn.

I tested my Japanese slang on Mr. and Mrs. Ogasawara. I mentioned the word "kūru" (cool), but they did not know the word. Mrs. Ogasawara proclaimed, "Muzukashii..." (difficult). I supposed that slang words depended on the generation of people using them. Mrs. Ogasawara said that I was "atama ga ii" or that I had a good head.

Esperanto...

Alitempe, mi kaj gesinjoroj Ogasawara manĝis en restoracio. Tie troviĝis ankaŭ la mezaĝa fratino aŭ iu parenco de sinjoro Ogasawara. Ŝi diris al mi, ke ŝi antaŭe edziniĝis kun Filipinano kaj nuntempe ŝi eksedziniĝis. Ili eble avertis min pri la volatileco de miksaj geedziĝoj.

Iam, sinjorino Ogasawara demandis min pri miaj favorataj filmoj. Mi diris al ŝi, ke unu el ili estas Baza Instinkto kun la blonda sireno, Sharon Stone.

The Ogasawaras had a so-called "second home" in the countryside, something like a modern cabin in the woods. There was a small village with a community bath house. I was not used to being naked with a lot of strangers. But apparently, Japanese were not so prudish.

Esperanto...

Kune kun aliaj junaj Japanoj, inkluzive de unu dudekkelkjarulo kaj du dekkelkjaruloj, mi vojaĝis al la eksterurba areo de la

arboplena Lago Biwa. Tiam tre malvarmis. La aliaj tri fiŝkaptis sur boato kaj mi restis en la hejtigita belaspekta aŭtomobilo pro ekstera malvarmego. Mi ne havis vetertaŭgajn vestojn tiam. Poste, ni iris al la kampara moderna dometo de la familio Ogasawara. Ni banis nin en la vilaĝa komuna banejo. Venonttage, ni revenis al la urbo. Survoje, ni haltis ĉe karedomo por manĝi karean rizon. Tio eble aludis pri Orienta religio. Aŭ ĉu mi aspektis Baratano? Ĉie en Japanujo troviĝis karedomoj kun diversaj kareaj pladoj. Dum kiam mia dudekkelkjaraĝa kunulo stiris, elurbe kaj urben, li fumis kaj fumis cigaredojn, kio plenigis la aŭtomobilon kun fumo. Tio, mi pensis, havis multajn subsugestojn. Tamen, mi tute ĝuis la vojaĝon.

Another time I spent with the Ogasawaras

was at a fireworks display. We had a nighttime picnic on the roof of a tall building overlooking a meandering river. After eating interesting Japanese picnic cuisine and chatting, we viewed the beautiful hanabi or "flower fire."

The Ogasawaras comprised of the father Tadashi, the mother Junko, the eldest son Masāki, the youngest son Hiruki-chan, and a daughter. They had a bit of Korean ancestry. They were all very fair-skinned, except for Hiruki-chan who was dark. Hiruki-chan was a baseball fan. Baseball was a popular sport in Japan, even much before World War II, my manager Akio Fujii told me.

I was with some other Japanese people, who were a little older than I, one time. As we

walked through city streets, we stopped by a shrine. They did a simple ritual in front of it. I mentioned to them how "convenient" their religion was. They all giggled and one lady repeated in Japanese fashion, "Konbiniento!" One of the men told me that he and his wife would go with me to Tōkyō Disneyland at an appointed time. Then later he telephoned me and said that he was a little busy to go just then. I said that it was no problem. I supposed that many Japanese were hinting that I was still very much just a kid. The whole of Tōkyō was my Disneyland...

There was a point in time in Japan when I thought myself as not being a tourist anymore, but actually living there. That time was when I stopped carrying my camera and taking pictures.

I learnt some "underground" Japanese slang. One word made me snicker. It was herusu, derived from the English word "health." Herusu was oral sex.

Esperanto...

Cigaredfumado estis populara en Japanujo. Iam mi marŝis tra iu subtera vojo de la urbo. Unu marŝanta viro fumis tro, tiel ke la griza fumo kovris mian vizaĝon. Mi fortrapide svingis mian dekstran manon antaŭ mia vizaĝo. Pasanta juna alta svelta virino diris al mi Japane, «Ŝiro no ko!», kiu estis kalemburo por «kastela infano» kaj «blanka infano».

Viro kun lipharoj, Fumio Wakatsuki, kiu estis subkontrakta komputilista kunlaboranto ĉe mia oficejo, invitis min al Taja restoracio. Tie ni ĝue manĝis. Poste, ni parolis. Kaj dum tio, li fumis kaj fumis, kiel sceno el filmo de la 1950aj jaroj. En mia oficejo mem, multaj tro fumis. Estis malbone por mi...

An interesting event happened one time near a train station where a young Japanese woman was recruiting new members for a New Religious Movement (NRM). I followed her to her temple where I then donned a robe and was submerged and baptised in holy water outside on the temple grounds. Afterwards, there was a prayer with a Japanese man along with the initial young woman. The man said that I should only get baptised once in a lifetime. Then the woman

led me to a restaurant and I was offered a bowl of ramen because it was cold that day. The ritual was some form of spiritual salvation according to the beliefs of their NRM, of which there was a multitude in Japan.

One time, I took the metro to Tōkyō Proper. Whilst walking, I noticed on the almost empty street a lone young Japanese man. And on his shoulder, he carried a very big cross, perhaps wooden, at the base of which was a wheel that allowed the whole thing to roll on the asphalt. The scene looked surrealistically intriguing. It was true that Japanese were experimenting with many belief systems. The roots of the multicoloured NRMs were various religions—both Western and Eastern—including Buddhism, Shintō, Christianity, and others. There was a growth spurt of these

NRMs right after World War II. According to some sources, many Japanese were bireligious, being both Buddhist and Shintō. They had usually a Shintō wedding and a Buddhist funeral. Perhaps, this arrangement was why Japanese associated Buddhism with death. In places like Thailand, Buddhism had no connotation with death, although many Thais had a folkloric Animistic religion like Japanese Shintō in conjunction with their Buddhistic beliefs.

Two Chinese friends from Canada visited me whilst I was in Japan.

En route to China, Steve Kwong, a friend from university, arrived. I showed him around the city. He helped me carry newly bought barbells through the subway. Steve

had another friend in the city. The friend and his wife picked us up in his automobile. Steve's friend showed us his empty office during that non-working day. There was a long table shared by employees. Rank strictly determined the seating of employees around there. Later on, we drove to an industrial-looking area around a river. We then ate pizza in a restaurant overlooking the riverfront, which seemed like a scene in a science fiction movie.

Sometime afterwards, Steve flew to China. En route back to Canada, he revisited me and presented me with a green Chinese military uniform, which I thoroughly appreciated.

David Ho, another friend from university, arrived. One funny scene was when he

intentionally picked his nose in public in a fast-food restaurant. I was not too sure what he meant by that...

Back at the company, my team in Japan was being temporarily relocated to the American headquarters. I decided to transfer there to Washington State and find a new beginning. Nearing the end of my term in Japan, I had a Japanese female counsellor, who spoke to me in Spanish, which some Japanese knew was one of my ancestral languages because maybe they looked at my résumé. I suppose that one hint was that some problems occurred because of linguistic miscommunication. And maybe they knew that I was attracted to the Japanese language because of its powerful sound. Later, I suspected that there could be a secret Esperanto revolution in Japan, in any case,

at least a leaning towards Latin culture. I would remember that there was a yearly Samba festival in Tōkyō, the influence of Brazilian immigrants there. Many Latin Americans who had any Japanese ancestry could be immigrants in Japan. Many of them were multiracial. When they get to Japan, social workers indoctrinated them to the Japanese Dream. Indeed, there were many Koreans and Iranians in the city. The Japanese populace was divided on the issue of mixed races. The Japanese seemed to prefer brownish people into their society because their cultures were more compatible.

Indeed, there were some detractions in my stay in Tōkyō. Where I lived particularly, there was a subtle plastic-like, chemical fragrance in the air, which could have been from air pollution. Also, the cold viruses in

the winter were especially fierce; they were strains from the Asian mainland. Then of course there was the language situation.

Maruyama-sensei, my Japanese-language teacher, was an excellent teacher. She held a small class with me, Tom Hensel, and Jeff Muzzy as students in a room in the office building. She noticed how fast a learner I was. She had a secure, almost masculine voice for a beautiful, fair-skinned woman, who was perhaps a little older than I was. I was somewhat enamoured that I gave her quite expensive books with glossy coloured pictures about Buddhism, which I had bought from museums and other places. I would remember that at one time she had vacationed in India with her mother. She brought a gift for me at the office, a small black elephant statuette with glassy bits on it.

Indeed, someone else, a Japanese man, had mentioned that I was an "elephant" and that time was when I had lunch at Tamaru-kun's house where there was a German girl student with eyeglasses amongst the invited. Tamaru-kun said that she was "cute." She said to me whilst we sat on the floor eating, "Talk about yourself." Japanese were not comfortable talking too much about themselves, but amongst Europeans such was a good trait to have and helped self-esteem. Japanese tended to internalize their feelings or emotions. And since they considered everything as art, so must speech be artful, which would require much effort. Hence, Japanese were not too talkative. Perhaps, they were the least talkative of all ethnic groups in this world...

Another interpretation of the little black

elephant was that Maruyama-sensei was more interested in Hinduism than Buddhism. I did give her glossy Buddhist books before. Or another interpretation was that the elephant was Jeff Muzzy, whom, she thought, I should remember as a friend.

Maruyama-sensei thought that I was like "white chocolate" because she repeatedly wrote about it to me obliquely in her notes.

Esperanto...

Iam, mi kaj Tom Hensel vizitis Sud-Koreujon pro renovigi niajn vizojn. Ni veturis per aviadilo. En tiu lando, ni prenis lupagan aŭtomobilon. Dum kelkaj tagoj, ni restis en ĉambroj en bona hotelo en la ĉefurbo Seoul.

Ni aĉetis multajn memoraĵojn kiel tradiciajn kolorplenajn maskojn. Dumnokte, ni esploris amuzejojn kiel trinkejojn. Kiel aliaj Aziaj urboj, Seoul havis seksindustrion.

La manĝaĵoj estis pli spicitaj ol tiuj en Japanujo, sed Koreoj manĝis ankaŭ Japanaĵojn kiel suŝiojn. Mi vidis surstratan tablon kaj sur tiu troviĝis amaso da netranĉitaj longaj flanksinkantaj suŝiaj rulaĵoj.

Seoul imponis min, kiel kurioza, sed moderna, loko. Mi ŝatis la kuriozajn labirintajn stratetojn.

At the office, there was another class that I attended, a cultural orientation class. There,

they taught us about the finer details of Japanese culture. I made a gauche remark one day about the probability that Japan could be a Chinese province one day. Maybe I should not have said that. Indeed, my stay in Japan was like attending another university and I liked it. But my term there was soon ending.

MSKK gave me the option of staying in Japan, but I was thinking that it could not be a permanent stay since, as far I knew, citizenship was difficult to attain without Japanese ancestry. I was looking for a permanent home...

Esperanto...

Japanujo estis granda lando plejparte pro la lingvo kaj pro la manĝaĵo. Tiuj difinis la popolon. La arkitekturo en Tokio estis plejparte moderna aŭ postmoderna kaj malmulte da tiuj antikvaj strukturoj supervivis la Duan Mondmiliton. Oldaj konstruaĵoj ankoraŭ troviĝis en kelkaj lokoj, en la periferio...

Jeff Muzzy gave me a weathered sports magazine with an ice hockey player on the cover. What was he saying about Canada really?

By the very end of my sojourn in Japan, there was a Chinese woman from the USA who introduced herself to me as a new Human Resources employee at MSKK. At the day of my packing, she came by my

apartment with her husband who was a white man. There were several packers there, all of them Japanese. One of them misspelt my surname on a box; "MADRANO" it was. Later, the Chinese woman messaged me by electronic mail when I arrived in the USA. I told her jokingly that Tōkyō was "The Big Sushi" for me.

Perhaps, in Japan there were gay men who discouraged my further adventures into heterosexuality and were saving me from a possibly terrible marital situation. Or perhaps, some Japanese thought that I was specifically wanting slantier-eyed children, and that I should pursue more Caucasian-looking offspring for their own aesthetic reasons. Or perhaps, some thought that I was simply too young to pursue marriage. Or perhaps, the wiser of the Japanese knew that

I was really wanting a more religious life, and that marriage would not work for the very spiritual...

In Japan, I learnt more about what it was that made one Oriental. Perhaps, Nonong always had been "Oriental" in outlook. Orientals, I learnt in Japan, liked "fuzzy logic," "metaphoric or metonymic language," and "subtle indirect communication." Japanese were also extremely meticulous compared to other ethnic groups and demanded high quality out of every service and object. They also preferred "group think" over too much "individualism," but I noticed that this trait did not inhibit too much of individual creativity. Japanese were very artistic and creative. Japanese believed in "hierarchical society," which the neighbouring Chinese so-called

"Communists"—really Authoritarian State Capitalists—tried to eliminate. (My political preference was Democratic State Capitalism.) Japanese had a spiritual dimension which one could not find elsewhere in the world. Perhaps, they were more like the ancient Amerindians in terms of spirituality. Japanese had these majestic gate-like structures called torii in their parks and harbours. These portals were entrances into the spiritual realm...

I listened to some Japanese music. I particularly liked the serenity of the album Wica EPO and the sexual ambiguity of the lesbian-like GAO Roi Roi. There was also the heavier rock of T-BOLAN So Bad. I listened also to some Okinawan new music from RINKEN BAND Banji. I liked also traditional Japanese Enka music. I would

feel nostalgic whenever I would hear these songs...

I often watched music videos on television in my suite or played music at the booths at Virgin Megastore. Two songs were very important—"Return to Innocence" by Enigma and "Go West" by Pet Shop Boys...

The Japanese knew that I was in love with their language. It sounded somewhat like Spanish, as my departing counsellor insinuated. Indeed, I would find out much later that Japanese would be much easier if it were all in Roman letters, or what they called Rōmaji. Like Indonesian's, Japanese grammar, I thought, was easier than that of Spanish. Anyway, Japanese children learnt Japanese at first using phonetic Kana—the

heart of the Japanese language. The Kanji—Chinese-derived logograms—they thought, were for older and old people. I knew all the Kana. To me, they were just as easy as Rōmaji.

In neighbouring Korea, people were rapidly becoming illiterate in Chinese logograms as more and more of their literature were all in phonetic Hangeul—the Korean alphabetic system...

Unlike others, Japanese were not too anthropocentric—human-centred. They did not automatically assume that objects had human-like aspect. An abstract object as a language might not be human-like. The missing bicycle represented that a language could be like a vehicle to take me somewhere

I had never been...

My passport was stamped with at least nine entries into Japan from 1992 to 1994. I became truly a veteran Japanologist since then.

Thai Soup

[1996-01-15/1996-02-01]

My Auntie Vicky (Viveca), my father's youngest sister, was living in Bangkok in an expensive hotel-apartment high-rise. She was working as a manager at Tupperware to turn around the subsidiary's business in plastic containers. I was heading back from a trip to the Philippines and planned to visit her. When I arrived at the Bangkok airport, I

was so happy to see my aunt whom I had not seen for a long time.

From the airport on our way to the hotel-apartment, my impressions of the city were quite favourable. It was certainly more orderly than Manila seemed. Even the traffic was not as bad as Manila's. My aunt had a company car assigned to her with a friendly driver, Khun Santi.

It was a large apartment at Pantip Court Executive Residence, 68 Soi Atthakarnprasit, South Sathorn Road, Bangkok 10120. And, thank the gods, it was air-conditioned. It was quite a fancy place where attendants placed blossoms to float on the water in large ceramic containers. A bowl of exotic fruits awaited us inside. From the window, I could see the expanse of the busy metropolis laid

around me. My aunt's woman Australian boss at Tupperware was her neighbour.

The Thai people themselves impressed me. They were always in such good disposition, smiling and warm. I attributed it to their belief system, which was Buddhist. A group of svelte Thai dancers in costumes gave me a good welcome wave...

I learnt that not many Thais really spoke English. Even the money changers who dealt with foreigners a lot hardly uttered anything English. The Pantip Court chambermaid certainly did not speak any English, always smiling her way through. The tonal Thai language sounded gentle and lilting.

We saw a lot of things in Bangkok itself: the markets, the malls, the restaurants, the grand

palaces, the temples... The temples were remarkable with their elegant Thai architecture. There were figures of Buddha everywhere: thin, fat, gold, black, metallic, stone, squatting, reclining, you name it...

Back at Pantip Court, we had the privilege to eat at the restaurant near the lounge. Thai food was one of my favourites. Much of it was hot and spicy. Yummy! There were desserts that I never saw in Thai restaurants in Canada. One kind of dessert impressed in my mind was small multicoloured flower-shaped delicacies made of sticky rice flour, somewhat reminding me of Filipino "kutsintâ."

My aunt's Australian boss was rather funny: Being on a diet, she would order anything with watermelon: watermelon soup,

watermelon juice, watermelon everything. She previously lived in the Philippines for years and considered it her adopted land.

I had a chance to ride a boat through the "klongs" or canals. After all, Bangkok was the Venice of the East. One could buy food from the boats. From the canal, I could see how Thai people of all classes lived as sumptuous homes elbowed rickety shacks on stilts. Another transport I experienced was the "tuk-tuk," a small three-wheeled motored vehicle which went "tuk tuk tuk..." on the road.

The exquisite squiggly Thai writing on signs itself was a sight to behold. I found Japanese Kana easier to read, but of course if I set my mind to it I could learn the baroque, but sexy, Thai script. As a cyberphile, I took note

of Thai computers, which had fascinating Thai letters on the keyboard.

The markets were full of exotic foods. There were lots of dried spicy squid, fish, and other seafood. There were lots of delicious fresh exotic tropical fruits. Available were large rose apples or Java apples, species from the genus Syzygium, which were not "apples" at all, but were what Filipinos called "makopa." Strangely, makopas were not available in the markets in the Philippines, but in Thailand, they were a ubiquitous commodity. When I was little, makopa was one of my favourite fruits, besides coconut.

With my aunt's dependable driver Khun Santi, we drove up to the culturally preserved old capital, Ayutthaya, where there were ancient pagodas and temples. It was

really hot there at the time. The aircon in the car and inside buildings was quite refreshing. The sights of the centuries-old architecture were like extraterrestrial sets from "Star Trek." Ayutthaya was a quaint, small, rustic city. It was a kind of place in which I could spend a lot of time just meditating if I had the chance. It certainly seemed from another century, whether past or future was debatable...

We also visited a crocodile farm and show. One person put his head inside the crocodile's mouth. We also visited a snake farm, where I had a chance to put a large boa constricter around my neck. Eek! Then off we were to an elephant show. I rode on an elephant. What fun!

Nowadays, I often listen to Thai music on the

Internet and it reminds me of my time there. I have even bought some phrase books to learn a little of the fascinating language as part of my "reinvention of myself."

My 4th Revisit to the Philippines

Well, the Philippines in 2003 was somewhat different from the 1970's. The Manila skyline was now full of skyscrapers. The roads were now much wider. There was now a light rail network, befitting a metropolis. It was amusing trekking through the city. The shopping malls had now all the fashionable boutiques one could see in any major city in the West. There were now many McDonald's outlets and other franchises from America, but with which the local franchise Jolibee was in thriving competition because its fare included Filipino and Chinese food. But

eating at McDonald's was considered cute, and not so ordinary as with North Americans; well-to-do joggers would often stop there after exercise. I was feeling ethnocentric as I haunted mainly the bookstores, hoarding Philippine-related and Tagalog-language books, which I could not get in Canada.

Mi serĉis romanojn en la fantasta ĝenro per la Tagaloga lingvo tra la librovendejojn en Manilo, sed mi ne trovis. Bedaŭrinde, ŝajnis, ke la literatura industrio per la indiĝena lingvo en Filipinoj ankoraŭ ne estis matura. Ekzistis ja Tagaloglingvaj fantastaj rakontoj per la bildstria formato.

Mi tie ne povis trovi ankaŭ gramatikajn librojn pri aliaj indiĝenaj lingvoj de Filipinoj. Kelkajn lakonajn vortarojn de

kelkaj indiĝenaj lingvoj mi ja trovis.

Fakte, en librovendejoj en Manilo, kaj eble ĉie en Filipinoj, plejparte da libroj vendataj estis per la Angla, kune kun kelke da libroj per la Tagaloga. Filipinanoj kutime legis Angle, sed parolis indiĝenlingve.

In Manila, I attended a birthday of some rich kid. The parents rented a large hall and there were balloons, clowns, music, and other entertainment, as well as a buffet, from which I had up to a third serving. There was a kind of game, somewhat like the idea of the piñata, but with a bamboo matrix from which goodies and toys were attached; the matrix was intermittently lowered, so kids could grab the goodies. It was interesting. I was with my cousins Eric and Myra, their kids and spouses.

In Manila, I noticed that outside on some streets were rows of public urinals for men and they were pink in colour. They seemed metallic in construction. Due to embarassment, I did not photograph. But I thought how convenient the system was for pedestrians.

During my visit in 2003, I stayed mostly in Ibaan, Batangas, about two hours drive south of Manila. It was a rural town, which had no bookstores or libraries. I liked lounging around the verandah of the house of Auntie Bella (Tita Bella), especially when it was empty. Every morning, I would walk around the town, to the palengke (market), the church, the cemetery, and elsewhere. It was unheard of there for people to walk around; everyone hired the tricycle or jeepney to the

market. I walked. Nobody wanted to expose his or her skin under the sun, so that it turned brown. Nobody wanted to sweat walking under the sun. I walked.

The old Spanish-style Roman Catholic church was a favourite haunt of mine, an ersatz Buddhist temple. I would go there mid-afternoon when it was empty to meditate and sit on a wooden pew. Above, by the high light blue ceiling, were birds fluttering about. Candles were lit on one side. I felt so peaceful whilst sensing a spiritual presence in the sanctum as I would in a Shintō shrine back in Japan or in my neighbourhood Thai Buddhist temple back in Canada.

At the cemetery, I visited dead relatives, my ancestors. Luckily for my genealogy project, I

chanced upon the tombstone of my great-grandparents—"In Memory of Pedro A. Medrano, Florencia A. Medrano, Family Remembrance." He died on March 26, 1941, at the age of 74 years; she died on March 13, 1962, at the age of 96 years. What a find that tombstone was.

Parked in front of the Ibaan town market were dozens of colourful tricycles for hire. I would saunter in the market aisles not really expecting to buy anything. One small vendor sold some inexpensive children's booklets, quite thin, in Tagalog. I bought some for my research. I also bought some very inexpensive T-shirts and shorts, which I found out later did not really fit me. There were fish, meat, vegetables, fruits, and goodies amongst the vendors. It was fascinating.

My cousin Eileen's husband Arnel drove me in his army jeep around his family sugarcane plantations. I saw quaint huts which housed the sugarcane workers. Around there and the riverine ravine were expanses of thick jungle full of exotic plants and animals. Safari.

Almost every other day, there was a dinner or lunch at some relative's. There were crabs, prawns, mussels, and lots of other seafood. There were tons of traditional dishes and desserts. I was unaccustomed to so much revelry and socializing. But I was glad to see my cousins and uncles and aunts. I was glad to see new additions—the children of my cousins—to the clan.

I attended a school function of my 6-year-old niece Alec, who was actually my second

cousin, as she was the daughter of my cousin Eileen. It was Buwan ng Wikà, Language Month. I heard my niece Alec, as well as other oratory contestants, recite whole Tagalog essays. Impressive, they were. There were slogans on the wall in front of the auditorium, in Tagalog:

Wikang Filipino,
pagyamanin
Wikang Vernakulár,
huwág limutin
Wikang Inglés,
pagbutihin

(Filipino Language,
treasure it
Vernacular Language,
don't forget it
English Language,

improve it)

It was a trilingual approach. "Vernacular" referred to the local tongue—dialect or language.

In Ibaan, I had some time to surf the TV. My aunt had cable TV. My favourite channel of all was MTV Asia, which showed Indonesian, American, Japanese, and Korean music videos. They rocked! The VJ language alternated between Indonesian and English. When the VJ spoke English, there were subtitles in Indonesian. On the other channels, I saw soap operas from Taiwan and Korea, all dubbed in Tagalog. Such shows became real hits on the Philippine Archipelago. An "Asian Awareness" was brewing. The most popular band was from Taiwan, called F4.

Arnel and I went off one day to the city of Makati in Metropolitan Manila. Tall glass and concrete Bauhaus buildings lined the skyline. We entered one posh modern building, took an elevator, and found ourselves in a fancy air-conditioned lounge, in which it seemed that we were the only two people besides the waiters and waitresses. Then two young ladies entered the lounge and sat at our table. Arnel expected them and kept talking to them by his cellphone beforehand. One lady was a more European-looking mestiza, whilst the other was a more Oriental-looking mestiza. Both were jovial and smiling. Whilst the rest ordered coffee, I ordered a tall, cool glass of kalamansî (x *Citrofortunella microcarpa*) juice. One of the ladies said, "Ang saráp ng kapé!" (The coffee is delicious!). We chatted for awhile. Then we all headed off to the elevator. Therein,

whilst they were all chatting, one of the lady friends mentioned the word *badíy*—meaning "low-class, uncouth, unfashionable, having mass appeal." I was not sure to whom or to what she was referring. Was it the coffee? Or was it my citrus juice? I often confused that Tagalog word with *badíng*, which meant "homosexual."

On another day, Arnel and I sped down the highway from Ibaan to Makati again. This time, we ventured into an Italian restaurant. Several friends, mostly young, of Arnel were at the table as we all ate various pasta dishes. There was an old Chinese man at the table. I overheard that his name was Philip Tan. Really? A coincidence maybe? Then later on, I had some time to walk around the shopping mall. The palm trees and Mediterranean architecture here and there made, in Manila, many parts looking like

Southern California. Later in the evening, two close friends of Arnel, Arnel, and I sat a table for drinking rounds of beer. After a few, I had to stop, whilst the others kept on chugging as we all talked politics. One of them said that I was like one of the four legs of the table and I needed to help support the table up. By the end, Arnel drove the younger friend back to his house in a luxurious subdivision where the lampposts were very modern. Those lampposts did impress me.

One thing I realized in this trip was that I was more quintessentially "Asian" than the Filipinos in the home country. Like most Asians, I was a tea-drinker, unlike most coffee-drinking Filipinos. Filipinos sought a stimulant to excite themselves; I chose a sedative to calm my mind. Most Filipinos were chatterboxes; I was a quiet person. They

went to church, whilst I preferred a Buddhist temple.

Be They Souls and Spirits

Brian, the dog owner of Rafa and Chino, does believe in souls and spirits, in some ways. On 2012-10-20, with two leashes in hand, Brian the baron phantom struts approaching along the Halloween-like sidewalk, then we have a conversation near the dilapidated purple-leaved tree in the neighbour Bruce's yard. Yes, he says, he believes in souls and spirits and each kind is in a human body. I tell him that in some religions, people believe in multiple souls and spirits inside a body and to complicate matters, they may be "fluid" in nature. Brian thinks that I am like a Hispanic, but I imbue in him the notion of at least some

Eastern influence inside of me. I take a pseudo-scientific turn and tell him that the "soul-spirit structure" may be really complicated and may have many components like a chandelier does with different gems and crystals.

Brian believes in "extraterrestrials" or ETs, a term he prefers over "aliens." Both he and I agree that such beings may be millions or billions or years more advanced than "we" humans are. He mentions that some of them have the power of invisibility or they can phase in and out of walls like ghosts. I ask Brian if he thinks that the ETs are from the same universe as ours and if he believes in the "multiverse," the multiplicity of different universes. Thereof, he is not so sure.

I explain to Brian that in Tokyo, where I

once lived, I felt an alien non-human presence that was often and eerily communicating non-verbally.

Another thing eerie now is my feeling of an alien ship above the Rideau school field as it hovers invisibly. Brian asks me if it is higher than a kick to a soccer ball. I affirm. It may be connected with my orangy UFO sighting on 2010-07-09.

Brian, on his cellphone-cum-computer, shows me a picture of the UFO he saw one day. It looks like a grey kite-like shape with a grey trail. But it looks metallic. It is a grey sky. It is intriguing.

Astronomers know that there are 8 known planets in the Solar System. But Brian adamantly says that there are "11" counted.

Maybe, he hints that war may happen one day, Solar-System-wide. For Westerners, "11" has become the symbol for war in their current numerology.

Brian mentions that humans have some extraterrestrial genes in the body and that "we" are special beings. He says that our prehistory was manipulated by outworlders.

Brian is not a sci-fi fan, but he is intrigued by my anecdotes about Piers Anthony's *Cluster* stories about spy technology wherein the astral body can be extricated out of the physical body and transmigrated into a physical body of an extraterrestrial on some distant world, or about Arthur C. Clarke's novel *Imperial Earth* wherein the Makenzie (no "c") family become wealthy by mining methane on Saturn's moon Titan and

propagate themselves generationally by cloning, the clone cloning himself. Brian's ufology is not like my sci-fi. Sci-fi is fictional dramatization, but Brian is looking for something factual in ufology. He is searching for a reality.

Some people base reality in their local sphere. Maybe, most people do not travel enough, I mention to Brian. A bit aghast becomes Brian. I tell him about the Daoist notion that one's own garden or local neighbourhood may be a microcosm that reflects macrocosmic reality. All the learning from all the travelling one can do may lie right here locally. A snail on the sidewalk may have a "doppelganger" (Brian's conceptual word) in the macrocosm.

Brian and I are alike in some ways. He tells

me that he cannot talk so openly to his many intellectual friends and to his own wife as he does to me. Indeed, there are few people like us. Maybe, we are not "human."

On 2012-10-21, we meet up again, on the grey-sky sidewalk. This time, Brian discusses about a Japanese psychic experiment wherein a Buddhist monk is used to imbue certain emotions like love, anger, etc. into water. Then the water is frozen. The researchers find out that different emotions affect the way water crystallizes.

Brian also imparts to me about the author Stan Romanek who writes several books, including The Orion Regressions, which recounts in detail the "channelling" by an extraterrestrial through a human host. Those told are philosophical.

Brian notices my tuque on the head. It is dark blue with an emblem and "FCB." I tell him that it is "Futbol Club Barcelona." I tell him that I have been trying to learn the language there, Catalan, which is like Spanish with "marshmallow vowels." He smiles. We manoeuvre into a different topic about "15 million millionaires in China" (or "15 thousand"?) and how China was a Russian colony and Hong Kong was a British serf and China is now copying American ways, Russia and USA being successive mentors to China, then eventually, he says, "It's a good thing everybody speaks English." I retort, "About one billion people have some English, but they're not all fluent. Only something over 300 million are fluent." Actually, I should say "1.6 billion" know English at some level; many just know the rudiments. There are over 7 billion people

in the world. "The good thing about English is that there is so much information in it," I add. I go on to say, "The vocabulary is difficult with so many synonyms, Latinate and Germanic. Then you have to know which is highfaluting." The dogs Chino and Rafa get excited. Then Brian says that they have to get on their way to the park.

On 2012-10-22, we see each other again, but this time at the L-shaped alleyway near Rideau Park. Brian is wearing a red jacket and is with his two dogs. Firstly, we ponder about electronic libraries. I tell him then that I have 1102 electronic books at Amazon Kindle and the collection still grows. On top of it all, I have over 1000 books in solid print, in plastic boxes. Brian begins to think that I am really well-read.

Then we talk about Europe. Brian was not pleased with his train excursion in Italy. He says that as he peed into the urinal, he could see the rails below. (My own experience from a train ride from Amsterdam to Paris and back was that the toilets were just like in the airplane. Maybe he is just kidding.) He says that in the then Yugoslavia, his ancestral land, people were suspicious of one another and they did not like "ethnic people" to put it ambiguously. I say indeed that Europeans are "cliquish." We both have doubts about the longevity of the European Union, which may be just a giant Yugoslavia in the making. Well, at least I hope that I am wrong on that judgement.

Then we talk about Papua New Guinea. I tell him it has the highest density of any place in the world for the number of languages, about 1000. The natives live in

isolated valleys and such. Brian is not comfortable talking about linguistics. He is typical of some Americans who think that English is the only important language. At least that sentiment is what I sense. He knows some Serbo-Croatian, a Yugoslav language spectrum, but thinks that it is not important. I tell him that my Philippines has over 165 languages and Indonesia has over 300. Both countries had to choose one. (Later, I check in the current Ethnologue that says that the Philippines has about 181 languages—171 indigenous, Indonesia 722 languages—719 indigenous, and Papua New Guinea 830 languages—all indigenous. And the score changes every year!)

Then Brian muses over how "beautiful" are the mixture of Asiatics with Caucasoids. He prefers the Hawaiian model over the Californian. He mentions that the Asiatic

traits are dominant. There are nice specimens of even sturdy, brown-haired, squinty-eyed hybrids, but these special Oriental-Nordic mix is much rarer than the Oriental-Mediterranean, to which I approximate. I look more like an Amerindian-Mediterranean mix because a Malay approximates an Amerindian. I would fit right in Mexico or Peru or even Brazil. A Mediterranean Caucasoid is like a chocolate chip cookie with possible traces of Negroid and/or Australoid. (My father looks like a Chinese-Malay outwardly, but my mother looks like a slightly yellow-tinged, fair-skinned Mediterranean woman. Everyone in my family is probably quadriracial: Caucasoid, Mongoloid, Negroid, and Australoid.)

Then the topic segues into my sighting of a large-wingèd, manta-shaped shadow over the

snow near the alleyway and the Rideau Park entrance, on 2010-11-20T03:45. Maybe, it has to do with the "presence" hovering over the middle of the school field. The aliens maybe are not humanoid in shape. I would see the manta shadow several times more, in different places and seasons. The spooky story intrigues Brian. In the conversation, I use the words "bird" and "bat," but "manta" slips from my mind then.

Then we start to wind down the conversation as we walk over to the front of my house. He confides in me that many of the things that he says to me he would not divulge to anyone else. He grew up as a "weird kid," he says. I confide in him that I also grew up like a "weird kid." I tell him that he sounds like a man who has a university degree, but he denies it.

It is 2012-11-04. I have celebrated Halloween alone as I have for the several years, since 2007, that I have been back to Lulu Island. People do not celebrate Halloween much on Lulu Island as much as people in East Vancouver where I lived from 1996 to 2006. There on Halloween, the houses are fully decorated with carved pumpkins and other paraphernalia and I can hear recordings of ghastly sounds blaring down the "character homes" block. Well, Lulu Island is a sombre island haunted by sombre Orientals and older white people, but East Vancouver seems more colourful. Both are Canadian cities and I know a short distance can make them like different countries. Oh well, there is so much nostalgia.

For several weeks, I have had a virtual vacation in Latin America as I listen to radio Web broadcasts from countries stretching from Mexico to Argentina, north to south, and Peru to Brazil, west to east. TV Brasil is a fantastic window into a strange and corpulent jungle country. Google Maps has enabled me to wander their fascinating brown streets where plastic chair canteens, Beetles, and shirtless men abound. I have been practicing my Carioca (Rio de Janeiro) accent in Brazilian Portuguese. I find this language more substantive than French and funnier than Spanish. In the Twitter communications, the Latinos have voted Brazilian Portuguese as the preferred contemporary Latin rendition. "Rio de Janeiro" means "River of January," my birth month.

Ang Tagalog ay Tagailog Nga

Ang Rio de Janeiro ay ang Ilog sa Enero. (Talagang nasa Isla Lulu sa Kanada ako nakatira. Nasa kalagitnaan ng ilog.)

Ang isip ng kapitbahay kong Intsik na si Irene ay magiging "saling pusa" lamang ang Intsik sa eksplorasyon ng espasyo. Hindi sila magiging drayber, kundi pasahero lamang.

Mas may tiwala ako sa Hapon tungkol sa espasyo dahil alam kong talagang interesado sila. Mas nagmamats ang personalidad ko sa mga Hapon. Mas parang Hapon ako. "Nipponic" 'ika nga na ginaya sa "Hispanic."

Nang ika-7 ng Nobyembre ng 2012, nagtagpo kami ni Brian na kasama ang dalawang

asong sina Rafa at Chino. Malapit sa eskuwela ng Rideau. Medyo maputla siya. Masakit daw ang leeg niya baka sa pagdradrayb ng bus at di siya makatulog. "Repetisyon" daw at nakagrey na dyaket siya. Baka interesado siya sa Lojban na. Kasi may mga flashcards ako. Alam niya.

Sabi ko na nasa labas ako ng bahay dahil naghihintay ako ng katapusan ng instalasyon ng mga double-glazed na bintana sa bahay. Sabi niya na noong naghahanap siya ng tahanan, may nakita siyang triple-glazed na bintana. Parang iniisip niya ang mga rasa: Caucasoid, Mongoloid, at Negroid. Sa opinyon ko, ang ika-4 na Australoid ay hindi magkapareho ng Negroid. Iba itong mga maiitim na rasa. Iba ang buto nila at ang Australoid ay kung minsan ay blondo o kulay dalandan ang buhok. Ibang panahon ang dalawang itong

nagsanga galing sa ibang katauhan. Mga libu-libong taon ang pag-itan.

Pagkatapos, sabi ko kay Brian na nagbukas ang Google Maps ng ilan pang bansa na kasama ang Thailand at Croatia. Sabi niya, Taga-Croatia ang mga magulang niya. Mukhang Mediteraneo roon. Tingnan ko raw sa Croatia ang lungsod ng Pula na may mga ruwina ng mga unang panahong Romano.

Sabi ko, nagagandahan ako sa Bangkok. Nabisita ko noong 1996 pa, pero ngayong kita ko ay parang mas kulimlim ang personalidad pala ng lungsod na iyon. May mga palanggana sa kalyeng puno ng maaanghang na pagkain. Nakakatuwa.

Sa tinitindigan namin, may malapit na bahay na may maiikling metalong bakuran.

Sabi ko kay Brian, noong dekadang 1970 may mga koneho at guinea pig sa loob ng hardin. May mga ubas sa paligid. Ngayon, alam kong Taga-Taiwan ang may ari na. Parang hindi nila kinakain ang ubas. May nadamput akong kompyuter kibord doon na may mga Bopomofo ng Mandarin, ang pangtulong na alpabeto nila para maipasok ang mga logograma sa kompyuter. Iba sa talagang Tsina na ang pangtulong ay letrang Romano.

Nalilito ang mga puti sa Thailand at Taiwan. Hindi Intsik ang mga Thai. Mukhang meyd ang maraming Thai. May singkit din. Mas barako ang lalaki nila. Mas parang Hapon ang ugali nila, pero para silang mas madaldal at makakaibiganin.

Nang ika-8 ng Nobyembre ng 2012,

nakapulang dyaket si Brian na kasama ang mga asong sina Chino at Rafa. Parang mas masaya siya. Galing akong Pizza Hut, nagsimula kaming naglakad sa kanyang townhouse hanggang sa bahay ko.

Sa kanyang iPhone, pinakita niya sa akin ang ufotv.com na puno ng mga video tungkol sa mga UFO. Tapos, sabi niya tungkol sa mga baka raw sa mga farm na nakitang may mga perpektong bilog na mga butas at ninakawan ng mga organ at dugo. Dinaysekt daw ng mga alien.

Sa mga crop circles sa mga bukid, may naririnig daw ng mga tunog na pinarinig ni Brian sa akin sa kanyang iPhone. Medyo parang tunog ng insekto sa gabi. Hindi raw iyon mga kuliglig.

Sa kanyang iPhone, may aplikasyon siya para sa mga UFO hunters. May kompas at magnetometer at iba pa.

Ang talagang hilig ni Brian ay ufology. Palagay ko'y may katotohanan din doon, pero dapat mag-ingat ang tao sa impormasyon.

Ika-9 na ng Nobyembre ng 2012. Di ko nakita si Brian ngayon. Kung minsan, ang asawa niyang si Lianne ang naglalakad ng mga aso nila. Kapareho ang pangalan niya ng pinsan kong si Lianne Angos sa Los Angeles. Si Lianne na asawa ni Brian ay puti rin na medyo kulay dalandan at kape ang buhok. Nagtratrabaho siya sa imigrasyon para sa gobyerno. Nakakapagod na trabaho raw.

Tungkol naman kay Brian. Ang isip ko'y dapat naisipan niyang kumuha ng biyolohiya sa hayskul dahil sa kinabukasan, ang hilig niya'y magiging eksobiyolohiya, yung buhay sa mga malayong iba-ibang daigdig.

Ang isip ni Brian ay mas magaling ngayon ang ufology kaysa sa sci-fi o salaysaying pang-agham o salaysaying makaagham, baga. Di totoo ang mga istorya sa mga ito. Mga guni-guni sila o dramatisasyon. Ang ufology ay naghahanap ng katotohanan tungkol sa taga-iba-ibang-daigdigang buhay na dumadalaw dito sa ating mundo. Releyted ito sa eksobiyolohiya. Nang bata pa ako, eksobiyolohiya ay hilig ko na dahil sa sci-fi.

Hindi ako naghihintay ng mga ahensiya ng espasyo ng iba-ibang bansa para sa

eksplorasyon. Limitado ang mga badyet nila at mabagal talaga ang mga plano nila. Kaya niyapos ko ang kathang-isip, ang guni-guni, ang imahinasyon, noong bata pa ako. Ganoon ako. Limitado ang realidad.

Kung sa bagay, baka nga mas adbansado nang mga ilang milyun-milyonang taon talaga o bilyun-bilyonan mang taon ang mga taga-ibang-daigdig, mga alyenihena, kaysa sa ating katauhan. Baka nga nagtatago sila sa atin dahil primitibo tayo.

Ties Are Not for Thais

It is 2012-11-13. My Amazon Kindle book count has stood at 1110 books for about three weeks now.

I have spent a whole week (since the 6th) travelling Bangkok, Thailand, via Google Maps. It is a fascinating country. I did not know until a couple of days ago that Thailand has a bigger land area than Japan. My reality view has been readjusted, I suppose. Thais love their food as can be seen on the streets with industrious, enthusiastic hawkers. My personality matches a colourful place like Bangkok, much more than Lulu Island here in Canada. Where I am now is low on energy.

Since 2012-11-12, my credit card has been disabled due to an illegal transaction to "Richard K. Frederick Found." Some people do not believe in other intelligent beings besides humans. The insinuation is the Foundation series of Isaac Asimov. Thinking this way makes people believe that Homo sapiens is all-important. It is misleading.

Humans are not the centre of the universe. Richard Atwood is my sister-in-law Lucinda's engineer brother who ventured to Australia and wound up back in Canada, whilst Fred Chin was my neighbour in East Vancouver. He is a "science mind" and has a bulky body for a Chinese because he has Malay or East Indian ancestors or similar. He is not sure what they were.

Back in 2002 and several years thereafter, I regularly attended meditation sessions at Wat Yanviriya Buddhist Temple in East Vancouver. I came to know the Thai culture more because of it. Pāli chanting, moon festivals, relics viewing, et cetera were part of my life then. I remember a spacious hall with hardwood floors and a Buddha altar in front. In summers, the doors would be open to the sunny green outside. In the wetter seasons at night, candles would be lit in the

silent darkness inside. (I wore a black Australian Outback jacket then.) Omnipresent was the Ajahn Bhoontam in orange robe, he conducting the rituals. Our saṅgha or congregation was medium-sized and multiethnic. A real saṅgha full of Thais allowed us to share the rustic building. The two groups met at different times.

Before or after a temple visit, I regularly ate at a local Asiatic restaurant. I walked and walked then. It was the city. It was daytime or it was nighttime.

Abruptly, there is more about "Richard K. Frederick Found." Ursula K. Le Guin is my favourite fantasy author who wrote about assorted brown people on an archipelagic world called the "Earthsea." I often wonder why is it that she writes like a man. Some

people are wondering whether other sentient beings are humanoid in shape. Because I took biology in school, my inclination would be that some may and some may not be humanoid in form. Biology makes one appreciate the variations in nature. Indeed, as some Japanese scientists speculate, other sentient beings may be post-biological, perhaps encompassing abiotic mechanisms and intelligence that have obsoleted those from natural progression. Indeed, such thinking is beyond that of an ordinary housewife.

Crowded Desert

It is 2012-11-29.

Brian's reality view is crowded. It is teeming

with lifeforms in space and here. Probably, it is reflective of a lonely trait.

My reality view since childhood is that since the microcosm, my local neighbourhood, is like a desert, where life and especially intelligent life are rare and precious, then the macrocosm, comprising the worlds "out there," is also desolate. My reality view has no microcosm-macrocosm dissonance.

Brian's reality view requires review of epistemology, the study of the nature of knowledge. Who says it? From where does it come?

Hope Is Within, or Without?

It is 2012-12-04.

The Europeans have been pushing me to support Interlingua. They perceive wrongly that Esperanto is like a Germanic tongue, whilst it really is mainly Latinate. Propagandists promote Esperanto as blond, whilst its origins are in Eastern Europe, where most people have dark hair. Esperanto is not like a Scandinavian. Its inventor, Dr. L.L. Zamenhof, was an intelligent Jew in 19th century Russian-occupied Poland. Perhaps, Interlingua is symbolic of the blue sky and blue sea of the Mediterranean, obliquely pointing to Roman Catholicism, which some want to endear. In fact, though, the -j plural ending of Esperanto is reminiscent of Ancient Greek, also Mediterranean. Esperanto is mainly Latinate, with Germanic and Slavic influences. This concoction is what matches my personality.

Sometimes, Esperanto is like a Japanesque Latin. Some Germans think that, politically, Japan now is like Russia. On looking back, I have some regrets that I did not take German in high school because I know today that German has lots of sci-fi. Sci-fi written in or translated into Latinate languages sounds more like fantasy. I do know now bits of German through osmosis over many years.

Today, Brian uses a long wooden stick to prod his dogs Chino and Rafa. He says that it is too cold to use the water spray bottle. He talks about the emerging Plasma Universe Paradigm. He says that space is not empty. I tell him what I read in Astronomy magazine about Jupiter-sized worlds, twice as many as stars, lonely worlds wandering unanchored to a sun, or primary star. Recently, I have

been fantasizing of an elegant teahouse in orbit around such a giant world surrounded by sunless darkness. I call this quiet, eerie fantasy "La Teejo" in Esperanto, or undecidedly "la tcat. barj." in Lojban. Some men prefer a Bath and Sauna Dream.

Brian's real name is Bratislav Tepsa, which reminds me of Vlad Tepes, the Dracula, in the 15th century. He tells me that people must not dwell too much in the past, but look to the future, something to hope. My hope is to get off this planet Earth, either physically or non-physically. Whichever is the case, I know that it will happen eventually. My fate is not the same as the humans' because I know that I am not human.

Cities around the world look "dead" from

prevalent Bauhaus buildings. It seems that the spirit of humanity has been hollowed out of them.

A white man has said, "Pre-War Japan was like heaven." He is probably correct. Essentially, Pre-War Japan was like a dream.

The spiritless modern buildings are perturbing. They are everywhere now on Earth. When will this fashion change? It is like the suit-and-tie attire.

Postmodernism is a little better with its hodgepodge of historical and ethnic reminders. It competes with modernism.

The old buildings still live in some places.

When I was in Paris, three times, I was awestruck by their organicity. It was the same when I went to the rugged town of Luxor, Egypt.

Life of Anime and Pornography

It is the 30th of October of 2013.

Since my purchase of a personal data assistant, Apple's iPad mini, on the 11th of July of 2013, my life has changed drastically. It is an ingenious machine, really. I can play chess and other games against it, do art, write notes, and so on, but best of all, I can watch Japanese anime with the Crunchyroll application and watch voluptuous pornography from the XTube web site. I am in touch with the jolly gang of

linguists and polyglots at the Tatoeba web site.

Lulu Island is still Lulu Island. There are a few changes. There is more interest in Daoism. Some people think here that both Daoism and Buddhism are white and male. Some are still promoting Christianity, but feel slightly shocked after me telling them that the verb "to know" in the Bible often means "to have sex."

Halloween season is subdued on Lulu Island as has been for several years now.

I still persevere with Lojban and Esperanto, which parallel my renewed recent interest in Japanese and Italian. I have reviewed the Hebrew alphabet and I can sort of sound out words in a Hebrew dictionary. It is such

merry news from me.

It is now the 31st of October of 2013, Halloween in the afternoon, as I write this phrase. It is a little drizzle outside. The sky is grey. The Lulu Island neighbourhood looks undecorated and unexcited.

The evening passes and my family feasts on Halloween pizza and rice porridge. We have candies ready, but no kids come to our door. I hear some fireworks from outside, though.

It is now the 1st of November of 2013. My Amazon Kindle Library now has 1350 books in total, all on my iPad mini. I think that it is too big. I have a much smaller library on iBooks, currently at 97 books and 10 PDF files. I have also an Adobe "Akrobato" collection of 186 files, mostly PDF. I have 9

months' culinary issues of FOOD and Yummy magazines, both of the Philippines. All mentioned are stuffed into my iPad mini.

It is now the 6th of November of 2013. After the climax of Halloween, I have now reached 100 books and 10 PDF files on iBooks on my iPad mini. My iPad mini is like a huge library. Since the climax of Halloween, I have pondered again about Shintō and Hinduism, this latter gaining popularity in places like the Philippines, as I gather from TFC, The Filipino Channel. Shintō, like Daoism, is a form of Animism.

I have quietly dropped XTube pornography because I have become satisfied with my study of physiology and sexology.

Lojban is my preferred language now. I

recommend it, as well as Esperanto and Interlingua, to needy people in other countries, as an escape from poverty. My charity work is the promotion of these languages.

Sometimes, I think that Japan is my adopted land and its language still fascinates me, not knowing if I really do have Japanese ancestry from way back. Japan has an affinity for Italy, the land of pizza and spaghetti. Japan is unique in the world for its love of futurology without forgetting the past. Japan is a unicorn amongst the nations of this world.

It is now the 13th of November of 2013. According to my current Biodata document, from which a new numerology has sprung, the number 13 commemorates Lojban, which

has been 5, 9, or even 14.

I now do watch XTube pornography off and on using my iPad mini. It is often just a few clips of less than five minutes each.

My family suffers from various health and money concerns. There is some agitation.

I have told my friend Brian Tepsa yesterday about my fantasy of returning to the Philippines. I have told him that a good, durable house there can be gotten for less than $50 000. A condominium is affordable at about $300 a month. But alas, the logistics of dual citizenship, living in both countries, the Philippines and Canada, may be too difficult. I have told Brian that the food there in the tropics has much more variety and colour. Canada is not too bad, as

it is now. I do not like flying in aeroplanes, anymore. Brian also worries about retiring as he is now 51, having been born in 1962. By the coming January, I will turn 48.

Brian is becoming more interested in philosophy. I have sent him electronic copies of Dao Scripture, Gnostic Scripture, Hindu Scripture, Southern Buddhist Chants, and The Urantia Book. Holy Scriptures are good sources for spiritual growth. Brian and I are different people from just a year ago.

It is now the 23rd of November of 2013. On my Biodata numerology, 23 is Thai. Apple Incorporated, I guess, supports Orange. Orange is like my Vling, or Indochinese languages, or Southeast Asian languages. On the older numerology, this esoteric set was the number 15.

My iBooks stands at 110 books with zero PDF files. My Adobe "Akrobato" collection now stands at 196 files. My Amazon Kindle collection still stands at 1350 books. My iPad mini is like a huge library. Therein, I also have several months' colourful issues of the Hispanic culinary magazine Cocina Semana.

I often still watch XTube pornography on my iPad mini. The pornographers are intelligent.

Recently, I have been catching up on my Interlingua. I still support the idea of promoting Lojban, Esperanto, and Interlingua (the purple, the green, and the blue) in developing countries, with emphasis now more on composition and speaking, whilst

books are still scarce for reading.

23 is the age that I graduated from university, which was a long time ago, the year 1989.

It is now the 26th of November of 2013. I am undecided if I am more like Arthur C. Clarke, Samuel R. Delany, Olaf Stapledon, *Gargantia on the Verdurous Planet*, or Larry Niven, but I prefer these scenarios depicted as futurology. Somewhere amongst them is the near truth.

Some now are already noticing that things are really at turtles' pace.

Oh yeah, Asimov! I also like Isaac Asimov's view of futurology. He depicts a whole galaxy populated by people, but I guess that he has

doubts about aliens' existence. His Otherness comes as robots, about which he writes plentifully. He does not discount wars, of all sorts. He often talks of a kind of Animism; the whole galaxy may be endowed with a spirit.

It is now the 27th of November of 2013. My Amazon Kindle collection now stands at 1352 books.

There is a Happy Planet somewhere.

Today, I visit my father in critical condition in Richmond Hospital, Room 370. Alone with him in probably unconscious state, I say, "Hi, Papa!" And those words are all I say. Some Centralians are beyond the curtains. I walk to the family room to be

with kin. Sitting at a table, I eat a Centralian purple taro pastry, drink a styrofoam glass of Happy Planet juice, and eat vanilla ice cream. I reserve the century egg congee for later when I get home. They move my father in bed to a private room, Room 375. More kin come to visit.

It is the hope of my father to be born again on a different planet to live a new life, in a new body. He told me that it is what he believes.

It is now the 28th of November of 2013. Papa passes away in the morning. Anyway, the Earth seems not a good planet, people being mean to one another. There is a Happy Planet somewhere.

It is now the 1st of December of 2013, Sunday

evening. At the Ocean View Funeral Home in Metro Vancouver is the viewing of Papa's coffin. With kin, into the chapel, I enter carrying white flowers, which I place on a white columnar pedestal near the wooden coffin. Papa's head and upper body are viewable, in a yellow dress shirt and blue suit. With flesh sunken, he looks like my grandfather, Daddy Pito.

I am dressed darkly. On my shaven head, I am wearing a dark blue tuque with the FCB shield (*Fútbol Club Barcelona*). Barcelona seems to be my father's favourite city, which he has not visited. A shiny black leather jacket and a black sweater and a pair of shiny black dress shoes are all legacy clothing from Papa himself. My pants are black.

With the chapel still mostly empty, my mother starts combing Papa's hair with Tancho pomade, his favourite. Mama places its green plastic container within the coffin.

Before more mourning guests arrive, I have lemonade and iced tea at the dining area. The catered food includes lumpia, pansit, fruit slices, tarts, and so forth. My nieces Calla and Tria silently show me the way.

With the dining area still mostly empty, Shane Wilson, my nieces' white Canadian artist-sculptor uncle, joins me at a table. We discuss Esperanto; how it is more popular in places like Brazil, France, China, Japan, etc.; how English seems just an ordinary expectation in North America; how language-learning seems for the young; how I know that Esperanto can be learnt even later

in life; and how languages can be experienced at the Tatoeba Project web site.

The guests start streaming in. They give their condolences, and I say, "Thanks for coming." Over 300 arrive, mostly Filipinos. The Carpio couple help out emceeing and taking photographs. Mrs. Cecille Carpio is wearing something furry and grey. Mr. Tony Carpio holds an SLR digital camera. There are about 9 mournful speeches, unfortunately in English and too American-sounding. In front of the chapel is an ongoing, cyclical slide presentation of photographs of Papa's life history. Papa died at 76.

Afterwards, the crowd streams into the dining area to munch. I also eat a little, again. I love the lemonade.

Near the ending, I talk to my dark and handsome uncle, Tito Dante. He lives in Camarillo, California. I say that I like the cacti and palm trees in California. We talk about how Canada and Sweden are greyish countries. I retort that Swedes like mulled wine, wine which one drinks hot, glögg. Swedes have culture. North America seems still like a colony.

We all stream out of the chapel. It is a chilly night.

It is now the 2nd of December of 2013, Monday, the day of the burial. I decide to skip it, I going to my hideaways at Pizza Hut and the field and groves at Rideau Park. (The regular pizza lady, the East Indian Sarabjit, at Pizza Hut is like an aunt to me now:)

I do not want to see the burial. I remember that back in 2001, in the Philippines, my big cousin Carlo Medrano skipped the funeral of my maternal grandfather, Lolo Mac. I think now that what he did makes sense.

I spend time alone outside the house, in the chilly sunshine. Meanwhile, the telephone answering machine picks up a message from my cousin Myra Reyes in the Philippines. She gives her condolences in brief, masculine Tagalog.

The last book that Papa was reading was *Living Your Past Lives: The Psychology of Past-Life Regression* by Karl Schlotterbeck. That blue book was placed in the living room. I take it to my own library.

It is now the 3rd of December of 2013. My uncle Tito Ed and his wife Tita Evelyn and their friends Tito Roger and Tita Minda have sojourned at my house all through the funeral period. They are from Oregon and are returning today. I guess that they like it here in Metro Vancouver because of all the Oriental influences. Tito Ed is having a house built in the Philippines. He intends to go back and forth. With his doctor wife, he has been already visiting the Philippines once a year. Travelling elsewhere like Europe does not interest them.

Helping out, Tita Nedy is also here on Lulu Island. She worries about her prospective job in San Francisco, next year. She has been visiting us in Lulu Island at least once a year. For her rheumatism, I think that frigid

Canada is not good to her.

Yesterday, back from the burial, Tita Evelyn reported that it was a pleasant burial. My cousin Eve Ferrer quipped that they saw an eagle hovering above. (Decades ago in 1987 at my grandfather Daddy Pito's funeral, there was an owl.)

Friends and other kin have been thinking that Papa was a Christian man, but like others of his religious persuasion, he was grappling with his own perceived religion. He was reaching out to other belief systems, like Ufology and Paranormality on television and books.

Until my own death and maybe beyond, Lojban, Esperanto, and Interlingua will be my friends, all three of them.

There is a Happy Planet somewhere.

It is now the 4th of December of 2013, in the evening. Another party atmosphere transpires as it is the family friend Dindo del Mundo's birthday celebration at my house. His wife Nida and 9th grade daughter Crystal are with us.

The party food consists of fried lumpia, fried fish, green mangoes, pansit noodles, banana cake, strawberry chocolate cake, and so on. It is just a little crowd.

Meanwhile, my brothers Fernando and Paolo are busy fiddling with our wobbly home Internet connection. They are trying to fix it, anyway.

My mother's sister Tita Bella, in the Philippines, telephones earlier, talking to Tita Nedy. She asks what I want brought here to Canada as she intends to visit in July of 2014 for the Ibaan Association convention, which Tita Nedy is arranging ahead of time. I say that I want dried rimas or breadfruit.

Dindo receives legacy clothing from Papa as presented by Mama: a nice navy blue suit attire and a white Barong Tagalog.

I like the provincial Tagalog of the del Mundos. Nida is from Ibaan, Batangas, my "hometown," whilst Dindo is from Marinduque. They are different islands. They like to learn more English, but may be at least curious about Esperanto's "whitish tranquillity."

Dindo once worked for sea ships and has travelled around the world. For example, he has been to a provincial part of the northern coast of China; there, people rode their farm tractors everywhere.

Like I, Dindo was born in 1966. Verily, verily, life goes on!

It is now the 5th of December of 2013, quiet before dawn. I opine that people here have not settled down yet concerning the death of Papa. In some cultures, mourning takes a long time.

Probably because of the five-fingered working hand, the number 5 is considered by many as black. It often designates Tagalog, or even Lojban. Locally, this colour still

scares many people. Black may designate science or technology, things that make many women cringe.

I have read news on Wikipedia about space exploration by different countries. Japan and China seem to focus now on uncrewed missions to the moon. Both India and the USA have separate uncrewed missions arriving at Mars' orbit in September of 2014. They are now still in space transit, on their way there. Apparently, it takes several months to get there.

It is now the 6th of December of 2013, morning. I have been studying some about space exploration:

Nozomi (Japanese for "Wish" or "Hope," and known pre-launch as Planet-B) was planned

as a Mars-orbiting aeronomy probe, but it could not achieve Mars' orbit due to electrical failures. Operation reportedly terminated on the 31st of December of 2003. Apparently, Mars is Planet-B, so Earth must be Planet-A.

The two currently Mars-bound missions are USA's MAVEN and India's MOM:

MAVEN stands for the Mars Atmosphere and Volatile Evolution mission, which has already launched. "Maven" is also a Hebrew word, via Yiddish, for an expert. I opine that the word "evolution" may allude to Olaf Stapledon. It is not silly.

India's Mars Orbiter Mission (MOM), informally called Mangalyaan (Sanskrit for "Mars-Craft"), has already launched. The

Sanskrit word sounds a bit like "Mongolian."

Experts are thinking that Mars, Planet-B, may be humanity's next home. I suppose that habitats underground or above ground may be constructed. Otherwise, terraforming the reddish Martian landscape would be costly and would take perhaps generations. Terraforming would modify the atmosphere and make green the terrain to be more suited for humans. With current technology, it seems far-fetched, but it may be possible one day.

I guess that some aspects about current space exploration remain top secret information, shielded from public view. There is, apparently, international competition. The public may be exposed to some propaganda, so that they do not know the truth.

Mars is Planet-B, apparently, the next home of humanity. It will take a long, long time, I bet.

It is still the 6th of December of 2013, around noon. All 4 of my living immediate family have lunch at Chongqing, a spicy Sìchuān cuisine restaurant in Burnaby, Metro Vancouver. Fernando, my elder brother, drives us in the red Mercedes which Papa gave him when he was still on Earth.

It is chilly weather, with some clouds and some sunshine. Today is my first visit to Papa's grave at Ocean View Funeral Home. Using the closest building as a marker, I can see that the grave lies between the 2nd and 3rd columns. In the field, Papa's grave lies between the burials of Cando and Rickovic. My two brothers, Mama, and I saunter around the grave after placing flowers.

Paolo, my younger brother, says to me, "You should have seen the eagles." Some report that there were 3, even 4, eagles hovering during the burial day.

Then we go into the building. We talk to a tallish, white-haired, bearded man named Bob Barker in a room with a table. We decide on the grave plaque. Mama wants the second part of Psalm 23:6 on it. My brothers quip that they would prefer cremation for themselves. I am not sure about that method because any remains left could be cloned in the future, just in case. In any case, I would not prefer English on my own plaque; I would like Esperanto on it. Mama settles accounts with Mr. Barker. Apparently, grave real estate has boomed.

Afterwards, my family drives off to the relatively nearby big Bosa Foods ("since

1957") to buy delicious Italian goodies. It feels all Mediterranean-like, Christmas-like inside the brick building. Lulu Island has nothing like it because the Italian population is not as big over there.

It is now the 7th of December of 2013, nighttime on Lulu Island. I study more about space exploration:

Apparently, the Mars Express mission of the ESA (European Space Agency) has been operational for over 10 years. It inserted into Mars' orbit on the 25th of December of 2003.

I fear that a religious war may brew even in outer space.

Mars' waistline is about half of Earth's. Mars' surface area is about a third of Earth's. Mars' gravity is more than a third of Earth's, so

Earthlings would feel lighter on their feet. Children born on Mars would be used to lighter gravity.

It is now the 8th of December of 2013, morning. 8-legged creatures are the octopus, the crab, and the spider. 8 may also signify Interlingua. "Octo" is 8 in Interlingua. Many Japanese like this language.

Zamenhof Day is coming up on the 15th of this chilly month, December. It commemorates the birthday of Esperanto's inspiring creator, Dr. L. L. Zamenhof. I do not usually do anything special on that day. I just want to remember it.

I still promote Lojban, Esperanto, and Interlingua for developing countries. It is a good idea, really.

It is now the 7th of July of 2014. I celebrate Tanabata, the Japanese Star Festival, by watching the stars at night, on the balcony. My iPad mini's astronomy apps really help peer through the clouds. The ancient legend is about the stars Vega and Altair.

It is now the 11th of July of 2014. It is my first time to vicariously travel Greece via Google Maps. It is really more convenient than my physical travel of Greece back in 2002. Recently, also some cities in Peru and Colombia have become open for fascinating virtual excursions on Google Maps. I use my iPad mini's iMaps+ app.

It is now Saturday, the 12th of July of 2014. My Chinese neighbours Irene, Fred, and RJ have a garage sale, from which I buy 8 Chinese books, including the translation of George Orwell's 1984. It is really a prize, a

treasure about an alternate history of three competing supernations—Oceania, Eurasia, and Eastasia—on Earth. All the books are in the most modern form of logograms, often called "Simplified Chinese" as contrasted with "Traditional Chinese." The family are ground floor tenants of Chinese-Indian Molly Wong and Chinese Leong Wong, both from Fiji. Their house with a big back balcony is next to and north of my home on Rideau Drive on Lulu Island.

My visiting plump auntie, Tita Bella, a sister of my mother, takes part in the garage sale by buying all sorts of trinkets. Tita Bella is always full of stories, especially about our Philippine hometown of Ibaan and about trips to neighbouring Asian countries. She loudly and jollily tells of exotic Ibaan cooking, bonsai-gardening with exotic tropical trees, daily eating "Peking Duck" in

her stay in Beijing, and so forth.

It is now the 19th of July of 2014. My Amazon Kindle book collection now numbers 1370 books in total. My iBooks collection numbers 230 books in total. My Akrobato collection now has 233 documents. My iPad mini is a huge multilingual library.

As of now, both Mangalyaan and MAVEN spacecraft are more than three-quarters of their journey to Mars, hundreds of millions of kilometres away from our Terra.

Nowadays, I still endeavour to learn Esperanto and Lojban. I have again started listening to Pola RetRadio, which broadcasts in Esperanto from Warsaw, every three or four days, through the Web. I like perusing my Lojban dictionaries. I know that I can always write something good in Lojban with

the help of these dictionaries. I have written in Lojban since 2005, but much more in 2011 and 2012. I have proven myself. I know the grammar quite well.

It is now the 20th of July of 2014. I have been reading about China's Mars exploration Yinghuo-1 spacecraft that, along with a Russian Fobos-Grunt sample return spacecraft, piggybacked a Ukrainian Zenit rocket that launched from Baikonur Cosmodrome in Kazakhstan, on the 8th of November of 2011. Yinghuo-1 was intended for exploring the Martian atmosphere and sandstorms amongst other things. However, the spacecraft crashed into the Pacific Ocean on the 15th of January of 2012. It was a great disappointment.

On the subject of religion, for more than a week now, I have been using the Religion

Crash Course by Brainscape on my iPad mini. My score is 52% to 57%, so I have passed. It is a flashcards examination about Hinduism, Buddhism, Islam, Judaism, Christianity, and Chinese Religion (app's order). I estimate that most people, perhaps more than 80%, would not get a passing grade on this examination. So, I am quite knowledgeable about religions.

It is now the 30th of July of 2014. My personality now revolves around three languages mainly, one natural language, Japanese, and a duo of artificial languages, Lojban and Esperanto. Esperanto is like a Jewish language and it epitomizes all the other Latinate languages that I know. Esperanto symbolizes European civilization, Japanese Asian, and Lojban the rest. With these 3, I feel like a whole man. Red Mars has two moons, Phobos and Deimos.

Nowadays, I feel that Religion is much fantasy. I embrace Science, the perpetual self-correcting paradigm. I am still wading in the influences of Dharmic religions, Hinduism and Buddhism. And whilst I prefer a generic, postmodern form of Animism, I still cherish the notions in Shintō and Dao. But in fact, I am less religious these days, still just spiritual.

It is now the 21st of October of 2014. Halloween is rapidly approaching, although I have celebrated ahead of time as I have listened to a Dracula story in Spanish on my iPad mini. Here on Lulu Island, due to so many Asian foreigners, one does not really celebrate Halloween as one does in my old neighbourhood in East Vancouver that is full of character houses. Lulu Island here is more solemn.

What are on the minds of locals? People here are thinking more of their mortality as they have been exposed to Buddhism and Asian ways. People do not understand that Buddhism tries to eliminate suffering, not dwell in it. For those who do not understand, this religion becomes psychotoxic. People here are afraid of the number 4 because here it stands for Buddhism as sometimes the white colour. People here think more about poverty too because they do not know the principles of Communism. They just think that Market Capitalism with its central casino called the stock exchange is the natural order of things. It is contrived. Poverty is in the mind. I have learnt more about the good ol' Soviet Union days from my multiethnic Soviet friends at the local Pizza Hut. Everybody had a job and housing was not a problem.

People did not love money. Children loved their free camping days. University was free.

On the lighter side of things, I have been studying languages as usual. I speak to myself in Esperanto more often; I am like a sole *Esperantisto* in the whole solemn Anglosphere. Esperanto I liken more to Romanian because it is a Slavic-influenced Latinate language, although Esperanto also has bits of Germanic.

There are more languages. I watch Japanese anime with Spanish subtitles on my iPad mini. I study more Mongoloid languages like Thai, Indonesian, Classical Nahuatl (Aztec), Yucatec Mayan, Quechua, Guaraní, Tahitian, Samoan, Hawaiian, and Korean. But I also study the Arabic alphabet and a bit of Turkish. Nahuatl now I know much better. It is a very daydreaming language.

The Thai alphasyllabary I have memorized about 90%. Sometimes, I think that I should just stick to Esperanto and Lojban. All these other studies are just distractions from my true path, I opine now. These two, Esperanto and Lojban, are my loves.

I travel much vicariously through stereoscopic satellite imaging on my iPad mini. I have been so happy that I am able to see much of Bangkok, Ayutthaya, Phuket, Chiang Mai, and Chiang Rai in vibrant orange Thailand. I am so happy to see Jakarta and Bali in circumcised Indonesia. I have been to selected spots in the Middle Kingdom as well. I like it because it is like a "boring country." There are lots of big structures. There are lots of new shopping malls. Having also looked at Japan all over, I opine that the Japanese look more comfortable and more spiritual.

The Japanese have really influenced my thinking through their animes. One of my favourites is Gargantia on the Verdurous Planet, which is about the far future wherein there are three subspecies of humanity. One has remained on Terra. Two others, one of which has become a breed of monsters, colonize space. The timeline is many thousands of years. The Japanese think well beyond the present time. I much admire them for their insight. Japan is different from the rest of humanity today.

I am like a Filipino-Japanese. It is my identity, though many might disagree with me.

In my Amazon Kindle book collection on my iPad mini, I have now 1371 books. My iBooks stands at 280 books. And my

Akrobato collection has now 238 documents, including books.

It is now the 27th of October of 2014. My neighbourhood here on Lulu Island still has no Halloween decorations, unlike in more festive parts of autumnal Canada.

In Apple's iTunes in the Internet, I have stashed 59 sci-fi videos of movies and television episodes, many of which I already watched as a youngster. They are mostly nostalgic for me.

Sometimes now, I opine that happenings are a result of superior god-like puppeteer beings, who manipulate humans and other lesser beings here on Terra. We are under their spell.

As for my path in life, I will be faithful to

verdant Esperanto and to violet Lojban, the essences of the West and of the East.

It is now the 30th of October of 2014. It is a rainy day before Halloween. No one looks excited here on Lulu Island. I think that it may partially be due to the ethnic mix here, but in more exciting East Vancouver, where I once lived, there were also many Asians, but amongst Italians, Hispanics, and other groups.

On a different note, my Akrobato electronic collection now stands at 239 documents as I have just added the enormous 3124-page Nostratic Dictionary by Aharon Dolgopolsky. It is about the Nostratic language macrofamily, the theory of a common ancient origin of several language families on our Terra. The work is like a detective story, piecing words together.

Lust still plays a role in my life. I often watch pornography on the XTube video site. I have watched over 1000 pornographic clips in the more than year that I have had my iPad mini. Bodies are like sculptures. Their intimacy is interesting.

Esperanto and Lojban make me happy. How can languages make me happy? One may ask. Languages take me to different worlds. A language can be like a place, yet in the mind.

I have been travelling all over Southeast Asia by stereoscopic satellite imaging on my iPad mini. There are many similarities amongst the countries. The region seems "browner" than what I have previously imagined. The region is a transcultural intersection. It is fascinating. The Bauhaus architecture seems similar to those seen in other parts of the

world. What makes a place different from others seems really the food!

It is now the 31st of October of 2014. It is a rainy Halloween. It seems to be an uneventful day, in any case. The Halloween spirit has withered in this part of Canada. In Esperanto, my province British Columbia (BC) is "Brita Kolumbio" (BK). The abbreviation BK sounds as "Boko" in Esperanto. So, I am in a boring part of Boko. I am "Viktoro el BK," Viktor from BC. I like Esperanto as it is part of my Latino self. Spanish, too, is part of it. I am glad about my collection of Spanish books. I have a precious array of sci-fi and fantasy books in Spanish. Spanish always reads like poetry. Spanish is one of my ancestral languages. Yay!

It is now the 1st of November of 2014. I opine

that Lulu Islanders just do not understand how important Halloween is. Halloween allows us to face the theme of death with humour and feasting. It celebrates the colours orange, black, and purple. Halloween springs from very ancient traditions, both Xtian and pagan. An encyclopedia could tell one about its mysterious beginnings.

Anyway, when I was a youngster here on Lulu Island, I enjoyed Halloween. I could fill a whole large plastic bag of sweets from joyful trick-or-treating, door-to-door. That time, Saunders Road nearby still had ancient character homes.

In other parts of Canada, one probably still joyfully celebrates Halloween, even in other parts of "Boko." Canada in Esperanto is "Kanado" (with the accent on the second

syllable).

Inevitably, my durable toys are Esperanto and Lojban. They make sense to me. I am both an Esperantist and a Lojbanist.

It is now the day after Valentine's Day. It is the 15th of February of 2015. In Japan, on Valentine's Day, the girls give gifts like chocolates to the boys. A month later, on the 14th of March, on White Day, the boys return the love expression with gifts like white chocolates to the girls. The custom is different here in Canada, where there is only that one day on the 14th of February.

Talking about languages, I am still in love with my Japanese the Red. More Kanji to memorize are all that I need. My fantasy intertwines with the Amerindoid ambiance in the animes Naruto Shippūden and

Kemono no Sōja Erin and others.

My Tagalog the Black is quite healthy. It is yet another Amerindoid ambiance fantasy. I regularly contribute to the corpus at the Tatoeba Project.

In Japan and other parts of Asia, people like Interlingua the Blue and Esperanto the Green. Some Japanese think that now is still like the Meiji Era, when they still can learn more from the West. The Japanese experiment with many new paradigms such as Olaf Stapledon's "Everybody-is-still-an-ape" paradigm to the more controversial Blade Runner's "Everybody-is-an-android" paradigm amongst others. The Japanese are open-minded. (I am still in love with Lojban the Purple Language.)

On a more personal note, I am still able to

make new friends, even that I know that I cannot keep them for long when they go away. Amongst others from the delivery gang of Pizza Hut are two Russian-speaking friends, the Ukrainian Yaroslav and the Kazakh Adil. The ex-Soviet peoples are highly educated. I do miss talking to Bratislav "Brian" Tepsa about Ufology and starry philosophy. (Brian left the neighbourhood in May of 2014.) As long as people can still make friends is fine.

By the way, my book collections are stabilizing. My iBooks collection stands at 288 books. My Akrobato collection contains 239 books and documents. My Amazon Kindle collection is under 1400 books. Moreover, I have thousands of other books scattered in print and in electronic form. I also collected thousands of beautiful graphics files. My personal data assistant (PDA), my

iPad mini, is really handy.

On the astronomy front, NASA's MAVEN space probe reached Mars' orbit on the 22nd of September of 2014. India's Mangalyaan inserted into Mars' orbit on the 24th of September of 2014. Now in February of 2015, both are still circling Mars as they collect data. Some say that Mars is the future home of humanity. Maybe, Venus would be another. There would be three brown balls.

I am more interested in cosmology now than in astronomy. Physical cosmology is the "study of the origin, evolution, large-scale structures and dynamics, and ultimate fate of the universe." The vast cosmic "watershed" in which Earth finds itself is called Laniakea, from Hawaiian for "immeasurable heaven." (Hawaiian 'lani' is cognate with Tagalog's 'langit'.)

Anyway, Yaroslav likes drama books, like Tolstoy's. He does not like speculative fiction or ufology. He is a seaman, a ship engineer, and has seen much of the world. He strangely has the philosophy of "being plain."

Anyway, Adil is knowledgeable about Central Asia. His Kazakhstan is a desert country with food much as what the Arabs and Turks eat. Adil is like Genghis Khan. He likes anthropology and linguistics.

I still immerse myself in speculative fiction. I watch lots of new anime. I sometimes watch my old sci-fi video collection. Irreality helps explain reality. I do not now meet people with this interest as I easily did in high school and in university. Back then, friends with this interest were really common.

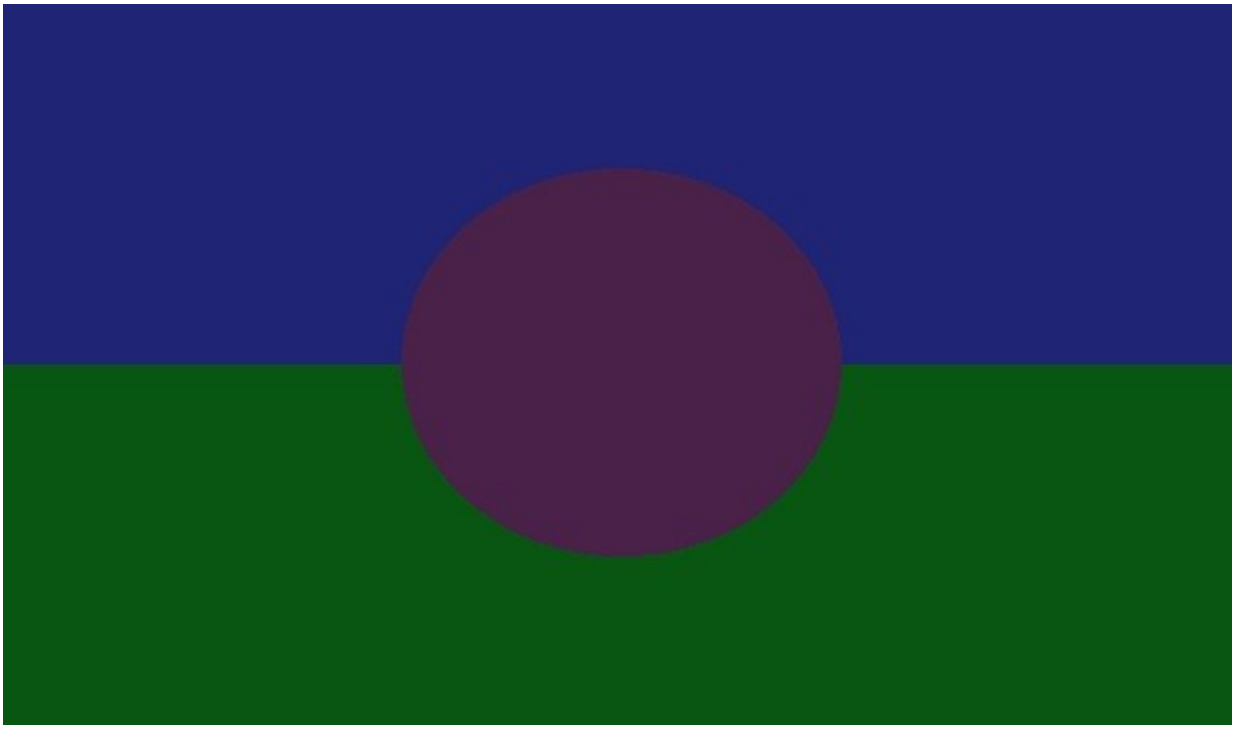
Pornography is still interesting for me. The nude actors have many secrets that they want to share. Many people do not understand why I watch pornography. They go through life not knowing the inner secrets of naked people as they use their bodies to pump, jiggle, and secrete. The psychology is fascinating. Not many understand.

Anyway, life, like a Ferris wheel, keeps rolling on.

It is now the 1st of April of 2015. I have now 299 books and documents in my iBooks collection. Just under 1400 books are in my Amazon Kindle collection. All these multilingual books are electronic.

Still, Esperanto and Lojban both win the Viktor's Award for Best Language. It is the

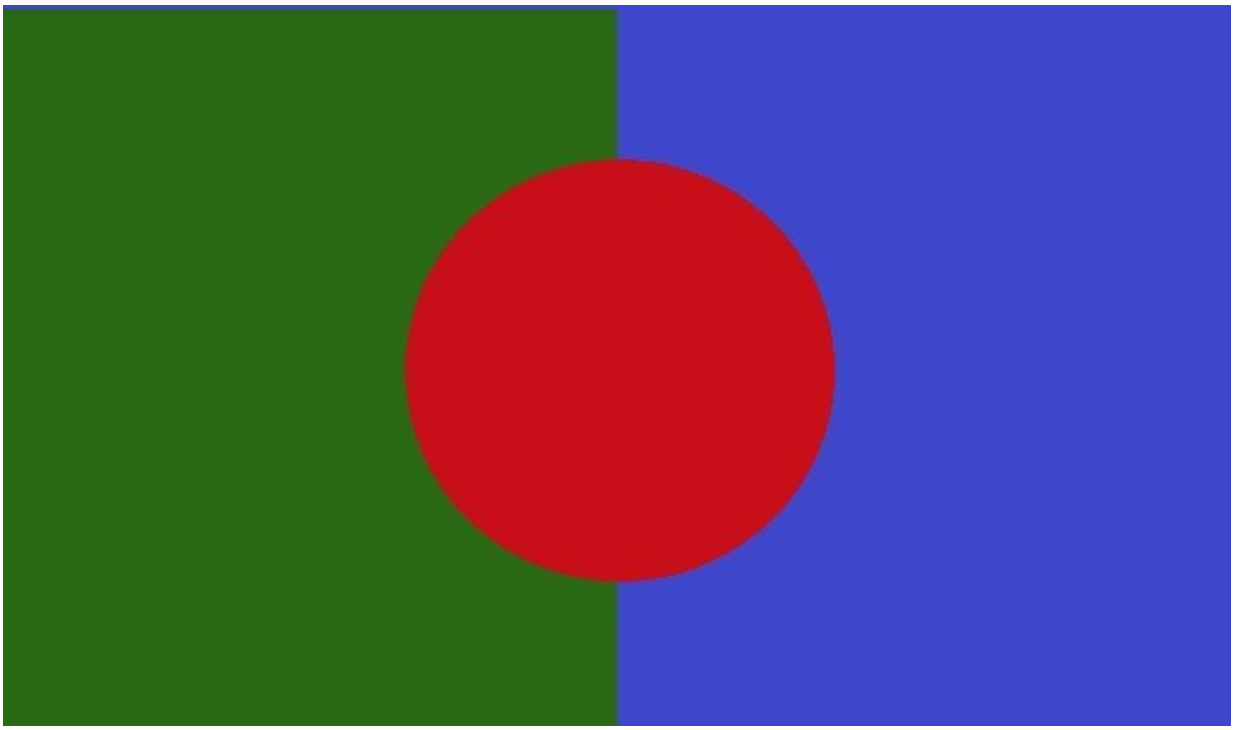
wise way of the Green and Purple.



It is now the 23rd of May of 2015. Today, I create a beautiful flag for my geofiction, my fictional country, which I call Nonongia. (My nickname is Nonong.) The flag is about the blue Interlingua sky, the green Esperanto field, and the purple Lojban celestial globe. This configuration is my personality today.

It is now the 3rd of June of 2016. My

multilingual Amazon Kindle collection now stands at 1430 e-books in total. My multilingual iBooks collection now stands at 393 e-books and 37 audiobooks.



My flag today consists of a green field for Esperanto, a blue field for Latinate languages, like Spanish, Portuguese, and French, and a red disk for Asian languages, like Tagalog, Lojban, and Japanese.

I have amassed a valuable collection of Asiatic and other ethnic pornography. It is a real treasure.

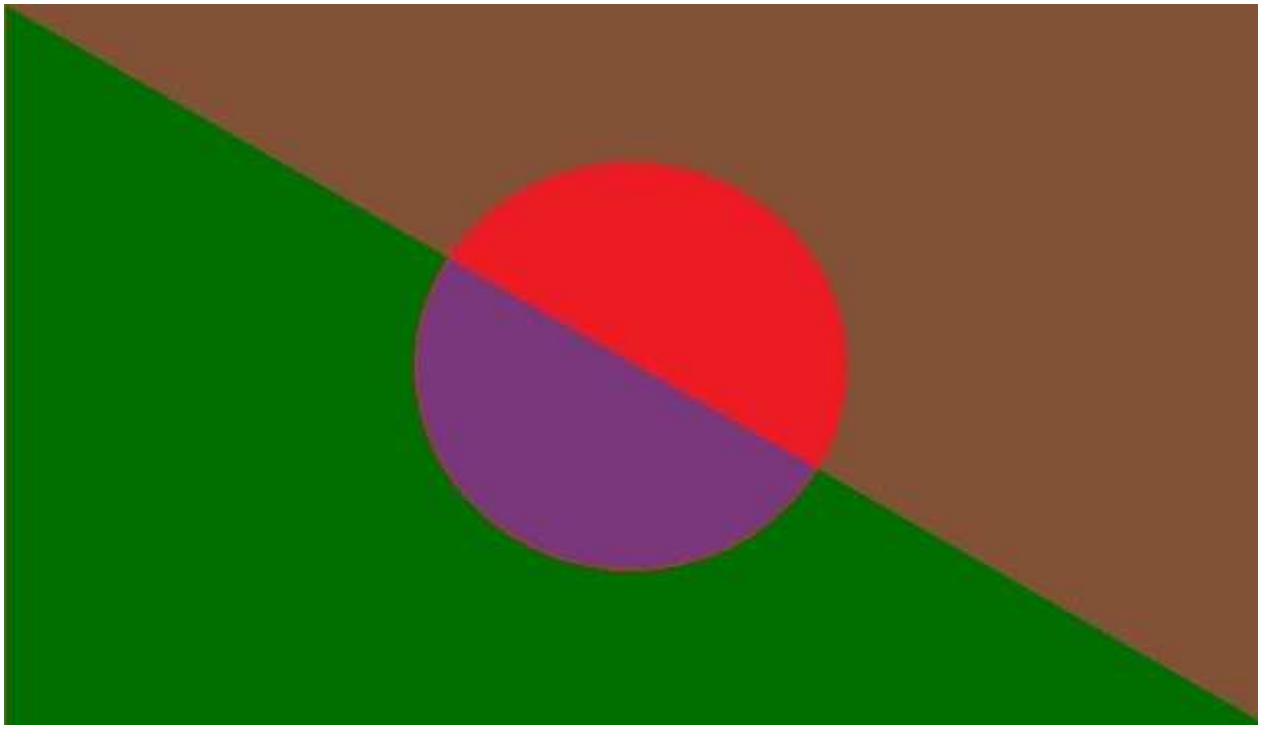
As for belief systems, I now tend to Scientism, as in science fact and sci-fi, technology and science. I more believe that religion is just make-believe.

My favourite haunts these days are two 7-11 stores in my neighbourhood and the local Pizza Hut. Lulu Island seems like a lethargic community. Many more older people live here, as schools are closing down because the young population is dwindling.

My muse these days is still my Apple iPad mini, a personal data assistant. With it, with stereoscopic satellite imaging, I have travelled to Sri Lanka, Bali, the Balearic Islands, and many other places on this world.

This world is still full of wonder for me. And what lies beyond this world is a real mystery. I persist in astronomy and cosmology. This year 2016 is Star Trek's 50th year. It is no coincidence that I was born also in 1966. It is a secret semaphore.

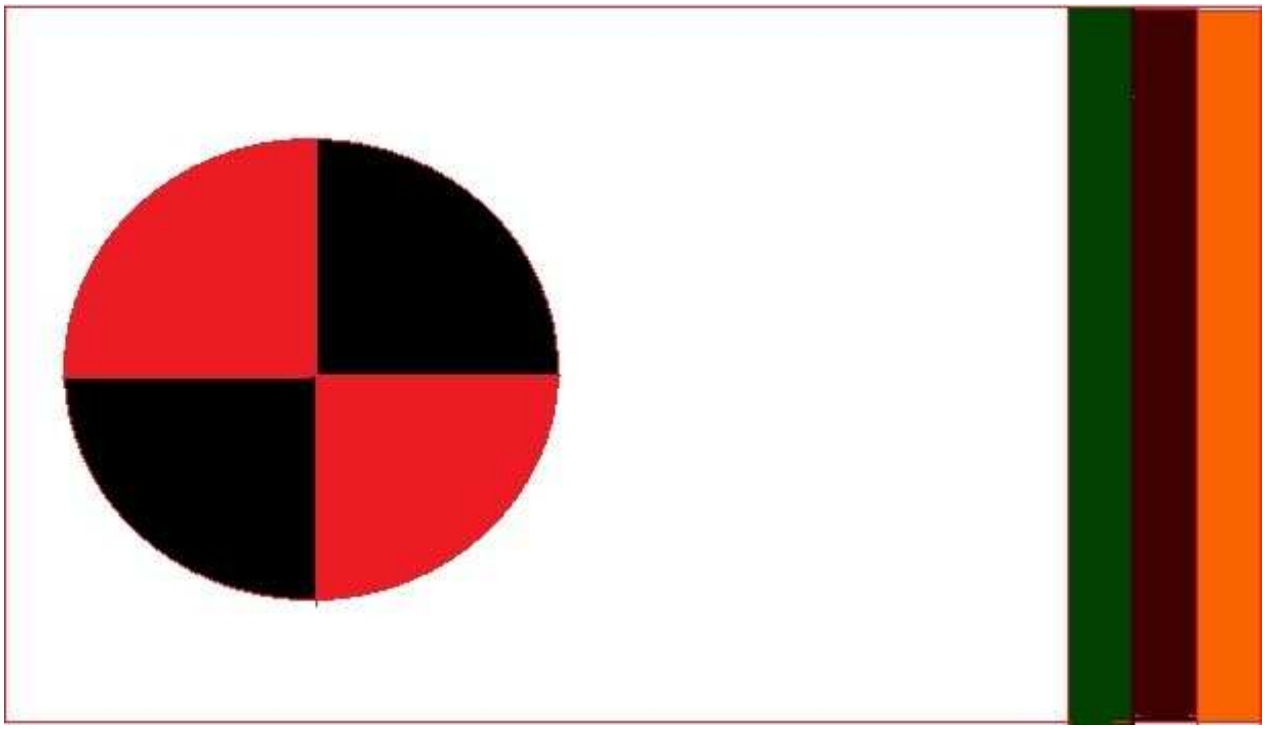
It is now the 4th of June of 2016. My iBooks audiobooks have increased to 39. I just love my favourite sci-fi books read aloud.



My new flag today has a greenish field for

Esperanto, a brownish field for Latinate languages, a reddish hemisphere for Asiatic languages, and a purplish hemisphere for Lojban. Sigh!

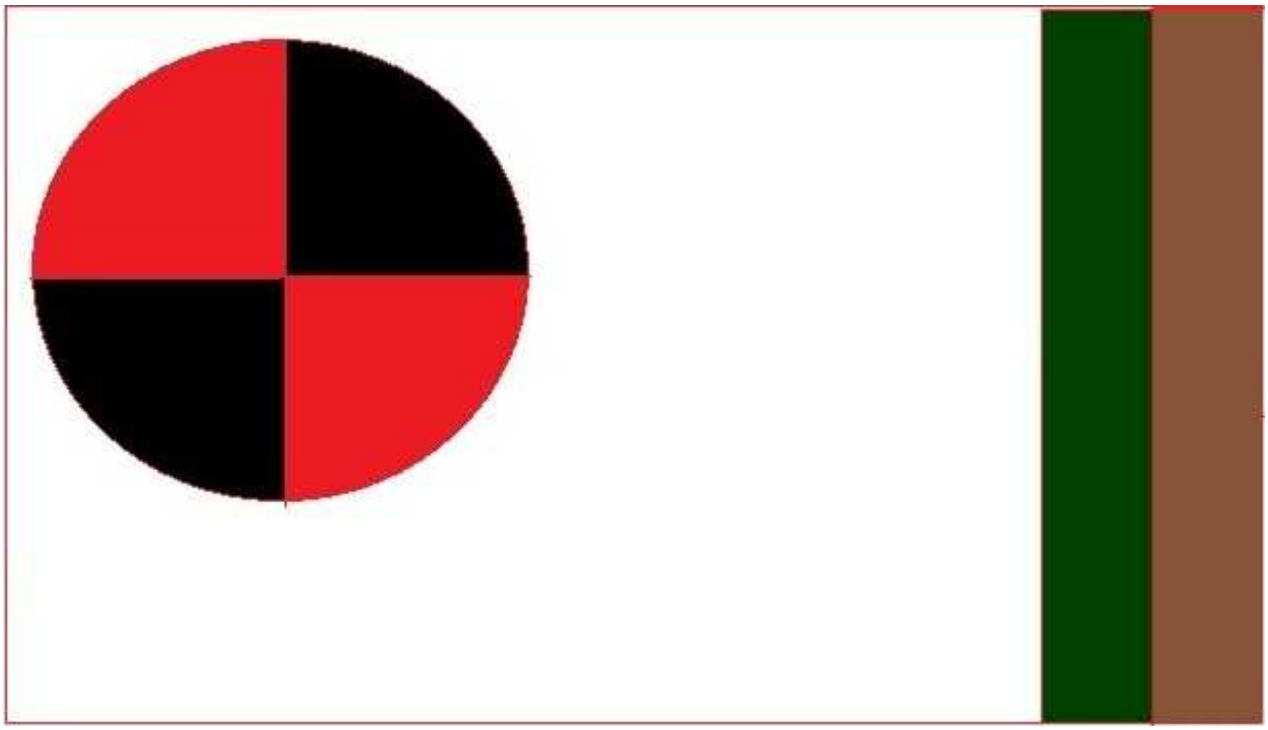
It is now the 5th of June of 2016. My new flag does not need explaining.



It is some hours later into the 5th of June of 2016. My iBooks audiobooks have grown to 47. I really enjoy my favourite sci-fi books

read aloud.

I have rearranged my flag a bit. Again, it needs no explanation, except that it mainly deals with languages, like Japanese and Tagalog, and others.



It is now the 13th of June of 2016. My iBooks audiobooks have expanded to 71, and iBooks e-books to 395. Hearing my favourite sci-fi books read aloud is a spiritual experience.

2016-09-28 I've been to Europe 5 times so far: 1995, 1998, 2000, 2002, and 2004. I can say, since I've been there physically, that it's not like the multilingual Tatoeba Web forum, which is just propaganda about Europe. Europe still holds some magic, not present in North America. Tatoeba is not reality.

2016-10-01 Like many Trekkers, I define wealth differently from other people. Star Trek defines what is being rich. Being rich for me is about living in the future, perhaps with a likeable occupation with Starfleet, as I could be an astrobiologist or exobiologist. There would be recreation time on the holodeck. Or there would be real vacation on the pleasure planet Risa. I could have any food or drink I would want, simply by ordering the food replicator. Being rich is

something different for us Trekkers.

2016-10-01 Pasado nang hatinggabi, naroon si Vince na trabahador sa 7-11. Sabi niyang Taga-Iloilo siya. At ang lengguwahe roon ay Ilonggo. Sabi niyang may malalapit na mga bayang may magkahawig na lengguwahe sa Ilonggo. Halos lahat nang mga Pilipino ay marunong ng Tagalog bilang si Vince. Malaki siyang lalaki at mukhang parang pinsan ko. Bago pa siya sa Kanada...

2016-10-02 Mga hatinggabi, kinausap ko si Vince na trabahador sa 7-11. Sabi niya'y nag-aaral siya ng Ingles at Java para sa kompyuter. Gusto niya ang trabahong tekniko dahil mas malaki ang "sahod." Tinanong ko ang "tatak" na pagkain sa Iloilo. Iyon pala ay ang batchoy. "Beynte uno" lang ang edad ni Vince. Ang pahiwatig niya'y

para akong Ferengi o Talaxian sa Star Trek dahil talagang mas matangkad siya kaysa sa akin. Narito sa Kanada ang pamilya niya. Wala pa siyang asawa. "Ayaw pang magkalat" ang sabi niya.

2016-10-08 Pasado nang hatinggabi, kinausap ko si Vince sa 7-11. Sabi niya'y nagtratrabaho rin siya sa Esso, na binili ng 7-11. Tungkol sa kompyuter, tinanong ko sa kanya, "Kamusta ang pag-aaral mo?" Sabi niya, "Nag-iipon pa muna..." Sabi kong talagang mas madali ang Java kaysa sa C++, at may bagong C# na parang naging obskuro. Sabi niya'y may kilala siyang magaling magprogram, pero hindi siya makaturo. May Intsik na kostumer na nagsabi kay Vince, "Sa tingin niya, mas parang Hapon ka!" Oo, nga. Ang mga tagaprobinsiya, sa labas ng Maynila, ay mas parang Hapon. Taga-Iloilo si Vince...

2016-10-08 Pinapansin ni Vince na ang mga keywords sa mga lengguwaheng pangkompyuter ay Ingles, kaya ang mga teknokrato sa buong itong daigdig ay nangangailangang marunong ng kahit na kaunting Ingles. Ang Java, C++, HTML, at mga ganoon ay hindi Ingles, pero ang mga keywords nga ay Ingles. Kahit na ginawa sa Suwisa ang Modula-2, ginamit nila ang Ingles para sa mga keywords.

2016-10-08 Alam ng Hapon na wala pang mabisang teknolohiya para sa espasyo. Naghihintay sila ng mas mahusay na gamit. Mas malimit ang paggamit ngayon nang robot sa eksplorasyon sa espasyo, imbis nang may tao. Hindi hinihiwalay ng Hapon ang teknolohiya sa lipunan ng tao dahil hindi parang Amerikano ang isip nila para sa mga ganoon. Alam ng Hapong mas parang pagong ang tao ngayon tungkol sa espasyo. Hindi

pa tipaklong o palaka...

2016-10-09 Itong umaga, kinausap ko si Vince na trabahador sa 7-11. Sabi niya'y masaya sa kanila at may mga pista-pista. Taga-Iloilo siya. Pinag-usapan namin ang pagkain bilang kilawin, bola-bolang isda, at batchoy sa kanila.

2016-10-15 Sabi ni Vince sa 7-11 ay walang Halloween sa Iloilo, kundi "Araw ng Kamatayan." (Sa katotohanan, iyon ay "Araw ng mga Patay.") May kaunting gumagaya sa mga Amerikano sa mga mall sa Maynila, pero hindi sa mga bahay-bahay. May *Día de los Muertos* naman sa Meksiko. Hindi alam ni Vince ang "Gabi ng Pangangaluluwa."

2016-10-17 Nanunuod ako ng *Chacun son île* (Bawat Isa'y May Isla) ni Sophie Fouron sa

Pranses na TV5. Maganda pala sa Réunion at sa Cuba. Mga kulay-kape ang tao. Hindi parang hotdog ang teleseryeng ito.

2016-10-18 Many Japanese think China is still dominantly a poor country. Cities and countryside have wide disparities, as in Nigeria, India, and China itself. Nevertheless, one can say that one can find "wealth" in logographic writing, highly homonymic speech, much food variety, colourful wares, beautiful scenery, etc. What really is wealth?

2016-10-19 It is the Halloween season... My iBooks e-books stand at 395 in total, and my iBooks audiobooks stand at 113 in total. On my Netflix app on my Apple iPad mini, I watch the various six Star Trek series, dubbed in French and in Italian, to celebrate the 50th year. There is rumour that a seventh

series is coming up in 2017. My new haunt these days is the local ice cream parlour Dairy Queen, which began melancholically, but people there seem to be adjusting. It is just typical of Anglo-Saxon culture to be so gloomy. For the Halloween season, I am collecting beautiful images from Japan and Mexico. In 2016, I have strengthened my knowledge of Elefen, a kind of Latinate creole mimicry. But I realize now that my everlasting predilection is to Esperanto, as I can speak it very well now...

2016-10-19 I meet Zade, a person of East Indian descent from East Africa. We are just outside a local shopping mall. Zade greets, "What have you been up to?" I say, "Nothing much, really. It's sweet to do nothing..." adding a European saying. Then, we start talking about travelling. I say, "I don't have a passport. Travelling's mostly visual." I

continue, "If you just want to see architecture, like I do, then Google Maps or iMaps+ is good enough. Massive graphic data are stored in supercomputers. Imagine you can move around the images like you're there. I'm satisfied with my real travelling. I've been to Europe, Asia, Africa,..." Zade replies, "Yeah, there's a different energy in Europe. You've been there... Everything's old. There's history. And it's not just the buildings. You've made the connection!" He likes Hawaii because of "energy" again. I say, "You'd like Hawaii because of biology... the hibiscus, palm trees..." He says, "...plumeria!" Zade just loves Hawaii, and he keeps going there. I've visited Hawaii by satellite stereoscopic imaging, and I think that many of the residences and other buildings there just look like cold Oregon's. My perspective is different because I'm from the Philippines and Japan. Zade likes to

read sci-fi and spiritual books. Later in the evening at the local ice cream parlour, a little Eurasian girl, sitting with her white daddy, says, "Victor thinks it's just an ugly place..." She is part of the Eagle agents' what I call *Fantasia Exhibition*, showcasing Eurasian families and individuals. I ask in my mind, "What is a beautiful place?" Well, probably, it's what I read and see in sci-fi. Somebody after midnight by a local dark alleyway says, "They know you like Egypt..." Indeed, Egypt was like a different planet for me.

2017-01-19 I like this year's number "2017." I gleefully have been watching the six Star Trek series in dubbed Spanish on the Netflix app of my Apple iPad mini. Via the Web, I sometimes listen to Radio El Fonógrafo from Mexico, and it soothes me. For years, I have been reading French books, but now I

think my Spanish needs more attention. Spanish translations as sci-fi Titán by Ben Bova and historical drama Azteca by Gary Jennings really impress me. Spanish is like chocolate or sticky rice cake.

On the Tatoeba project and forum, I usually contribute licorice Tagalog and zucchini Esperanto sentences, but occasionally coconut Hawaiian. Unfortunately, the Web is still much as it was in the middle 1990's. Neurotics and psychotics still use the Web as a garbage dump.

These days, I see no one as intellectual as the ufologist Bratislav "Brian" Tepsa or the sci-fi fan Don Chan. I see lots of "feminine" religious folk, but I do not prefer talking about religion, especially if it is about Western religion. These days, I swing towards irreligion.

For many years now, I have lived a kind of Dào-Dharma existence. I walk a lot, having no automobile. My regular haunts are two 7-11 stores and the DQ ice cream parlour in my neighbourhood. It is a small universe in which I encounter the bigger universe.

I discuss more about languages. I still believe in green jade Esperanto and purple amethyst Lojban. Unlike others, I learn languages not to meet people, as I am not really lonely, but I like solitude. I learn languages because I like the sound and the look of the text, as languages are art objects. I know bits of Mandarin and Cantonese now by gradual absorption through the years, but these yellow lemon languages are too political here on Lulu Island, where I live. I want to learn more Thai and Vietnamese, but these orange kumquat languages are too political here as

well. My red cherry Japanese these days involves forums on Google+ about desserts, coffee, rāmen, books, and temples or shrines. I watch anime with the Japanese audio, my current, delicious favourite series being Vampire Knight. About pink grapefruit English, I listen to fascinating audiobooks of Olaf Stapledon, Star Maker and Last and First Men. It is amazing what people knew about astronomy, history, biology, etc. back in the 1930's, when Stapledon wrote them.

My iBooks collection still stands at 113 audiobooks and 395 e-books. My Amazon Kindle collection stands at 1430 e-books.

Some religious people have a strange opinion about "learning." They complain that some are still just learning. What is wrong with that behaviour? They think if they are watching sitcoms or the dreary news on

television, then they are not learning. They really are learning, but maybe learning garbage. Not only Jews like learning, but also Germans, Chinese, Japanese, Koreans, and lots of other people. The problem is that some people already feel "too old" to feel studious. I think learning does not really stop. I know many do not believe it. People have to be selective in what they learn, and such includes what they watch on television. Sigh!

2017-01-20 I have acquired 5 new e-books on my iBooks for my Apple iPad mini, the total e-books now standing at a whopping 400! The newly acquired, all of which are in Spanish, are about the history, philosophy, and analyses of science fiction, as well as some science fiction stories. I am anticipating the delicious moments when I actually read them.

2017-01-21 I have been travelling vicariously via Street View on my iMaps+ app on my Apple iPad mini. I have seen much of this world. I like looking at Japan, Philippines, Sri Lanka, Finland, Sweden, Taiwan, Indonesia, Hawaii, Thailand, Australia, New Zealand, South Africa, Czech Republic, France, Greece, Spain, Portugal, Italy, Turkey, Romania, and much of Latin America. I like this virtual travel, as it is not so hectic and tiresome as real physical travel, of which I have done a lot years ago.

2017-01-28 I like many anime shows from Japan. Some of my really creative favourites include Vampire Knight, Gargantia on the Verdurous Planet, No. 6, Mushi-Shi, Naruto Shippūden, Kemono no Sōja Erin, Moribito: Guardian of the Spirit, The Mystic Archives of Dantalian, Galaxy Express 999, Xam'd:

Lost Memories, Fate/Zero, Level E, La storia della Arcana Famiglia, Polar Bear Cafe, Yumeiro Pâtissière, Gintama, Maoyū Maō Yūsha, Aoi Hana, and Nokto de la Galaksia Fervojo.

The End for Now